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EDITORIAL PAGE

PRESIDENT
DROUPADI
MURMU

LET'S HOLD OUR TEACHERS IN THE HIGHEST ESTEEM. THEY HELP INDIA LEARN AND LEAD
PAGE 12

Happening today

● **PRIME MINISTER** Narendra Modi will attend the centenary celebrations of Shri Ram College of Commerce in Delhi. He will also address the gathering.

● **INDIA WILL FACE** archivals Pakistan in a Group A clash at the Women's Asia Cup in Dubai.

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Air India fires pilot who failed dope test after it is flagged by accidents bureau

In initial report, AAIB also takes note of hydraulics failure on flight from Phuket to Delhi

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, September 4

HOURS AFTER the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB) flagged the positive drug test of the pilot-in-command of the Air India aircraft that suddenly lost altitude while flying from Phuket to Delhi on August 4, the airline Friday announced the termination of the pilot's employment with immediate effect.

An Air India spokesperson said, "Safety remains Air India's highest priority. The Pilot-in-Command of the Phuket-Delhi flight tested positive for a psychoactive substance. In line with Air India's zero-tolerance approach to violation of safety, fitness or regulatory requirements, the pilot's employment



The August 4 incident had left 20 passengers and four crew members injured. ANI

has been terminated with immediate effect."

Sources said the pilot-in-command had tested positive for marijuana.

On Friday morning, the AAIB released its preliminary report on the investigation into the August 4 incident involving Air India's Airbus A320 aircraft VT-EXO.

While the investigation remains underway and the preliminary report hasn't identified any definitive likely cause, it focussed on a sudden and brief triple hydraulic failure

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Rubio visit likely in Oct, Quad summit on G20 margins in US being explored

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, September 4

US SECRETARY of State Marco Rubio is likely to visit India in October, and officials are preparing for a possible summit of Quad leaders in December in the US, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

The Quad summit — the grouping comprises the US, India, Japan and Australia — is likely to take place on the sidelines of the summit of G20 leaders which, under the US presidency, will take place at the Trump National Doral Miami in Doral, Florida, on December 14-15.

Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri hosted a meeting of Quad Sherpas in New Delhi Thurs-



US Secy of State Marco Rubio

day. It was attended by Sergio Gor, Special Envoy to South and Central Asia and Ambassador of US to India; Elly Lawson, Deputy Secretary, Strategic Planning and Coordination Group, Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade, Australia; and, Hiroyuki Namazu, Senior

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ISRO's GSLV-F17 rocket carrying the EOS-05 satellite lifts off from Sriharikota, Andhra Pradesh, Friday. PTI

GSLV sheds 'naughty boy' tag with India's first geo-imaging satellite

Amitabh Sinha & Anonna Dutt
New Delhi, September 4

IN ITS first launch since January, the Indian Space Research Organisation sent an earth observation satellite, EOS-05, to space early Friday morning, using a GSLV rocket.

The EOS-05 is India's first dedicated imaging satellite to be placed in the geosynchronous orbit, about 36,000 km from Earth, from where it can keep constant watch over the

country and provide real-time imaging service.

With a 10-year mission life, the satellite is designed to image large areas of interest at frequent intervals for purposes such as monitoring natural disasters or keeping track of agriculture or forestry. It will also have defence uses.

India has several other active earth observation satellites in the lower-earth orbits which circle Earth and periodically capture imagery over India.

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E. EXPLAINED

ISRO success after string of setbacks

For ISRO, the successful launch comes after one of its most difficult phases in the last two years. Three of its six missions launched in 2025 and 2026 were unsuccessful, with the satellites unable to reach their intended orbits.

EXPRESS special

Bengal: Christian groups stop house prayers after attacks, govt points to 'forced conversions'

Ravik Bhattacharya & Sweety Kumari
Kolkata, September 4

IN SEVERAL districts of West Bengal, Christian groups have suspended house prayers and visits following a series of attacks on prayer meetings, including one in Uluberia in Howrah over a week ago, where police had to rescue the pastor and the congregation.

There have also been reports of disruption of a burial in Purba Bardhaman, and vandal-

Police rescue pastor, congregation from mob in Howrah; burial disrupted, body removed in Purba Bardhaman

ization of an under-construction church in Subhasgram in South 24 Parganas on July 5.

In a video that went viral, a mob entered a house in Uluberia on August 23 while Sunday prayers were on, and claiming "forced conversions", beat up the gathering and ransacked

the premises. Pastor Mithun Hazra told *The Indian Express* that like every Sunday, they had "rented a house for a prayer meeting, where around 60 people, men and women, were gathered". "Prayers started around 11 am. At around 3 pm, a mob chanting slogans barged

in. They assaulted me and others... ransacked the house, destroyed the sound system, podium, tables, chairs, and fans. They beat up men and women."

The pastor said police rescued them and took them to hospital. "After treatment, we went to the police station and filed a complaint. Since that day, we have not held house prayers in the area."

Superintendent of Police, Howrah Rural, Amit Verma

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EXPRESS Aqda

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'NETFLIX IS BOTH CLASSY AND MASSY'

TED SARANDOS
NETFLIX CO-CEO

THE BIG PICTURE

CHOCOLATE WITH CAPSICUM? DATA IS CHANGING THE FOOD WE EAT PAGE 10



National Security Advisor Ajit Doval and China Foreign Minister Wang Yi held boundary talks in Beijing on August 25. @EOIBEIJING

been held between the two sides in recent weeks to resolve issues.

Earlier this week, Army chief General Dhiraj Seth also visited the Spear Corps to "review the operational readiness of all formations and ongoing border development initiatives," the Army said in a post on X, adding that he was briefed on all aspects of capability development and initiatives taken to further strengthen combat capability.

On August 25, National Security Advisor Ajit Doval and Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi, who are the special repre-

sentatives for the boundary talks, met in Beijing.

A day later, it was announced that India and China had decided to advance discussions on "an early and substantial harvest" of boundary delimitation and border management, and agreed on two new border military hotlines in the eastern and middle sectors, two new meeting points for military commander-level meetings, and on holding the trans-border river meeting in September.

The two military hotlines in

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



CJP's Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka with Azad Samaj Party (Kanshi Ram) MP Chandra Shekhar in New Delhi, Friday. PRAVEEN KHANNA

JANTAR MANTAR PROTESTS

After CJP dharna, man who 'attacked' father of protester detained

Pragynesh
New Delhi, September 4

SWATANTRA BHARDWAJ, the self-styled "influencer" who purportedly admitted to having attacked the father of a young Jantar Mantar protester in July, was detained by police on Friday evening, about six hours after the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), Indian Youth Congress, and Lok Sabha MPs Chandra Shekhar and Rajesh Ranjan protested at Parliament Street police station in New Delhi.

Police officers said Bhardwaj was picked up in Bulandshahr

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Business as Usual

By EP UNNY



● 503 INDIAN ATHLETES ALONG WITH 256 SUPPORT STAFF AND OFFICIALS TO TRAVEL TO AICHI-NAGOYA THIS MONTH

Container rooms to sushi: Indian athletes prepare for Asian Games — and Japan

Nitin Sharma & Pritish Raj
Patiala, Bengaluru, September 4

NOT ALL surprises are pleasant. And Indian athletes are doing all they can to avoid one when they land in Japan for the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games starting September 19.

Since last week, the athletes at the Sports Authority of India training centres in Patiala (Punjab) and Bengaluru have been spending time in 40-by-8-foot shipping containers, refurbished to include beds, air conditioners, a pantry, and a washroom. Food served at the canteen includes sushi,

many varieties of it.

They are being familiarised with the conditions in Nagoya, where the organisers have decided not to build an 'athletes village', a residential complex usually set up during major events, including the previous versions of the Asian Games. To keep costs low, organisers have instead offered the 17,000-odd athletes three accommodation options: a cruise ship, hotel rooms, and containers.

Of these, 503 athletes and 256 support staff and officials will be from India. Aiming to better India's record of 107 medals, including 28 gold, in

Hangzhou, China, in 2023, no effort is being spared to eliminate a curveball, particularly when it comes to stay and food.

The National Institute of Sports (NIS) in Patiala has modified two containers, which it had procured during the Covid pandemic to store equipment, into two-room spaces for the athletes. So has the SAI Bengaluru centre, which bought two containers last year.

"Nine players have stayed in these containers so far. According to the roster, more players will spend time in containers. During Covid, the two containers were used for storing athletics and weightlifting equipment in Patiala. We took



the decision to convert these two containers to accommodation facilities, similar to what athletes will get in Japan," said

Vineet Kumar, Senior Executive Director and Deputy Director General of NIS.

Among those who got first-



(Left) Shot-putter Tajinder Pal Singh Toor outside a container at NIS, Patiala. HARMEET SODHI; (Above) Sushi on the menu at SAI centre in Bengaluru

hand experience of living in a container is Glasgow Commonwealth Games bronze medalist Seema Kaliraman. Discuss

throwers like her, she said, "need more space to sleep, but the container has constraints."

"I could not sleep well on the first night. Then I got accustomed to it. I thought the Asian Games were such a big event and there would be an athletes' village. But we have to adjust. Our main focus is to win medals," Seema said.

Two-time Asian Games champion and defending champion shot-putter Tajinder Pal Singh Toor, who is six feet and four inches tall and just about fits on a standard-sized bed, said the container reminded him of his hostel days.

"As a young athlete, I would stay with four or five other shot-

putters in one room, sleeping on mattresses in Punjabi University, Patiala. We did this to save money. The space in the containers reminded me of those days. For a tall and well-built athlete like me, space can be a problem. We have the training gear too. But preparing the mind ahead for such challenges helps any sports person, and that's what we are doing by getting accustomed to sleeping in containers here at NIS," he said.

At the SAI centre in Bengaluru, sushi varieties such as chicken tempura uramaki, salmon nigiri Avocado and cucumber uramaki are now a staple on the canteen menu

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Goa Chief Minister Pramod Sawant, MoS Shripad Naik and other dignitaries perform rituals to mark the launch of the Koti Tirth Corridor Development Project in the state. PTI

Had Portuguese not come to Goa, we would have temples similar to South India: Sawant

Pavneet Singh Chadha
Panaji, September 4

UNDERLINING THE need to “remember our history”, Goa Chief Minister Pramod Sawant said Friday the state witnessed a “golden era” during the Kadamba dynasty. If the Portuguese had not come to Goa, the state would have many temples similar to those in South India, he said.

At Divar, where he performed ‘Udakshanti and Gangujan’ to mark the commencement of the ‘Koti Tirth Corridor Development Project’, Sawant said many temples were later destroyed during Portuguese rule.

“Goa was ruled by several kingdoms. The golden period for the state was between the 10th and 14th centuries during the rule of the Kadamba dynasty... If we say that the Portuguese destroyed a thousand temples, then who is it who built these temples? It is the people of Goa during the rule of the Kadamba kings. That was the true golden period. Remember your history,” Sawant said. “If the Portuguese had not come here, we would have had a chance to witness temples in Goa... even better than those seen in South India. Unfortunately, it was the Portuguese, who succeeded Adil Shah, and

Yasin Malik denies involvement in Sarla Bhat killing: ‘Got to know months later’

Express News Service
Srinagar, September 4

JKLF CHIEF Yasin Malik has denied involvement in the killing of Sarla Bhat, claiming that he got to know of the murder of the Kashmiri Pandit nurse only in February 1991 – months after her death in April 1990.

This comes over two months after the State Investigation Agency (SIA) filed a 737-page chargesheet in a special NIA court in Srinagar in June, naming Malik as a key accused in Bhat’s abduction and killing.

With regard to the SIA stating in its chargesheet that Bhat was killed on the Jammu Kashmir Liberation Front’s (JKLF) assumption that she was passing along information to the security forces, Malik, in an affidavit recently filed before the Additional Sessions Judge (TADA/POTA) Court in Srinagar, said, “The very framing of this question is deeply offensive to the memory of the deceased.”

“Despite the mass migration of Kashmiri Pandits that commenced on 19 January 1990, Ms. Sarla Bhat and her family chose to remain in the Valley alongside their Kashmiri Muslim neighbours despite the prevailing uncertainty and danger,” he said in the affidavit. It is, therefore, he said, “both unjust and insensitive to attribute such a baseless motive without any credible evidence whatsoever.” He said that in June, officers of the SIA visited him in Tihar jail, where he remains lodged since 2019, and questioned him on his alleged involvement in Bhat’s murder.

In the 25-page affidavit, Malik stated that on that day in April, 1990, he along with Showkat Bakshi, Javed Zargar, and Iqbal Gandroo, reached a house at Hafiz Bazaz. “Within approximately 20 minutes, the premises were raided by the Border Security Force (BSF).” In an attempt to escape, he jumped from the fifth floor of



JKLF chief Yasin Malik

the building, sustaining grievous injuries, he said. “I began bleeding profusely and soon lost consciousness. My associates were apprehended during the raid,” he added.

After this, Malik said he was in a coma for many days and his whereabouts were not known to his organisation. He said that in subsequent years, the government of India initiated a dialogue process with him. He said Special Director, Intelligence Bureau (IB), Ajit Kumar Doval met him and arranged for him to meet then National Security Advisor Brajesh Mishra.

“Historical record demonstrates that I had sustained life-threatening injuries on 8 April 1990, remained in a coma, and was widely reported to have died. Indeed, I was declared dead on two occasions ... It is therefore incomprehensible how a person who was unconscious, fighting for his own survival ... could have participated in, directed or orchestrated the commission of the offence alleged by the prosecution,” he said in the affidavit. Malik wrote that he first came to know of Bhat’s murder in February 1991.

Towards the end of his affidavit, Malik stated: “I wish to clarify that I have no complaint against this Hon’ble court or the prosecuting agencies. I respectfully state that, in my understanding, the present proceedings have arisen out of political circumstances and decisions and, I believe, I have been falsely implicated in the present case.”

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India-China Corps Commanders’ meet

the eastern and middle sectors are likely to be at the Army command headquarters in Lucknow and Kolkata.

A Border Personnel Meeting (BPM) point will also be established in Joshimath in Uttarakhand for senior commander-level talks. Such meeting points already exist in Tawang in Arunachal Pradesh and Chushul in Ladakh.

Chinese President Xi Jinping

is expected to attend the BRICS summit in New Delhi on September 12-13.

New Delhi and Beijing have been trying to restore ties that plummeted after the start of the military standoff along the LAC in eastern Ladakh in 2020.

Xi last visited India in October 2019 when he travelled to Mamallapuram near Chennai for the second informal bilateral summit of leaders.

Air India fires pilot

and the pilot-in-command’s positive drug test report.

The AAIB also issued a recommendation to regulator Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) to take actions deemed fit to prevent abuse of psychoactive substances.

Neither the airline nor the AAIB identified the pilot-in-command. According to the AAIB’s preliminary report, the pilot-in-command had over 5,000 hours of total flying experience, all of it on the A320 aircraft type.

“Detailed investigation regarding technical and other aspects are underway. In this case, it has been observed that the PIC was found non-negative for psycho-active substance in the confirmatory test. The confirmation of use of psycho-active substance is a serious concern and AAIB recommends appropriate actions by DGCA on priority. The preliminary report is published as per ICAO (International Civil Aviation Organization) guidelines. The investigation is under progress. The final report will be published in due course,” the preliminary report said.

But it did not say whether or not the purported use of drugs by the pilot-in-command was directly linked to the incident.

The DGCA is already in the process of holding stakeholder consultations to expand the scope of random testing of pilots for drug abuse. The Ministry of Civil Aviation has mooted a once-a-year random drug test of all pilots, up from the current norm of 10% pilots being tested per year, according to Civil Aviation Minister K Ram Mohan Naidu.

On August 14, The Indian Express had reported that an initial assessment of the digital flight data recorder (DFDR) data by Airbus had indicated that the aircraft experienced a temporary loss of all three hydraulic systems, which led to loss of key aircraft control surfaces for a few seconds.

The AAIB preliminary report has not identified any underlying cause for the rarest-of-rare triple hydraulic failure, and clarity on this count is now expected only when the final investigation report is released.

A key question in the investigation will be whether the hydraulic systems actually failed – and if yes, why – or was it a case of spurious signals. Airbus and French aircraft accident investigation body BEA are assisting the AAIB probe.

On August 4, the aircraft encountered a sudden altitude drop at cruising altitude over Odisha, resulting in injuries to 20 passengers and four cabin crew members. The aircraft had 137 passengers, six cabin crew members, and two pilots on board. The incident also damaged the aircraft cabin including ceiling panels, overhead bins, and handrails, among others.

According to the preliminary report, some hydraulic components and samples of VT-

EXO have been collected for further analysis following the aircraft’s inspection by Airbus technical experts.

Its maintenance records have also been collected by the AAIB from Air India for further scrutiny, and investigators also have the data from the plane’s DFDR and cockpit voice recorder. Other pieces of evidence and records collected from the airline, airport authorities, and ATC are also being evaluated.

The Airbus A320 aircraft has three independent hydraulic systems – coded green, blue, and yellow – built as a redundancy so that the loss of one such system doesn’t result in total loss of hydraulic control.

According to the preliminary report, the incident occurred while the aircraft was cruising at 36,000 feet at 09:32:43 am India time, when the aircraft’s flight control system detected loss of green hydraulic system. About four seconds later, loss of blue and yellow hydraulic systems were detected, followed by the autopilot getting disengaged. Shortly thereafter, the stall warning triggered for two seconds. “The Co-Pilot, who was the Pilot Flying (PF) responded and tried to control the prevailing situation. Subsequently, PIC took over the controls. Meanwhile, the aircraft encountered altitude upset. Initially, it gained 372 ft and fell by 292 ft from its assigned FL360 during the event,” it stated.

“At around 04:02:52 UTC (09:32:52 India time), the Blue hydraulic system was recovered, and a few seconds later, the Yellow hydraulic and the Green hydraulic systems were also recovered. Consequently, this led to the recovery of the Flight control (F/CTL) surfaces. Subsequently, the aircraft operation returned to its normal operating condition,” it stated.

The AAIB noted that since seatbelt signs were off at the time of the incident, some passengers and cabin crew members were injured. “Flight crew assessed the cabin situation and took the decision of continuing the flight to its planned destination i.e. Delhi airport and did not divert to the nearest enroute airport. Later, the flight crew contacted ATC Delhi and sought medical priority. ATC responded accordingly and provided requisite assistance. At 05:30 UTC aircraft landed safely on runway 11 L at IGI airport, Delhi,” the report stated.

Following the release of the preliminary report, Air India said it continued to extend full cooperation to the investigation, including providing access to all relevant operational, maintenance and technical records.

An Airbus spokesperson said, “In accordance with ICAO Annex 13, Airbus continues to provide full technical assistance to the relevant investigating authorities. We are actively supporting the airline and we will provide further information as it becomes available.”

Influencer detained

in western UP, not far from his home, and was being brought to Delhi. Earlier in the day, police had assured the father of the young protester that they would detain Bhardwaj within 24 hours.

In the evening, news agency ANI posted a video of an unidentified “friend” of Bhardwaj saying in Bulandshahr that officers of the “Crime Branch from Delhi” had taken away the influencer around 2 pm.

Bhardwaj had arrived in Bulandshahr around 7 in the morning, the person in the ANI video claimed.

On Friday morning, members of the CJP led by its spokesperson Saurav Das and co-convenor Ashutosh Ranka

marched to Parliament Street police station to demand the arrest of Bhardwaj.

Around noon, when the CJP leaders, along with the protester and her father, were negotiating with police, Nagina MP and leader of the Azad Samaj Party (Kanshi Ram) Chandar Shekhar arrived at the police station.

As the crowd of protesters swelled, police erected two layers of barricades to keep them from entering the premises. The protesters sat outside the gates of the police station, raising slogans.

They were later joined by the Independent MP from Purnia, Rajesh Ranjan alias Pappu Yadav, and Akshay Lakra, president of the Delhi Pradesh Youth

GSLV

In the geosynchronous orbit, the satellite remains stationary relative to Earth, and is able to watch the same region continuously, without gaps.

The GSLV-F17 rocket deposited the EOS-05 satellite in a transfer orbit, at an altitude of more than 190 km from Earth, about 18 minutes after the launch. From there, the satellite will perform a series of orbit-raising manoeuvres over the next few days to travel to the geosynchronous orbit, its final destination.

In a message congratulating ISRO, Prime Minister Narendra

Modi said, “Yet another outstanding achievement by ISRO and a proud moment for our nation. The successful launch of GSLV-F17 carrying EOS-05, India’s first-ever imaging satellite from geosynchronous orbit is a reflection of the excellence, innovation and growing capabilities that define India’s space sector. The growing partnership between ISRO and Indian industry is adding new strength and scale to our space

programme and expanding India’s capabilities across the entire space ecosystem.”

Weighing more than 2,360-kg, the EOS-05 was the heaviest satellite to be carried by the GSLV rocket until now.

The successful launch is a big relief for ISRO which has gone through one of its most difficult phases in the last two years. Three of the six missions launched in 2025 and 2026 turned out to be unsuccessful with the satellites unable to reach their intended orbits due to anomalies in the launch vehicle or the spacecraft engine. Because of this, subsequent missions went through extended reviews and checks to avoid another failure.

The launch that took place Friday was ready in February itself, but had been put on hold to enable additional rounds of checks and tests. The GSLV rocket has had its own share of problems in the past, mainly with the cryogenic engine that powers the third and final stage of the flight.

It had suffered four failures and was called ‘naughty boy’ because of the difficulties it posed to scientists in mastering

the cryogenic technology. But that description no longer holds valid. After a successful launch in 2024, ISRO scientists, including the then chairman Somanath, had said ‘naughty boy’ had become ‘disciplined’ and a ‘smart boy’.

After the satellite was deposited in orbit Friday, ISRO chairman V Narayanan said, “This is a great achievement in our country’s space programme, because this is the first earth observation satellite to be placed in geo-platform for national activities. This success is the culmination of team work of ISRO, its industrial partners and also the academia which has provided a lot of support.”

“Also, this success is because of the open work culture and vibrant review mechanism of ISRO,” he said. “All the satellite systems are working fine and are normal. The solar panel has been deployed. The health of the satellite is perfectly alright. In the coming days we will raise the orbit of the satellite and place it in the geosynchronous orbit,” Narayanan said.

Lt General A K Bhatt (retd), Director General of Indian

Space Association, an industry body, said, “The geosynchronous imaging capabilities of EOS-05 satellite will enable persistent, high-frequency observation of large regions rather than relying only on periodic satellite revisits, which is increasingly critical for India. This can be strategically valuable for tracking rapidly evolving weather systems, floods and forest fires, monitoring agriculture and natural resources, and strengthening situational awareness across India’s land and maritime domains. The real opportunities now lies in translating this rich, frequent satellite data into actionable intelligence through India’s private space and geospatial ecosystem.”

“This mission also reaffirms the deepening partnership between ISRO and India’s private space industry, whose components and expertise increasingly power such national systems. As India’s ecosystem matures under robust policy frameworks and with support from ISRO, milestones like this will build the confidence needed to scale commercial participation further,” he said.

Rubio visit likely in Oct

Deputy Minister for Foreign Affairs, Japan.

A statement issued by the Ministry of External Affairs and US State Department said, “The Quad Sherpas’ Meeting follows the Quad Foreign Ministers’ Meeting held in New Delhi on 26th May 2026 and was convened to take forward its outcomes and to prepare for the next Quad Foreign Ministers’ Meeting.”

It said the Sherpas reviewed progress across ongoing Quad initiatives and discussed ways to further strengthen practical co-

operation, with a shared commitment to advancing a free and open Indo-Pacific.

“Discussions covered key areas of Quad cooperation, including maritime and transnational security; economic prosperity and security; critical and emerging technologies; and humanitarian assistance and emergency response. The Sherpas also exchanged views on developments in the Indo-Pacific and the broader regional and global context,” it said.

The Quad Sherpas, the statement said, reaffirmed the impor-

ance of focusing on concrete, action-oriented initiatives. They looked forward to continued consultations in the lead-up to the next Quad Foreign Ministers’ Meeting, it stated.

Ambassador Gor, in a post on X, said, “The Quad is moving forward with clear purpose.” He said that he joined other Quad Sherpas to set an action plan for concrete deliverables — advancing President Trump and Secretary Rubio’s commitment to a strong, results-oriented Quad.

“Proud to take up the mantle of Quad Sherpa and to help turn that vision into action,” he said.

India was supposed to host the Quad summit last year, but its ties with the US were strained

after Trump’s claims of mediation between India and Pakistan post Operation Sindoor and Washington’s decision to impose heavy tariffs on Delhi. The two countries are currently firming up a bilateral trade deal.

While efforts are being made by both India and the US to repair ties — Rubio visited India in May this year for the meeting of Quad Foreign Ministers — it looks unlikely that the US President will be travelling to India this year.

Rubio’s next India visit will be an attempt to schedule a Quad summit in the US because Prime Minister Narendra Modi is likely to attend the G20 summit.

Christian groups

confirmed receiving a complaint. “An FIR has been registered. Investigation is on.” No arrests have been made in the case.

Herod Mullick, founder of the Bangiya Christiya Parishba (Bengal Christian Council), said what happened at Uluberia was “not a stray incident”. “There have been a series of such attacks recently... We are providing legal help to the victims, who are scared,” Mullick said, adding that last Sunday (August 30) too, incidents were reported during house prayers, at Jagatballavpur in Howrah and Hingalganj in North 24 Parganas.

On August 14, there was an attack at a gathering at the St Clare’s Church in Sahanagar, Purba Bardhaman district, with a funeral disrupted and mourners allegedly assaulted.

Parish Priest-In-Charge Father Samuel Hembrom told The Indian Express that the mob demanded “to see the papers for the burial ground”. “We said give us some time to get them from the church... we protested. But they did not allow the burial. The body had

already been lowered into the grave, the mob took it out. The body had to be taken to another cemetery in Bardhaman town,” said Hembrom.

The Father said he sent a complaint to the Superintendent of Police and Block Development Officer by email. “No thing happened.”

The SP, Purba Bardhaman, Pushpa, told The Indian Express: “The woman who died did not belong to the area. So people here objected and tried to prevent the burial. Locals also claimed the land where the burial was happening was not a cemetery but private land. We are checking the land records.”

On mourners being roughed up, the officer said: “I don’t think there was an assault. However, I will check with the local police station. There was a law and order problem and police priority was to control that.”

On August 25, an attack was reported on a prayer meeting at a house in Ghusuri in Howrah. Father Suraj Saroj of Church of the Grace said: “Community members were beaten up and some people were injured. I

tried to reason with the mob, but they refused to understand.”

Saroj alleged that police made them wait for hours at the station, and then “enquired about the church, funds and credentials”. “We did not file a complaint. We have decided to suspend all house prayers, visits.”

Police refused to comment on the matter.

On August 26, a group gathered for a prayer meeting at a house in Check Milepost village in Purba Medinipur allegedly saw a similar incident, with the pastor and his wife beaten up and taken to the local police station.

“They were chanting slogans and said we were forcefully converting people... Our community members called up our lawyers, who came to the police station and had us released. Out of fear, we did not file a complaint,” Pastor Joy Sutradhar said over the phone. Later, Herod Mullick said, they filed a police complaint through email.

SP, Purba Medinipur, Angshuman Saha did not respond to calls.

Debdutta Majhi, the president of the Hindu right-wing Singha Bahini, one of the

groups blamed for the attacks, said: “In Uluberia and other places, forced conversions with the lure of money are rampant. We are protesting against this. It cannot be allowed to continue.”

Kshudiram Tudu, the West Bengal Minister for Tribal Development and Minority Affairs, told The Indian Express: “Praying is a religious choice, and our government doesn’t believe in disturbing anyone’s personal beliefs. But if forced conversions – not those by choice – are happening, then law will take its course. One has the right to file a complaint.”

CPI(M) state secretary Md Selim said: “In other BJP-ruled states too, such things have happened. It is the right of the people to practise their religion, and we will fight to ensure this in Bengal.”

TMC spokesperson Praadepta Mukherjee accused the BJP of doing “politics of fear”. “It has now become part of their job, to dub Muslims as foreigners and attack houses of Christian community members.”

BJP Rajya Sabha MP Rahul Sinha said, “I would not like to comment on this... I am not aware of any such incidents.”

Asian Games in Japan

prepared by chef Jeyaraj in consultation with the athletes and the nutritionist.

The centre’s Regional Director, Vishnu Sudhakaran, said: “We decided to come up with the Japanese menu in January. But once the squad list was announced in July, we launched it completely. The idea is that our athletes don’t get surprised when they see

food in Japan.”

Pole Vault national record holder Sindhusree G, who will be going to Japan for the first time, said she adjusted to the Japanese food after the first few days.

“For two to three days, the food didn’t suit my palate, but eventually I got used to it. It is important for us to know what we will get once we reach

Japan,” she said.

Jeyaraj’s team is also preparing energy bars for the athletes. “The athletics team, especially our race walkers, asked for the energy bars, which help them in healthy snacking. These bars also contain chia and flax seeds,” Jeyraj said.

Before the shipping containers were refurbished into living spaces to acclimatise the athletes, SAI officials travelled to Japan for a recce.

India’s deputy chef de mission and two-time Asian

Games medallist in table tennis, Sharath Kamal, said talks were still on with the organising committee to ensure Indian athletes were comfortable not only with accommodation but also with the food.

“We are in touch with the organisers with regard to the menu at the dining hall. We are trying to put in place a team that can co-ordinate with the athletes and take care of their requirements,” Kamal said.

With inputs from MHIH VASA VDA

In the video, Bhardwaj is purportedly seen and heard claiming that despite having attacked the father of a CJP protester, he had managed to stay out of jail due to the intervention of a politician.

He also purportedly boasts in the video that the person he had attacked had to be given 60 stitches and was on the verge of death – and that a case under Section 307 of the IPC, which relates to attempt to murder, should have been registered against him.

Bhardwaj purportedly says that another accused in the case was released from jail the following day, and that he never had to face the law, allegedly because police received a call from the Delhi-based politician who was like his “elder brother”.

In Patna, Union Minister and Lok Janshakti Party (Ram

hind these online rape threats. (The protester’s name is being withheld because she is a minor, and a case has been registered under the POCSO Act.)

Bhardwaj, who describes himself as a “Kattar Hindu”, purportedly claimed in a widely circulated video podcast that he had cracked the skull of a protester at Jantar Mantar. He was referring to a scuffle in which the girl’s father, a resident of Ghaziabad, sustained a head injury.

The father told reporters outside the police station on Friday that “They (police) have assured us that they will arrest him (Bhardwaj).”

The protester said: “I have not gone to school for weeks. I felt like everyone was judging me. I have also given the police a complaint regarding rape threats to me.”

Vilas) leader Chirag Paswan, one of the politicians whom Bhardwaj had named, said that his name had been “misused”, and called for action against the influencer.

“It is an extremely serious matter that a person (Bhardwaj) is openly admitting that he assaulted someone so badly that the person could have died, and is admitting this openly on a podcast. If there is no action against him even after this, I believe it will set a very wrong example...,” Paswan said.

The Minister said that those in public life meet a range of people. “But that does not mean that the person personally knows that politician,” he said.

It was “absolutely wrong” to suggest that he knew Bhardwaj, Paswan said, adding that his party stood firmly with the young protester and her father.

NOIDA PROTEST
Ex-journalist
booked under
NSA plans to
move HC after
co-accused
gets relief
Drishti Jain
Noida, September 4

SATYAM VERMA, a former journalist from Lucknow, booked under the National Security Act (NSA) after violence broke out at the labourers’ protest in April in Noida, has moved the Supreme Court to withdraw his plea challenging his detention under the stringent Act. Verma’s counsel confirmed that the latest appeal was mentioned orally before the court on Thursday, and that the matter is listed to be heard on Monday.

The 60-year-old then plans to move the Allahabad High Court.

His application in the Supreme Court came a day after the Allahabad High Court quashed the detention of another accused, Akriti Chaudhary, under NSA, describing the invocation of the Act as “arbitrary and vague.”

A bench of Justices Atul Streedharan and Achal Sachdev dictated the order in court. However, a fine print of the order is awaited.

A total of eleven FIRs were filed against Verma following the protest in Noida. He was booked under the NSA on May 13 after the police alleged that Verma masterminded the protests “because he was a member of Revolutionary Workers Party of India (RWPI)”, he did “pseudo writing that incites the new generation to enter into rebel organisation as a cadre”; and was the “publisher and writer of Mazdoor Bigul newspaper”.

“It is because of the ‘disgusting ideology of the illogical and stubborn violent *andolan*’ jeevi persons like you who with their extreme activeness’ are the decisive planners of such circumstances creating public unrest,” the police report claimed.

His friend, Katvayani (67), earlier told *The Indian Express* that he was picked up from his residence.

At Ridge, contempt of court claims ‘pause’ removal of invasive trees

Sept 30 deadline to plant 14L plants hit, say officials

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, September 4

FRESHLY CUT trunks, piles of branches and stretches of vegetation removed: the forest behind Buddha Jayanti Park near Dhaula Kuan in South Delhi bears signs of recent clearing. Even as the Delhi government’s Forest department initiated the clearing to remove invasive vilayati keekar to make way for indigenous plantation under a Centre-approved Delhi Eco-restoration Plan 2026-30, the work in the Central Ridge — hailed as the Capital’s green lungs — has been paused after the High Court on September 1 sought the department’s response to allegations of violations of its earlier directions, officials have told *The Indian Express*.

In the petition submitted in the High Court, questions were raised on the approach followed by the Forest department to remove the invasive species. While the work is said to have been paused, the controversy is still brewing with claims being made about machines operating inside the forest area. In response, officials said tyre marks visible in geotagged photographs from September 3 are of water tankers used for maintenance work, adding that there has been no new activity.

Court scrutiny

The HC order on September 1 came on a contempt petition filed by activist Lt Col (Retd) Sarvadhan Singh Oberoi, Managing Trustee of the Aravalli Bachao Citizens Movement, against senior Forest department officials, alleging disobedience of earlier court directions relating to the protection of the ecologically sensitive Central Ridge. Questions were raised on the manner in which



Pile of log of wood at Ridge.

invasive vegetation is being removed, as well as the timing.

Under the restoration plan, the government has envisaged planting more than one crore plants over four years. For the current plantation season, officials said the target is set 14 lakh plants, with September 30 set as the deadline. The monsoon window is important because planting before the dry months gives young plants better access to soil moisture, according to the department.

Officials have said that work and timeline has been affected

amid the contempt proceedings. The matter is listed next for September 24.

What High Court said earlier

On August 28, 2023, the HC recorded assurances that no construction of any kind of trail or park would be undertaken through the Central Ridge and there would be no clearing of land by felling trees without its permission. In another order, on September 4 the same year, the High Court said the Central Ridge should be preserved in its natural form and directed against concretisation and construction, observing that the Ridge could not be reduced to a park. On May 6, 2024, the court, while noting concerns over illegal felling and degradation, directed that there be no further felling of trees or removal of shrubs without its permission.

The allegations in the latest petition relate to observations

made by Oberoi during visits to Central Ridge in June and July. He claimed he found felled trees, pileup of logs, use of heavy machinery, and that some trees were burnt or ring-barked and large pits were dug up. The petitioner cited photographs taken on July 16 from an area behind Buddha Jayanti Park, which allegedly showed a bulldozer and extensive clearing.

The Forest department has, meanwhile, maintained that the activity now under scrutiny was not conventional clearing for construction or the creation of a park. Officials said the department has received approval this year from the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change for an eco-restoration plan based on the 10-year working plan prepared by the Forest Research Institute, Dehradun. The plan involves removing invasive Prosopis juliflora, commonly known as vilayati keekar, from identified areas and subsequently planting indigenous species suited to the Aravalli landscape. Officials said the work is being undertaken in phases and that the restoration approach varies according to the condition of individual patches. The plan does not involve concretisation inside the forest, they said

Why the removal?

At the heart of the dispute is the question about how restoration can be carried out in a protected forest without running afoul of the court orders. One reason for the focus on vilayati keekar is its ability to regenerate rapidly and dominate areas where native vegetation has been degraded.

The department’s earlier approach in some areas involved pruning the canopy of vilayati keekar. But officials said this alone has not been sufficient because the tree can regenerate after its branches are cut. The more intensive treatment proposed for heavily invaded patches involves removing the plant along with its root stock. The aim is to reduce repeated regeneration.



Security personnel outside Parliament Street police station where protesters (below) gathered on Friday. PRAVEEN KHANNA

Two MPs and a Cong leader join CJP at Parliament St station; police change FIR

Praghnesh
New Delhi, September 4

AROUND 10.30 AM on Friday, a large number of media cameras and mics could be seen at the entrance to Parliament Street police station.

It was a familiar sight at the station, a white colonial building, which also houses the office of the Deputy Commissioner of Police, New Delhi. In July, there were the protests by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), and then there was Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi’s sit-in for a pellet gun victim.

Friday’s protest was going to be for the father of a 14-year-old student protester, who was allegedly beaten by a self-professed influencer called Swatantra Bhardwaj and his men during the CJP protest at Jantar Mantar.

The CJP demanded that the FIR against Bhardwaj should include sections of the law relating to ‘attempt to murder’ and provisions of the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, 1989 (SC/ST Act).

The alleged attack on the father of the minor protester took place on July 23, at the height of the CJP protests at Jantar Mantar, when he was making a video at the site.

“Suddenly, 10-15 people came from behind. One of them was Swatantra Bhardwaj, whom I recognised from social media videos. They started beating him (the protester’s father).



There were serious injuries to his head,” said Feroz Gama, a lawyer who claimed he had witnessed the alleged attack.

Gama, who was at Parliament Street police station on Friday, claimed that he had taken the injured man to hospital, where he got dozens of stitches in his head.

“We also took him to the police station where an FIR was registered, but we didn’t get a copy of the document,” Gama claimed.

The CJP called for a protest after Bhardwaj was recently heard in a video purportedly boasting about beating the protester’s father to the brink of death, and getting away scot-free because of his purported political connections.

CJP leaders Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka entered the police station around 11 am. Around half an hour later, In-

dian Youth Congress leader Akshay Lakra showed up along with the student protester and her father. IYC and CJP supporters sat down behind the barricades erected outside the police station gate and raised slogans demanding justice.

After another 30 minutes, Lok Sabha MP and Dalit leader Chandra Shekhar, better known as ‘Azad’, arrived to roars of “Jai Bhim”, and went inside the police station.

“We went to the police station because we believe in the Constitution. But if the administration breaks our trust, we won’t stay quiet,” Azad told reporters later.

Around 12.30 pm, Rajesh Ranjan alias Pappu Yadav, the Independent MP from Purnia, arrived and sat with the protesters outside the police station.

“Will there be atrocities against our daughters? Will there be atrocities against Dalits? This person is openly saying the minister is his ‘brother’!” Pappu Yadav said, holding a copy of the Constitution.

By 2 pm, the student protester and her father had emerged from the police station. The police confirmed that the SC/ST Act had been added to the FIR against Bhardwaj. Late evening, they said that based on a complaint by the teenage girl alleging she had been threatened with rape, a case under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act, 2012 (POCSO Act) had been registered as well

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NOTICE OF THIRTY-EIGHTH ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING, REMOTE E-VOTING INFORMATION AND BOOK CLOSURE / RECORD DATE

1) Notice is hereby given that in accordance with the applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 read with General Circulars issued in this regard by Ministry of Corporate Affairs and other applicable circulars issued by the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI), the Thirty Eighth (38th) Annual General Meeting (AGM) of the members of the Company will be held on **Monday, 28.09.2026 at 15:00 Hrs.** to transact the businesses set forth in the Notice of the said meeting through Video Conference/ Other Audio Visual Means (VC/OAVM), without physical presence of members at the venue.

2) In compliance with the relevant circulars, the notice of the 38th AGM, along with explanatory statement and the Annual Report for the year ended 31.03.2026, has been dispatched in electronic mode to the members as at the close of 28.08.2026, whose e-mail IDs were registered with the Company or Depository Participant(s) and for others, a letter containing requisite details, has been sent. The notice of AGM and Annual Report are available on the Company’s website www.concorindia.co.in and on the website of Stock Exchanges (www.nseindia.com and www.bseindia.com).

3) Shareholders will have an opportunity to join and participate in the 38th AGM through VC/ OAVM facility only and cast their vote on the items of business as set forth in the Notice of the AGM through remote e-voting prior to the AGM and through electronic voting system during the AGM. The detailed instructions for participation in the AGM, remote e-voting for shareholders holding shares in dematerialized mode, physical mode and for those shareholders whose e-mail IDs are not registered, have been provided in the notice of AGM.

4) Pursuant to the provisions of Section 108 of the Companies Act, 2013 read with Rule 20 of the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014 and Regulation 44 of SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, the Company is providing its members the facility to cast their votes electronically on all the resolutions set out in the Notice of AGM from a remote location (“**Remote e-voting**”) through National Securities Depository Limited (NSDL). The business of AGM may therefore be transacted through e-Voting services of NSDL and the members holding shares either in physical form or dematerialized form may cast their vote electronically. All the members are hereby informed that:

- The business set forth in the Notice of the 38th AGM may be transacted through voting by electronic means;
- The remote e-voting shall commence on Thursday, 24.09.2026 at 09:00 Hrs.;
- The remote e-voting shall end on Sunday, 27.09.2026 at 17:00 Hrs.;
- The cut-off date for determining the eligibility for remote e-voting or at the AGM is Monday, 21.09.2026. Any person, who acquires shares of the Company and becomes a member of the Company after dispatch of the Notice and holding shares as on the cut-off date i.e. 21.09.2026 may obtain login ID and password by sending a request at evoting@nsdl.com or concor@beetafinancial.com. However, if a person is already registered with NSDL for remote e-voting, then the existing user ID and password can be used for casting vote;
- Members eligible to vote may note that:
 - The remote e-voting module shall be disabled by NSDL beyond 17:00 Hrs. on 27.09.2026 and once the vote on a resolution is cast by the member, the member shall not be allowed to change it subsequently;
 - The facility for voting through electronic voting system will be made available at the AGM;
 - The members who have cast their votes by remote e-voting prior to the AGM may also attend the AGM but shall not be entitled to cast their votes again; and
 - A person whose name is recorded in the register of members or in the register of beneficial owners maintained by the depositories as on the cut-off date only shall be entitled to avail the facility of remote e-voting or voting at the AGM.
- In case of any queries, members may refer to the Frequently Asked Questions (“FAQs”) and e-voting manual available at www.evoting.nsdl.com under help section or may contact Ms. Pallavi Mhatre (Deputy Vice President), NSDL, 4th Floor, ‘A’ Wing, Trade World, Kamala Mills Compound, Senapati Bapat Marg, Lower Parel, Mumbai – 400013. Email: evoting@nsdl.com, Tel: 022-48867000.

5) Shareholders holding shares in physical mode and who have not updated their e-mail IDs, mobile numbers or bank details (for receiving electronic payments of dividend, as & when declared by the Company) are requested to update the same by sending an e-mail at concor@beetafinancial.com with copy marked to investorrelations@concorindia.com along with a signed request letter mentioning Folio No., Name of shareholder(s), address, bank details, scanned copy of shares certificate (front & back), self-attested scanned copy of PAN card, cancelled cheque, address proof (Aadhaar Card/ Driving License/ Passport) etc. In case, if the folio is KYC non-compliant in respect of physical shares, the payment of dividend or any other entitlements for same shall be processed only after receipt of all the required details.

Shareholders holding shares in dematerialized mode, are requested to register their e-mail addresses, mobile numbers and bank details (for receiving electronic payments of dividend, as & when declared by the Company) with their Depository Participants.

6) The dividend which remains unpaid/unclaimed for seven years is liable to be Transferred to IEPF. Also the shares on which dividend had remained unpaid/ unclaimed for a period of continuous seven years or more are liable to be transferred to Investor Education and Protection Fund (IEPF) Authority. Members are advised to visit the website: www.concorindia.co.in to ascertain details of shares and unpaid/unclaimed dividend liable for transfer in the name of IEPF Authority. To avoid the situation of transfer of unpaid dividends and shares to IEPF Authority, the members are requested to write to RTA or to the Company for claiming their unpaid / unclaimed dividend(s), the details of which have been provided on the website of the Company.

7) As per SEBI circular No. SEBI/HO/38/13/(4)/2026-MIRSDPOD/II/4298/2026 dated February 6, 2026, a special window only for re-lodgement of transfer deeds is open till February 04, 2027. During this period, the securities that are re-lodged for transfer shall be issued only in demat mode.

8) Pursuant to Section 91 of the Companies Act, 2013 read with applicable Rules thereunder and Regulation 42 of SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, the Register of Members and Share Transfer Books of the Company will remain closed from 22.09.2026 to 28.09.2026 (both days inclusive) for AGM and to determine the shareholders entitled to final dividend of Rs. 1.00 per equity share of the face value of Rs.5/- each for the year ended 31.03.2026, if approved at the Annual General Meeting. This final dividend will be paid by 27.10.2026.

For Container Corporation of India Ltd.
Sd/-
(Harish Chandra)
Principal Executive Director (Finance) & Company Secretary

Place: New Delhi
Date: 04.09.2026

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DP/9914/2026

YELLOW ALERT FOR TODAY; SEVERAL STRETCHES INUNDATED, SQUALL REPORTED IN PALAM

Heavy rain in Delhi-NCR, 11 flights diverted from IGIA



Visitors walk in the rain near India Gate (top); heavy rain causes waterlogging near Bharat Mandapam, in New Delhi on Friday. PRAVEEN KHANNA

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, September 4

HEAVY RAIN lashed Delhi-NCR on Friday, causing water-logging and traffic snarls and disrupting operations at Indira Gandhi International Airport, where 11 flights were diverted between 3.30 pm and 5 pm due to bad weather.

Five flights were diverted to Jaipur, four to Lucknow, one to Ahmedabad and one to Chandigarh. Waterlogging was reported outside the airport, including near Terminal 3 and the underpass connecting the airport with Vasant Kunj in the Capital.

As of 5.30 pm, Palam recorded the highest rainfall in Delhi at 75.6 mm, followed by Naraina (54 mm), Janakpuri (48.5 mm), Lodhi Road (34.6 mm) and Safdarjung (32.6 mm). Ridge recorded 20 mm and Ayanagar 12 mm of rainfall.

In neighbouring NCR areas, Gurgaon recorded 44.5 mm at one of its weather stations, while Noida recorded 0.5 mm of showers as of 5.30 pm.

In a district-level nowcast issued at 2.15 pm, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) put all 11 revenue districts of Delhi under red alert, forecasting moderate rain at most places with isolated heavy rainfall of 50-100 mm, thunderstorms and strong winds. It also warned of winds of 40-50



A waterlogged Delhi Airport on Friday. ANI

kmph, with gusts reaching 60 kmph, along with frequent cloud-to-ground lightning.

A squall was reported at Palam airport between 3.37 pm and 3.39 pm, with wind speeds reaching 76 kmph. Visibility at the airport dropped to 600 m during the spell.

The heavy rain inundated several stretches, with water-logging reported in Vasant Kunj, Mahipalpur, Mehrauli, Connaught Place, ITO, Mathura Road, Sadar Bazar and Kamla Nagar.

Several key underpasses, including those at Pul Prahladpur, Zakhira and Minto Bridge, were affected, while the Utsav Park area in Patparganj also reported waterlogging.

Traffic movement slowed across the city, with bumper-to-bumper traffic reported at several locations, including Sub-roti Park.

Rainfall had been largely limited to a few parts of the city during the morning and early afternoon before the heavier spell.

The weather over Delhi is being influenced by a well-marked low pressure area over central northern Madhya Pradesh and adjoining Uttar Pradesh, along with the monsoon trough passing through the region. The low pressure system is expected to remain nearly stationary for the next two

• Skywatch



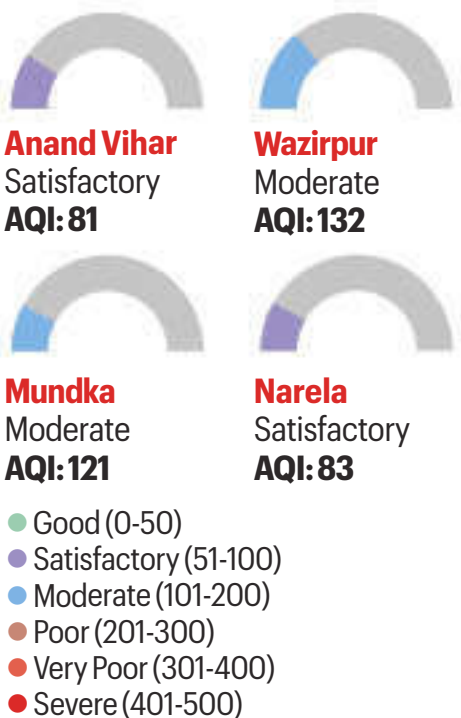
Forecast: September 5, 2026
Generally cloudy sky; spell of light to moderate rain

MAX: 29-31°C
3.1°C below normal

MIN: 24-26°C
2.6°C below normal

• **Sunrise:** 6:02 AM (September 6)
• **Sunset:** 6:38 PM (September 5)
• **Moonrise:** 12:27 PM (September 6)
• **Moonset:** 2:14 PM (September 5)

• AQI Tracker



Delhi appoints sub-registrars across 39 subdivisions via randomisation

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 4

IN A bid to improve accessibility to citizen services, the Delhi government has appointed sub-registrars across all 39 subdivisions of the Capital, officials said on Friday.

The appointments were carried out through a randomisation process to ensure transparency, they added.

"There used to be 22 sub-registrar offices in Delhi which has now been increased to 39, and the postings to these positions have been carried out through a "technology-assisted randomisation process," according to a statement issued by the Chief Minister's Office on Friday.

A sub-registrar is a revenue official who deals with registration of documents, primarily property documents.

"This will enable Delhi residents to access both sub-division and Sub-Registrar services in their respective areas... The government's objective is to strengthen systems that make government functioning more transparent, organised, effective and convenient for citizens," said a statement from the CMO.

The randomisation process was conducted in the presence of the additional chief secretary (Services), the CMO said.

Under the process, some officers have been retained as sub-registrars while others have been transferred from other assignments and appointed to the post.

WITH PTI INPUTS

SC's expert panel seeks more time to examine multiple yardsticks to define Aravallis

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 4

CAUTIONING AGAINST releasing premature area estimates, a High-Powered Committee (HPC) constituted by the Supreme Court has said the Aravalli hills cannot be scientifically delineated using a single terrain-based yardstick.

Instead, the panel has proposed an ecosystem-based framework that considers forests, watersystems, biodiversity, landscape connectivity and livelihoods. In a compliance report submitted to the top court on August 31, the HPC sought a six-month extension until February 28, 2027 to complete a transparent, reproducible, and scientifically defensible review.

This proposed "Aravalli Ecosystem Landscape" framework would treat the Aravallis as an interconnected ecological system rather than a collection of individually identifiable hills.

Numerical estimates with potentially key regulatory and socio-economic consequences should be released only after the underlying datasets, methodology, and analytical parameters have been tested and independently validated, the panel said.

In November-December 2025, a series of investigations by *The Indian Express* exposed how a SC-appointed committee headed by the Environment Secretary ignored the Forest Survey of India's (FSI) warning that a 100-metre height threshold would exclude nearly 90 per cent of Aravalli hills, overlooked objections raised by the Central Empowered Committee (CEC), and disregarded the SC's own re-



The Aravalli range. FILE

jection of the 100-metre benchmark in 2010.

Subsequently, the amicus curiae in the Aravalli definition case informed the SC in writing that the October 2025 report had "completely suppressed" the views of the FSI while recommending a 100-metre definition for the hills.

On December 29, the SC put the implementation of the Environment Ministry's October 2025 report on hold and underscored the need for a HPC of domain experts to undertake a comprehensive review.

The HPC was constituted in May 2026 to examine the definition, delineation, conservation, and management of the Aravallis and file its report by August 31.

In its report, the HPC said a robust assessment would have to go beyond the single terrain criterion and consider digital elevation models, spatial scale, analytical parameters, and validation procedures, as well as ecological and socio-economic evidence.

The panel is comparing the methodology recommended in October 2025 by the Committee for Uniform Definition of Hills

and Ranges of Aravalli with an earlier approach developed by the Forest Survey of India in 2010.

The feasibility of the comparative exercise has been demonstrated in three sample districts — Alwar, Ajmer, and Udaipur. The HPC proposes to extend it across the Aravalli landscape using the Copernicus 30-metre digital elevation model and thematic layers such as district resource maps. Selected areas may also be analysed using higher-resolution CartoDEM data.

The panel said the results required further scrutiny and validation by institutions such as the National Remote Sensing Centre and Indian Space Research Organisation. Changes in datasets or processing parameters could alter estimates of the area and number of hills, with major implications for conservation, regulation, mining, and livelihoods.

The proposed Aravalli Ecosystem Landscape framework would combine the core hill system with recorded forests, protected areas, sacred sites, 'Orans' and traditional pastures, wetlands, critical catchments, groundwater-recharge zones, and archaeologically significant areas. Where relevant, it would also examine ecological links between the Aravallis and the adjoining Vindhyan hill systems.

A composite index based on multiple factors could eventually be developed to identify areas with differing socio-ecological characteristics and guide differentiated conservation and management measures.

Sanitation workers' strike enters second month, Gurgaon's garbage problem grows

Abhimanyu Hazarika
Gurgaon, September 4

AT SUNCITY Township off Golf Course Road in Gurgaon's Sector 54, a 27-year-old sanitation worker quietly pushes one of three handcarts past rows of upscale houses.

He is among the few of the more than a dozen contractual workers deployed to clear garbage at Suncity Township who still report for duty — though only every alternate day — braving the fallout of an indefinite strike by municipal sanitation workers and fire department staff that completed a month on Friday.

He keeps looking over his shoulder as he talks about the pressure on workers caught between striking colleagues and private contractors. "Some contractors, who are traitors, take advantage of the helplessness of sanitation workers," he says.

He does not want to be named, fearing action from the workers' union. He explained that the garbage crisis is not only the result of workers being on strike. Even workers brought in to fill the gap are not coming to work, as they are also not getting their salaries on time, he claimed.

Waste piles up

At Suncity, Resident Welfare Association chairperson Kusum Sharma said the association has appointed additional labourers to manage sweeping and garbage collection in the society. But still, many do not turn up, she added.

A few metres away, Municipal Corporation of Gurugram (MCG) supervisor Akash (35) — 25 workers under him are supposed to clean garbage at Suncity — said only around eight



At Sector 23 market (top); Suncity Township's garbage collection point. ABHIMANYU HAZARIKA

have been reporting for work.

"Some residents complain about litter around parks not being picked up quickly enough. Workers fear action from the union if they are seen trying to break the strike," he said.

A short drive away in Sector 56, heaps of domestic waste have gathered on the roadside and vacant plots.

Rakesh Kumar, an MCG supervisor overseeing the area, cited a change in the company that supplies contractors to MCG and delayed payments to describe what has crippled waste lifting across residential pockets. "A recent change in contractors has made things worse. Some workers had to wait, and continue to wait, three months for their salaries, so they stopped coming," he said.

RWA president of Sector 56,

Harish Yadav, said the situation had worsened over the past month. "There are piles of garbage everywhere, especially near the markets," he added.

Protest march

Hundreds of sanitation workers and fire department staff gathered on Friday to mark 30 days of the agitation, even as garbage remained piled up in several residential areas.

Workers gathered under the Nagarpalika Karamchari Sangh and announced a protest march to the Civil Lines residence of Cabinet Minister and local MLA Rao Narbir Singh on Saturday.

Condemning what they called "unlawful arrests", union leaders demanded the withdrawal of all suspension and termination orders.

Basant Kumar, Gurgaon unit

president of the union, accused the Haryana government of giving conflicting figures on the number of demands accepted. "The Haryana government and its ministers are misleading the public. On social media and television channels, one minister claims 13 demands have been accepted, another says 14, and a third claims 12 have been met. This is false rhetoric. Not a single written government notification or letter has been issued," he said.

Tensions escalated on September 1 after the Haryana government issued show-cause notices and suspension orders to some fire service personnel.

Ministers questioned

While the workers questioned Urban Local Bodies Minister Vipul Goel over the continuing disruption of civic services, they also criticised Social Justice and Empowerment Minister Krishan Bedi for not following through on his assurance of facilitating talks between the union and Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini.

"Why sanitation and sewer workers continue to be hired on contract when other cadres have regular recruitment," Kumar asked.

He told the *The Indian Express* that Gurgaon could not become "like Paris" if the condition of workers did not improve. "What are the protesters asking for — wages better than the Rs 9,000-10,000 they are getting, and regularisation? The civic body can claim the city is clean by choosing some spots for photo ops, but we can assure you the sanitation situation is crumbling and diseases are spreading due to the administration's apathy," he said.

• THIS YEAR'S DELHI CONTEMPORARY ART WEEK FEATURES WORKS BY SIX CITY-BASED GALLERIES

At DCAW, Capital beyond its postcard image, seen through everyday life

Trisha Mukherjee
New Delhi, September 4

TWO YOUNG men stand leisurely in the street. One leans against a shuttered shop holding a half-lit cigarette. The other is on his phone. People, like life, pass them by.

It is a familiar sight from an urban neighbourhood. But on a gallery wall at Bikaner House, with Lutyens' Delhi just outside, the scene makes you look at a side of the Capital that often gets lost in the talk of development.

This everyday life of the city, seen in Shonezie Akhtar's *Galli Ke Ladke*, is at the centre of this year's Delhi Contemporary Art Week (DCAW), featuring works

by six Delhi-based galleries.

"I am drawn to things that are easy to overlook. I am interested in the everyday — the people you pass on the street, a particular gesture, a lane, a group of boys walking home. With *Galli Ke Ladke*, it was less about telling a story about these boys and more about capturing the feeling of encountering them in that space," Akhtar said.

This attention to things people usually overlook runs through the exhibition.

The works paint a portrait of a city not as a postcard but as a lived ecosystem — through its workers and public spaces, people in transit and the systems that shape their lives.



Under the Sink by Shreeya Dwivedi; (right) *Galli Ke Ladke* by Shoenize Akhtar. EXPRESS

In Ritika Sharma's *Getting Away* series, unidentified people are seen doing everyday things

— throwing out trash, leaving or arriving with a suitcase, or simply taking a stroll.



Sharma's vantage point mimics that of a CCTV camera, seemingly alluding to the in-

creasing surveillance in cities. "Sharma focuses on how routine gestures, spaces and signs reflect systems of control, care and resistance. The shifting position of the figure, from being seen and seeing, approaching and leaving, creates a sense of unpredictability about what has happened before and what might happen next," said Vadehra Art Gallery, which brought her work to DCAW, in a statement.

B Pradhan's sculptural installation 'Theatre of Labour' focuses on the workforce — the

backbone of the city — overlooked, though indispensable.

Shreeya Dwivedi's *Under the Sink* moves the lens from the macro view of the city into its intimate domestic spaces, inhabiting which, especially alone, come with its own challenges.

Although invisible, these spaces add depth to a city's character. In the work, Dwivedi paints herself cleaning a sink pipe. "Cleaning is a simple chore but it can feel overwhelming at times as I live alone. One day I was cleaning the pipe and

smelled like it the whole day. I tried to show a connection between the bend of the pipe and my backbone, showing that both are carrying the pressure alone," she said.

A city is shaped by its people, just as people are shaped by the city they live in — Astha Butail explores this idea in her *Self Series*, which comprises seven hexagonal mirrors placed in a horizontal line across the corner of a room. The mirrors create several reflections of the viewer, much like the different identities people take on as they move through city life. At times, these may even overlap or clash.

The DCAW ends on September 5.



Gift of Smile

SEEKING TO give a polite push to the usual appeal not to bring any gifts or bouquets, senior BJP leader and Rajya Sabha MP Satish Poonia's new office at the party headquarters has put up a poster bearing a special request for visitors: "Bring a single flower, or a book, or a gift of participation in a social deed. Your love and blessings are the best gifts." Poonia, who was recently appointed one of BJP's national general secretaries and given the charge of poll-bound Punjab as well as Haryana, reiterates in the poster that visitors are welcome to his office but no gifts will be accepted.

Polls Apart

ALL IS not well in the Uttar Pradesh unit of the Congress. State president Ajay Rai and AICC state in-charge Rajendra Pal Gautam are not ready to see eye to eye on party matters. Despite several leaders trying to iron out the differences between the two, sources in the state Congress say they remain at loggerheads. While Rai has the backing of the state unit and is a known figure in Uttar Pradesh politics, Gautam has been given authority by the Congress high command to do as he sees fit. With Assembly elections due early next year, some in the state unit are worried if this tiff between the two leaders will impact the results for the party.

Punjab to hike DA of 85,000 staff to 60%: Minister

Chandigarh: Punjab government will raise the DA of around 85,000 government employees from 42% to 60%, to bring their DA in line with the Central pay pattern, Cabinet Minister Aman Arora said Friday. The decision covers employees recruited after July 17, 2020, whose basic pay is based on the Central government's 7th Pay Commission matrix, but whose DA is based on Punjab's pay pattern. The move does not cover employees recruited before July 17, 2020, who are paid as per the Punjab Pay Commission's matrix. Arora said the decision was taken by a three-member Cabinet Sub-Committee comprising him, Finance Minister Harpal Singh Cheema and Social Security Minister Dr Baljit Kaur. The recommendation will now be sent to CM Bhagwant Mann for final approval, he said.

ENS

Backstabbing is everywhere... ask Manish Tewari: V-P in Chandigarh

Radhakrishnan says safety at Panjab University will be highest priority

Express News Service
Chandigarh, September 4

VICE-PRESIDENT C P Radhakrishnan on Friday urged students not to lose heart over setbacks, saying failure and "backstabbing" are part of life and mental strength is essential to moving ahead. "Failure is a part of life. I have also failed many times, not because of my effort, but because of somebody else's efforts also... Backstabbing will be there everywhere.... You ask Manish Tewari ji. How many backstabs he has taken in his career," Radhakrishnan said. The Vice-President, who is also the Chancellor of Panjab University in Chandigarh, was addressing students during his first visit to the university. Chandigarh MP Tewari was present on the stage. Radakrishnan said, "Every-one sitting on the dais, including me, had to face backstabs. They are well covered by my coat. It is not happening to only one person; it is happening to every person. In spite of that, we have to move forward."

Radhakrishnan's reference to Tewari came hours after the Congress MP's cryptic post on X: "When leaders tolerate mediocrity, it's a cancer that spreads like wildfire and consumes the very soul of a nation or an organisation." Tewari had earlier triggered political speculation through social media posts after the Congress announced a new organisational team for Punjab in July without giving him a prominent role. At the time, he posted about the "insecurities of individuals and institutions", amid questions over his position in the party ahead of the 2027 Punjab Assembly elections. Tewari, who has frequently been critical of the party leadership and has at times taken positions at variance with the stated party line, had also recently shared a quote attributed to former British prime minister Winston Churchill on the importance of criticism. "...If it is heeded in time, danger may be averted; if it is suppressed, a fatal distemper may develop," Tewari wrote, describing criticism as



Vice-President C P Radhakrishnan and Chandigarh MP Manish Tewari at Panjab University in Chandigarh on Friday. KAMLESHWAR SINGH

necessary even when it is not agreeable. Radhakrishnan also addressed campus safety, saying that following the death of a PhD student, he had immediately directed the PU authorities to undertake a comprehensive safety audit of the entire campus. In July, a PhD scholar of the Department of Microbiology died after she was allegedly electrocuted on the PU campus. He said an internal committee has been constituted to review the existing infrastructure and submit a detailed report, and stressed that the safety and well-being of students and staff must remain the University's highest priority. Speaking on research and innovation, Radhakrishnan said that on road to Viksit Bharat, research must increasingly focus on national priorities. "Ideas emerging from classrooms and laboratories should not remain confined within institutional walls. The entire world should take them," he added. In his address, Tewari asked the V-P whether the region could host a fully funded central university focused on semiconductor research and robotics, along the lines of one established in Andhra Pradesh.

13 years later, Modi returns to SRCC as PM for centenary celebrations today

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 4

AFTER ALMOST 13 years, Prime Minister Narendra Modi will return to Delhi University's Shri Ram College of Commerce (SRCC) to participate in the centenary celebrations Saturday and address the gathering, according to an official statement. Modi had last visited the premier institution in 2013 when he was Gujarat Chief Minister. A year later, he became the Prime Minister. His visit comes amid the BJP's ongoing youth outreach following the BJP-led Jantar Mantar protests last month over exam paper leaks. Important Assembly elections in Uttar Pradesh, Punjab and Goa are also lined up next year. Back in 2013, in one of his first major public addresses in New Delhi, Modi said he was a leader who thinks "differently". To illustrate this, he held up a glass of water and used the half-full and half-empty analogy. "Ek cheez ko dekhne ka alag nazariya hota hai. Maan lijiye main aapko dikhaun, to aap mein se jo aashavaadi honge, wo kahenge aadha gilaas bhara hua hai. Jo niraa-shavaadi hain, wo kahenge aadha gilaas khaali hai. Mitron, main do raaston se alag raaste ka insaan hoon. Meri teesri soch hai aur meri soch yeh hai, yeh gilaas bhara hua hai — aadha paani se, aadha hawa se. (There are many ways to look at one thing. Suppose I show you something (showing half-glass water), those among you who are optimistic will say, the glass is half-full. Those who are pessimistic will say the glass is half-empty. I have a third way of looking at it, and my thinking is this: the glass is full — half with

water and half with air.)" In April this year, Modi had met the Governing Body and a delegation from the college at his residence to mark the institution's 100th anniversary. He had also released a special commemorative postage stamp to mark the SRCC's centenary. Besides the PM, SRCC principal, Prof Simrit Kaur, has also extended an invitation to Union Education Minister Pralhad Joshi for the celebrations, which coincides with Teachers' Day. In a post on X, Joshi, who was given the charge of the education ministry last month, said, "...Had a cordial interaction on the institution's remarkable journey and its enduring contribution to education."

According to a government statement, "The centenary celebrations coincide with Teachers' Day, making the occasion particularly significant as the nation honours the contribution of teachers and educators in shaping generations and strengthening the foundations of society." Senior BJP leader and former Union minister Vijay Goel, an alumnus of SRCC, said in a post on X, "Our Shri Ram College of Commerce will once again host Prime Minister Narendra Modi. For me, this is a matter of great pride, because my father studied in this very college. I studied in this college. My brother studied in this college. My son studied in this college." "The best days of my life pursuing B.Com and M.Com, I spent in this very college. Student politics, national-level basketball and kho-kho player, jail during the Emergency, the fun in the canteen — we did it all," Goel said.

EXPRESS special

Row over his remarks on women, Keralam cleric calls for 'restraint' as CPM leaders join criticism

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram,
September 4

A WEEK after his remarks about women in public sphere stirred a storm in Keralam, prominent Muslim cleric A P Aboobacker Musliyar, popularly known as 'Kanthapuram', regretted the controversy on Friday and called for restraint from his followers. "Discussions should serve as healthy forums for impartially evaluating ideas and learning new things," he said. A day after Eid Milad-un-Nabi was celebrated on August 26, Musliyar had issued a statement to all mosque committees under his organisation Samastha Kerala Jamiyyathul Ulama — a powerful body of Sunni clerics and scholars — saying: "Islamic celebrations should not cross the confines of religion. All mosque committees, madrasas and other institutions should ensure that such celebrations and programmes are held as per the Islamic norms. Exhibiting women in public places and stages amidst non-related men (that is, men who are not their relatives), and mixing unIslamic ways of celebrations and practices are not fitting for the faithful and undesirable." Musliyar repeated the same at a public event later, saying: "What the Quran teaches is that women should remain quietly confined to their homes. If women enter the public arena in this manner, there will be great destruction." This is why the

purdah system had been introduced, he said. Eid celebrations in Keralam had seen several Muslim women and girls dancing during processions. Before that, during Onam, videos of Muslim women and girls dancing along with others in what is Kerala's state festival had gone viral. This was despite directives by some clerics against Muslims joining the Onam festivities. Musliyar's remarks drew condemnation from Keralam Chief Minister V D Satheesan, even though Congress ally IUML tried to defend the cleric. Later, the CPI(M) too came out against Musliyar, though he and his faction of Samastha are seen as backing the party in the state. CPI(M) state committee member P K Sainaba, who hails from Muslim-dominated Malappuram district, said the community had changed when it came to girls and women. "Even as they hold their faith dear, they are liberal in their thoughts and want to lead a social life... When I joined the CPI(M) in the 1980s, I faced protests from the community. Now, nobody will hold such a protest. All political parties, particularly the IUML, want to field women for elections," she said. Speaking about the wife of the Prophet, Sainaba said: "If Aisha could lead troops, why can't the Aishas of today be allowed to enjoy the freedom and rights enshrined in the Constitution?" Advocate Noorbeena Ra-



A P Aboobacker Musliyar courted controversy by saying: 'Quran teaches that women should remain quietly confined to their homes'. WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

sheed, one of the senior most women leaders in IUML, said her party should not remain silent or ambiguous on changing notions of women's empowerment. "The party should spell out how women can participate in public and political life while remaining rooted in Islamic values. In the 1990s, we had worked hard to bring Muslim women to public space. Our aim was to bring them into the mainstream of politics, overcoming various restrictions imposed by their families and society... They were told to shape their public life, personal life and family while firmly upholding Islamic values," Rasheed said, adding that these questions coming up now "make me uneasy". The IUML, which has been fielding women for local polls, nominated a Muslim woman during this year's Assembly elec-

tions. Fathima Thahilya became the first-ever Muslim legislator of the party, winning from the CPI(M) stronghold of Perambra in Kozhikode against the formidable T P Ramakrishnan, the state convener of the LDF. In his statement Friday, Musliyar said: "We have to realise the vested interests of those who are trying to divert spiritual discussions into controversies. Such malicious intentions that want to upend the pursuit of knowledge should be approached with vigilance. Workers should not succumb to any form of provocation... The tradition of Sunni believers has always been to confront every form of evil with goodness." **Who is 'Kanthapuram'** The stature of the 94-year-old Musliyar can be gauged from the fact that, in 2019, the general secretary of the Samastha Kerala Jamiyyathul Ulama was rendered the title of 'Grand Mufti' by a national body of Sunni clerics. At the same time, Musliyar is known for his orthodox views, especially on gender issues. In 2009, when the Law Commission of the state recommended banning polygamy, one of his reactions was that men should not miss sex during their wives' menstrual period. He also took a stand against co-education and women contesting elections, and said that the minimum age of marriage for Muslim women should be fixed at 16. The Samastha Kerala Sunni Vidyabhyasa Board, led by

Musliyar's Sunni segment, manages hundreds of madrasas in Keralam, some of them exclusively for women. And while he may be conservative when it comes to faith, Musliyar has been open to exploring business opportunities. Markaz Knowledge City, an integrated township in Kozhikode, is one of his flagship ventures, which includes a mosque, unani medical college, business school, apartments, nursing college, four-star hotel and souk, among other facilities. Musliyar is the chairman of the Knowledge City and his son Muhammed Abdul Hakkim is its managing director. The township attracts hordes of visitors, mainly followers of the cleric. On the political front, Musliyar has openly backed the CPI(M). During this year's Assembly elections, the party banked heavily on Sunni Muslims under his leadership to make inroads into the community, mainly in North Keralam. Musliyar was caught in another controversy early this year when, after meeting Prime Minister Narendra Modi, he said that Muslims in India were not facing any major difficulties. In 2025, Musliyar claimed that his intervention had helped postpone the execution of Indian nurse Nimisha Priya, who has been facing the death sentence in the murder of a Yemeni citizen. He claimed to have used his rapport with Yemeni Sufi scholars; the Centre did not officially attest his claim.

Govt orders to vacate TMC MP Abhishek's Kolkata office over 'fire safety violation'

Sweetie Kumari
Kolkata, September 4

CITING "SEVERE" fire safety violations and declaring the premises a "public safety hazard", the West Bengal Fire Services Department on Friday ordered that TMC MP Abhishek Banerjee's office in Kolkata's Camac Street be vacated immediately. The notice has been issued to vacate the building's sixth and seventh floors housing Banerjee's office and the basement "without any delay". Fire Department officials said the action was initiated after the building owner failed to respond to their earlier notice over alleged non-compliance with fire safety norms, even as the tenants appeared with relevant documents on time. The landlord is responsible for maintaining the building's

fire safety systems, they said. Besides, the fire safety certificate for the building expired on August 10 and the owner failed to renew it, they claimed. The owner has been directed not to use these floors in the building located at 9, Abanindranath Tagore Sarani (Camac Street), for any purpose until an adequate fire safety system is in place. The notice stated, "Considering the fact that due to non-maintenance and inadequacy of the required fire safety measures in the said occupancy(s) of the building, the occupancy(s) is unsafe from fire and life safety point of view (as notified by the memo under reference), it poses imminent threat to the safety of life and property of the building and its surroundings, you are directed to vacate the aforesaid occupancy(s) immediately."

What ABVP's Panjab University win means for Punjab polls, BJP-SAD alliance



NORTHERN LIGHTS
BY MANRAJ GREWAL SHARMA

A WEEKLY DISPATCH ON THE POLITICS AND IDEAS SHAPING NORTH INDIA
THE VICTORY of the RSS' student wing, Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP), in the Panjab University Campus Students' Council (PUCSC) election for the second consecutive time is being hailed as a proof of BJP's growing traction among young voters in Punjab. Union Home Minister Amit Shah took to X to hail ABVP's

win, describing it as a "testament to the unwavering faith of the youth power in the 'Nation First' ideology". In Punjab itself, the chatter was less about Gen Z and more about a tactical marriage of convenience: ABVP's last-minute alliance with Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD)'s student wing, Student Organisation of India (SOI). Coming less than six months before Punjab polls, some saw this pact as a possible sign of a similar tie-up between BJP and Sukhbir Badal-led SAD in the state. Yet, a sharper question remains: What does PUCSC poll result reveal about Panjab University — caught in a perennial tug-of-war between Punjab government and the Centre? And why should it not be read as a verdict on state's electorate? To decipher it, one could look at the university's history. Born in Lahore on October 14, 1882, after splitting from the University of Calcutta, PU was

midwifed by the Anjuman-i-Punjab, a literary and cultural movement spearheaded by orientalist Dr Gottlieb Wilhelm Leitner, then principal of Lahore Government College. It was funded by the princely states of Kashmir, Patiala, Kapurthala, and Bahawalpur, among others. From the beginning, PU had a fiercely autonomous character. It did not depend on a state treasury, but relied on its own earnings as an examining body. Then came Partition. PU became perhaps the only university in India to be partitioned. Reborn on the Indian side, it wandered through Hoshiarpur and Shimla before finally anchoring itself in Chandigarh in 1949. PU produced many luminaries, including former PM Manmohan Singh, who also taught economics here, ex-PM I K Gujral, ex-President Shankar Dayal Sharma, Nepal ex-PM Baburam Bhattarai, and Nobel



ABVP's Ankit Bidhan after Panjab University Student Council election victory.

laureate Har Gobind Khorana. In the late 1960s, a PU hostel room was considered more opulent than a bedroom in a prosperous home, recalls Senior Advocate ML Sarin. But the varsity's golden era was cut short. The 1966 reorganisation of Punjab, which once encircled Delhi from three sides, triggered a financial meltdown. New state universities disaffiliated their colleges, and by 2000,

Punjab had frozen its annual funding to PU at Rs 20 crore with Chandigarh, a UT, contributing the rest. A 1976 panel had fixed a 60:40 Centre-Punjab ratio for funding of PU; the attempts to shift the varsity's deficits onto the Centre's UGC went nowhere. A possible solution appeared when alumnus Manmohan Singh, after becoming the PM, proposed a central university status for PU. Prof Arun Grover, a physicist who served as PU's V-C from 2012-17, says that while Akali CM Parkash Singh Badal agreed, Congress's then leader Capt Amarinder Singh rejected the proposal, insisting that the university was and should remain part of Punjab. The Centre offered to shoulder the burden of paying salaries to PU's teaching and non-teaching staff. "PU is now an orphan institution," laments Grover. Today, the varsity limps along with roughly half the regular faculty it needs.

PU's poor finances eventually opened the door to a spiralling battle of control over it. There was a flashpoint in 2025 when the Centre proposed sweeping structural reforms in the university's governance, slashing its Senate from 90 members to 31 and stripping its graduates of voting rights. The Centre also replaced the elected Syndicate with members appointed by it. AAP CM Bhagwant Mann slammed the move as "unconstitutional" and "Nadir Shahi farman". Students and faculty members united under the Panjab University Bachao Morcha, launching an agitation that shut down the campus and forced postponement of exams before the Centre finally withdrew the order. When the PU administrators quietly stripped the campus signage of Punjabi earlier this year, the regional student group SATH — its name itself a Punjabi

word for a community gathering — retaliated by blackening the boards. The university eventually reinstated the language. Similar faultlines run through campus politics. Legacy student outfits such as the Student Organisation of Panjab University (SOPU) and the Panjab University Student Union (PUSU) have faded, their space taken by national players such as ABVP and Congress's student wing, NSUI, alongside AAP's student arm, Association of Students for Alternative Politics (ASAP). The Left acts as a watchdog through SFS (Students For Society), which made history in 2018 by electing PUCSC's first woman president, Kanupriya. In this fractured landscape of student politics, ABVP's back-to-back win in PUCSC presidential election is being seen in a section of state political circles as a sign of BJP's rise in the university. However, ABVP's last-min-

ute alliance with the SOI remained a significant factor this time. So what does it mean when ABVP needs SOI, and vice versa? As their rivals tried to run down the win, ABVP and SOI made a conscious attempt at inclusivity, raising slogans of "Bharat Mata Ki Jai" followed by "Jo Bole So Nihal" at the iconic student centre, popularly known as StuC, on the campus. What impact, if any, the PUCSC results would have on young voters in Punjab hinterland is anyone's guess, especially when disillusionment with mainstream panthic parties is being amplified by new political outfits like MP Amritpal Singh's Akali Dal (Waris Punjab De). Whether ABVP-SOI alignment would translate into a similar one between BJP and SAD is an open question.

Manraj Grewal Sharma is National Editor, North

Terrorist shot dead in Budgam encounter, search on for more

Bashaarat Masood
Srinagar, September 4

A DAY after a brief exchange of fire in the forests of Yusmarg in central Kashmir, an unidentified terrorist was killed in a joint operation by the Army and Police on Friday.

While security forces believe 1-2 terrorists are still trapped in the area, the combing operation has been extended into the dense forests.

“Based on specific intelligence input, a joint search operation was launched by [the] Indian Army, Jammu and Kashmir Police and the central reserve police force (CRPF) in [the] general area Ashdar Gali, Budgam,” the Army’s Srinagar-based Chinार Corps said. “Vigilant troops observed suspicious activity, and upon being challenged, terrorists opened fire, prompting a fierce exchange of gunfire during which one terrorist was neutralised and one AK rifle and other war-like stores recovered.”

This comes after a shootout between terrorists and security forces in the forested area of Ashdar Gali in central Kashmir’s Budgam on Thursday. Ashdar Gali lies above the famous Yusmarg tourist resort

This is the second gunfight between security forces and terrorists in the Valley this year

and connects Kashmir Valley’s Budgam to Poonch in Jammu region. The area has thick forests and borders the districts of Budgam and Poonch.

After the exchange of fire, the joint team tightened the cordon and launched a combing operation.

During intensified searches, the forces again came into contact with the terrorists, who opened fire while trying to break the security cordon.

The joint team returned fire, officials said, adding that intelligence inputs point to the presence of 1-2 more terrorists in the forests, prompting intensified searches. This is only the second gunfight between security forces and terrorists in the Valley this year.

On July 8, Zakir Ahmad Ganai, a Lashkar-e-Toiba (LeT) terrorist, was killed in a gunfight in south Kashmir’s Shopian. According to police records, Zakir was one of only two active terrorists in the Valley.

India in touch with Ukraine, Russia to help end war: EAM

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 4

INDIA HAS been in continuous touch with both Ukraine and Russia and is trying to see if there are ideas and suggestions that will contribute to the mitigation or the cessation of the conflict, External Affairs Minister (EAM) S Jaishankar said on Friday.

Jaishankar, who is in Poland after visiting Ukraine, said that he discussed with his Poland counterpart Radoslaw Sikorski the complex global challenges, including supply chain resilience, and food, fuel and fertiliser security.

“The Deputy Prime Minister and I also understandably discussed some major global and regional issues, notable among them is the war in Ukraine, now in its fifth year... I myself have just come here from Kyiv,” he said, referring to his visit to Ukraine a day earlier.

Replying to a question, he said India has been in continuous touch with both the Ukrainian and Russian sides. “What we are trying to do is to see if there are ideas and suggestions which can be developed in some way in which they will contribute to the mitigation, ideally, the cessation of



External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar meets Poland Deputy PM Radoslaw Sikorski in Warsaw on Friday. ANI

the conflict,” he added.

A day earlier, Jaishankar had said in Ukraine that India is ready to extend “help in any manner” to end the Ukraine-Russia war. He had met President Volodymyr Zelenskyy and his Ukrainian counterpart Andrii Sybiha in Kyiv on Thursday. On Friday, Jaishankar reiterated that India believes that endless war must give way to an end to war. “These are wars without winners. Every additional day means more death, more destruction, more loss to the parties themselves, and more cost to the rest of the world,” he said in Warsaw.

“Our efforts must therefore focus on promoting dialogue and diplomacy. We must each

do what we can in whichever way we believe could be most effective and support the efforts of others to bring this conflict to an end. This is India’s strong conviction, and we are acting on it,” he added.

On India’s purchases of Russian oil, the minister said the issue is a conflict, and its solution lies in negotiations, not in trade.

“This war is not going to end... not because somebody chose to buy or not buy oil or alumina or fertilisers or metals and minerals. It will end when there is diplomacy, when there is dialogue and when there is negotiation. So, I think let’s diagnose the problem right,” he said while replying to another question.

In his talks with Sikorski, the EAM reviewed the progress of the Joint Action Plan 2024-28, which focuses on, among other things, trade and investment, defence, culture and multilateral cooperation.

“Value Poland’s support for deeper India-EU cooperation. Confident that the entry into force of the FTA will lead to even closer bilateral cooperation,” Jaishankar said, adding that India and Poland have a longstanding cordial relationship that was elevated to a Strategic Partnership in 2024.

“The world is today grappling not only with multiple wars but also serious challenges of food, fuel and fertiliser availability. Supply chain resilience is an independent but added concern. As political democracies, market economies and open societies, India and Poland can cooperate to shape the direction of many important global debates. Our tradition of working closely in the United Nations and multilateral forums is an important expression of that convergence,” he said.

Later, Jaishankar called on Polish President Karol Nawrocki and discussed the bilateral Strategic Partnership and views on the Ukraine conflict and the West Asia situation.

• BRIEFLY



Medical professionals evacuate newborns as fire breaks out in the NICU of Asian Hospital in Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar. PTI

MAHARASHTRA

9 newborns evacuated after fire at private hospital’s neonatal care unit

NINE NEWBORNS were shifted after a fire broke out in the NICU (Neonatal Intensive Care Unit) of a private hospital in Maharashtra’s Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar in the early hours of Friday, the hospital administration said. The incident occurred at Asian Hospital on Jalna Road, officials said. Nine babies, in need of intensive or specialised medical care, were in the NICU when the staff noticed smoke coming out of an AC unit, said Dr Shoeb Hashmi, who runs the hospital. “It was a small incident, and nothing untoward happened. As a precaution, our team evacuated the infants along with the patients in the neighbouring general ward,” he said. The general ward patients were brought back later, he said. PTI

Jharkhand: 3 drown in river while bathing

THREE BOYS drowned while bathing in the Tadgao River here on Friday. All three bodies have been recovered, police said. The incident took place around 10 am in Ghurnadih village in Jharkhand’s Chatra district, they said. “We recovered the body of Satyam Kumar (12), who had gone missing while bathing with two of his friends,” Sadar police station officer-in-charge Anil Oraon told PTI. The other two deceased are Prince Kumar (16) and Ansh Prakash (11), police said. PTI

TN woman seeks rescue from Kuwait

A DOMESTIC worker from Kallakurichi district has sent an SOS video from Kuwait, alleging torture, starvation and non-payment of wages by her employers and appealing to Indian authorities to rescue her. In a widely-circulated video, she alleged that she had been denied proper food for over 50 days and had not been paid her salary of two months. “I am afraid they will kill me,” she alleged. In another video, the woman’s mother alleged that an employment agent had misled them about the job. PTI

RELEASE ON NOVEMBER 10

As Penguin deal falls through, Sonia book to be now published by HarperCollins

Ritu Sarin
New Delhi, September 4

A WEEK after *The Indian Express* reported that the deal between Penguin Random House India and senior Congress leader Sonia Gandhi to publish her memoir had fallen through, HarperCollins India has announced it will publish the book, titled *Belonging: A Journey of Love* by Sonia Gandhi.

The memoir, the publisher said in a post on X, will be published in India on 10 November 2026. “One of the most anticipated political memoirs of our time, *Belonging* is a dramatic and deeply personal story of love, identity, duty and belonging, and offers a rare insider’s view of India’s journey,” the post added.

The Indian Express was the first to report that Penguin Random House India would not proceed with the memoir’s publication after Sonia Gandhi turned down some “editorial changes and deletions” suggested by the publisher.

The Indian Express report had also mentioned that HarperCollins was close to finalising the agreement to publish and distribute the book in India. It is understood that several Indian publishers were in touch with the book’s agent, David Godwin, but were informed that the “deal” had been finalised with HarperCollins over 2 weeks ago.

Earlier, US-based Alfred A Knopf, a division of Penguin Random House, announced the book’s release scheduled for November 10. Knopf had said the first print run for the

title would be 100,000 copies. The publishing deal between Penguin Random House India and Sonia Gandhi fell through after a “back-and-forth” lasting at least two months.

Sources had earlier told *The Indian Express* that these deliberations were “cordial” at the outset but got “rough” towards the end. Among the passages that were objected to were: references to Prime Minister Narendra Modi and his 12-year rule; the role of the RSS; references to instances of communal divide and riots, and the plight of minorities.

Sonia Gandhi was represented by the wife of one of Rajiv Gandhi’s aides and a family friend. PRHI had a team of at least three editors, including consultants.

Sources said that the author’s side pushed back with two key arguments. One, that the Penguin Random House India lawyers were being “over-sensitive.” And, two, that the “numerous” edits and deletions, as suggested by them — including mention of Prime Minister Narendra Modi or contemporary developments like the Indo-China stand-off in Galwan as well as mentions of communal strife and status of minorities — would lead to an awkward situation of two versions of the book, the global edition at variance with the Indian edition.

“Readers in India would have to compare the text of the title published globally to the one printed in India to know what all had been changed or censored,” said a source.

Suvendu: FIR against teacher who asked student to ‘remove tilak’



A viral video brought the matter to CM Adhikari’s notice. ANI

Express News Service
Kolkata, September 4

ASSERTING THAT “these things will not happen in West Bengal”, Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari said on Friday that police have been directed to file an FIR against a teacher who has been suspended by a missionary school in South Kolkata for allegedly removing *chandan* (sandalwood) *tilak* from the forehead of a student.

Addressing a press conference in Kolkata, the CM said, “A teacher of a missionary school regularly harassed the student for applying *chandan tilak* on forehead. The student was humiliated everyday for this and was told to remove the *tilak* and wash face.”

The matter came to light after the student shared the issue on social media, it is learnt. The video went viral, triggering a controversy over religious freedom in educational institutions.

An education department official said the allegation came to the CM’s notice, following which the administration looked into the matter and initiated action against the teacher.

Adhikari added that a woman employee posted at Bikash Bhavan (Education Department headquarters) was also suspended for sharing “objectionable” content against Prime Minister Narendra Modi on social media.

“A government employee posted at Bikash Bhavan wrote something bad on social media against the Prime Minister. These things will not happen in Bengal. No government employee can do this. She has been suspended,” he said.

The employee in question had written about PM Modi’s foreign trips.

After the BJP came to power in West Bengal, Adhikari has asked the state government employees to “abide by service rules”. Earlier, Chief Secretary Manoj Agarwal had also issued a directive enforcing a “complete prohibition on unauthorised communication”.

35 years, two absconders and a cold trail: How police rebuilt 1991 Jammu blast case

Arun Sharma & Naveed Iqbal
Jammu, Bijbehara, September 4

ALTAF HUSSAIN Sheikh came from a well-respected family in Anantnag’s Bijbehara and an established businessman. Neighbours say he lived a perfectly ordinary family life with a wife and three children — a son and two daughters.

It was a shock, therefore, when police arrested the 56-year-old Sheikh from his home in Bijbehara’s Baba Colony on August 13 in connection with the 1991 bomb blast at Jammu Railway Station. “I don’t understand why this is happening now. Where were they for all these years?” his 21-year-old daughter told *The Indian Express*.

Over the last two weeks, GRP sources claim to have made one more arrest in the April 2, 1991, Jammu Railway Station blast, along with Sheikh. The blast killed two paramilitary personnel and a civilian and left 18 others injured. For the police, the two arrests mark a breakthrough in a case that has been in abeyance for over 35 years and came on the back of what investigators claim was a two-year-long verification of public records.

Says one investigator: “His lawyers appeared before the police officers with a long list of documents to prove that we have the wrong person. But everybody became silent when we got his identity established through the lambardar [village headman] and chowkidar of Marhama village, where he lived before the blast”.

But the family and neighbours insist that this is a case of mistaken identity. “He would have been in Class 11 at the time of the blasts,” his daughter says. “How is it possible that he participated in a bombing and came back to live a normal life? That he went to college and started a business.”

Police had previously arrested Aman Ullah Khan hours after the blast at Jammu Railway Station’s Platform No. 1. A week later, another absconding suspect, Showkat Khan, from Anantnag, was arrested.

All three have been booked under various sections of the Ranbir Penal Code and Terrorist and Disruptive Activities (Prevention) Act, India’s former anti-terrorism law. According to investigators, both Sheikh and Showkat were in their early 20s at the time of the explosion, and



One of the accused, Altaf Hussain Sheikh, was arrested on August 13

Aman Ullah Khan’s questioning at the time led them to believe that both went into hiding, frequently changing places. But the trail went cold and, eventually, the case took a backseat.

“Not much is known yet of Showkat Khan except that he eventually returned to Anantnag,” one investigator said. “But Altaf switched from place to place, and instead of returning to his Marhama village, settled in Bijbehara’s Baba Colony, where his family had ancestral property.” In Baba Colony, Sheikh allegedly established himself as a businessman, became a soft drink distributor and eventually opened a medical shop. “He was also president of the medical union here,” a

Keralam Cabinet swaps files for notebooks at IIM

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, September 4

IN A DAY and age where politics is seen as an almost 24x7 vocation, the 21-member Keralam Cabinet led by Chief Minister V D Satheesan has taken time out to pick up their pens and notepads, get back to the classroom, sit in on lectures, and soak up the lessons. If only for two days.

On Friday, Satheesan led his Cabinet colleagues back into the classroom at the Indian Institute of Management (IIM)-Kozhikode, where they will learn new tools of governance and listen to management experts. The two-day “Reimagining Keralam” strategic leadership workshop is expected to serve as a key platform for developing new ideas and policy interventions to make the state’s development journey more “people-centred, sustainable, knowledge-driven and technology-enabled”, government insiders said. It will also help strengthen collaboration between the academic sector and the government, according to the government.

In a post on X on Friday, Sa-



Chief Ministers V D Satheesan and others at the two-day ‘Reimagining Keralam’ event at IIM Kozhikode, on Friday. ANI

theesan wrote, “Good governance requires both responsive delivery today and strategic foresight for tomorrow. Keralam State Council of Ministers will convene at @IIMKozhikode for Reimagining Keralam, a dedicated two-day residential leadership retreat. From mastering transformational leadership in the era of AI to institutionalising community-level climate resilience, disaster

management and structural fiscal renewals, we are equipping our administration with cutting-edge, data-driven frameworks.”

Tourism Minister P C Vishnunadh said the lectures were interactive in nature and that governance and policy formulation were the major areas of discussion on Friday. The ministers were told how to nurture a team and make the team

members work. “In the new age, it is important to hear people before a policy is framed. In Keralam, hitherto the practice was to announce a policy and go ahead with a project for implementation. That approach would lead to protests. Today’s sessions highlighted the need for hearing people before a policy is framed,” Vishnunadh said.

State Minister for Labour, Women and Child Welfare Bindu Krishna, who posted photographs from inside the classroom, said, “Ministers have their doubts on many issues and we all raised questions. We had also filled out questionnaires. Developing leadership in this modern era with new tools like Artificial Intelligence (AI) were discussed. On governance, we were told to bring changes in many areas. The perspective on governance was presented with different models from the world as well as the country. We were told about how to popularise a new idea or project,” she said.

Industries Minister PK Kunhalikutty said this was the second such programme he had attended, recalling a similar initiative that the Oommen

Chandy government had taken in 2011. Kunhalikutty said the workshop would help improve coordination among ministers and provide an opportunity to share knowledge and experiences. Kunhalikutty said the ministers would also learn management skills and explore the use of AI and advanced technology in governance. “How can technology be used to bring a change in people’s lives? That is the subject. They will give us more theoretical knowledge, and we will share practical insights with them. By sharing mutually, that will be used to bring forth a new vision and new beginnings,” he said.

Among the other ministers who shared photographs and videos from the workshop are Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala, Health Minister K Muraliedharan, Higher Education Minister Roji M John, Excise Minister M Liju, and Transport Minister C P John.

On Day 1, the workshop formally kicked off with a session chaired by IIM Kozhikode’s Director, Professor Debashis Chatterjee, on “Transformational Leadership in the Age of AI: Engaging People with Purpose and Impact”.



Volunteers and relief workers prepare meals for flood-affected residents from Devighat at a temporary shelter home being run at a school in Nepal's Nuwakot district on Friday. PTI

275 Indians missing, 166 others rescued: MEA on Nepal floods

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 4

AT LEAST 275 Indians remained missing while 166 others were rescued following the devastating flash floods that struck the Nepal-Tibet border on August 26, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said on Friday.

As many as 1,907 Indian nationals have safely crossed over to Nepal from China, added the ministry.

MEA's official spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said that India has supplied around 95 tonnes of relief material to Nepal so far.

The death toll has risen to at least 1,295, after rescue workers recovered more bodies from affected areas, according to Nepalese authorities.

While over 12,000 people have been rescued, roughly 5,000 remain missing as search

and rescue operations continue.

"As per our information, 275 Indian nationals remain missing. We continue to be in close touch with the Nepali government," Jaiswal said.

"As per official sources in China, there are no Indian travellers stranded in the Tibetan Autonomous Region in China," he added.

Jaiswal further said, "We do plan to send more forensic kits, Bailey bridges and other materials that are requested by the government of Nepal. In addition to the relief material, we have sent 54 personnel to support relief and rescue efforts in Nepal. This comprises 30 tunnel rescue experts, 19 forensic experts, and a five-member medical team. Our rescue and forensic teams are deployed on the ground, and they are working closely with the Nepalese authorities."

Ganga above danger mark in Bihar, 33 rescue teams, 700 boats deployed

Himanshu Harsh
Patna, September 4

BIHAR GOVERNMENT has deployed 33 teams of the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) and State Disaster Response Force (SDRF) in flood-sensitive districts as rising water levels in several major rivers continue to affect parts of the state, the Disaster Management department said on Friday.

"Six NDRF and 27 SDRF teams have been positioned in vulnerable districts and are on round-the-clock standby for relief and rescue operations," an official said, adding that 693 government boats are also being operated across affected areas to facilitate movement and evacuation to safer locations.

According to officials, the Ganga is flowing above the danger mark at Digha and Gandhi Ghat in Patna Sadar, Hathidah in Mokama, as well as at Bhagalpur, Kahalgaon, Buxar and Munger. The Gandak is above the danger mark at Dumarima Ghat in Gopalganj's Sidhwalia and at Hajipur in Vaishali. The Kosi has crossed the danger mark at Baltara in Khagaria's Gogri and Kursela in Katihar. The Budhi Gandak is above the mark at Khagaria, while the Punpun is above it at Sripalpur in Patna and so is the Ghaghra at Darauli in Siwan.

"Despite the rising levels, continuous monitoring and administrative preparedness have helped contain the impact of the floods," claimed the official, adding that district administrations have been conducting relief operations, including running community kitchens and setting up relief camps.

On Friday, Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary conducted an aerial survey of the flood situation.



Partially submerged houses after the rise in Ganga water level, in Vaishali district on Friday. ANI

At a high-level meeting with officials, he further reviewed the flood situation, embankments and relief measures, directing officials to ensure timely delivery of relief and essential services to affected people.

District magistrates and superintendents of police in all affected districts were asked to remain in their jurisdictions, prepare lists of affected people, and provide immediate relief.

Officials were also directed to ensure uninterrupted food and other supplies through flood relief camps and community kitchens, maintain continuous surveillance of vulnerable and low-lying areas, and have the Water Resources department continuously monitor embankments from Buxar to Bhagalpur.

Community kitchens have been set up in Bhagalpur, Bhojpur, Patna, Vaishali and other districts.

Officials said light to moderate rainfall is forecast in the coming days.

Meanwhile, earlier this week, the state's Dairy, Fisheries and Animal Resources department advised people against consuming unidentified or unusual-appearing fish reaching Bihar along with the floodwaters from Nepal.

The advisory warned that "flood-displaced fish can become contaminated with bacteria, viruses and fungi after exposure to sewage, dead animals and other waste", and urged people to avoid fish caught from floodwaters until conditions stabilise.



An NDRF team evacuates residents from a waterlogged area of Pipauri village in Kanpur on Friday. ANI

Over a third of UP districts hit by floods

Press Trust of India
Lucknow, September 4

MORE THAN one-third of Uttar Pradesh's districts have been hit by floods, with relief measures underway in the affected areas, even as the water levels of the Ganga and other rivers continue to remain a concern, officials said on Friday.

According to the relief commissioner's office, around 3.53 lakh people have been affected by the floods in 26 districts. As many as 17,544 people have been moved to safer locations, while 4,847 people are staying in relief shelters. A total of 1,312 flood shelters have been set up across the state, while 1,634 flood outposts, 1,697 boats and motorboats and 1,068 medical

teams have been deployed in the affected areas, the government said in a statement.

The relief machinery has distributed 72,897 flood-relief packets and 3,67,551 lunch packets among the affected people. More than 5.52 lakh chlorine tablets and 1.87 lakh ORS packets have also been distributed as part of the health-and-sanitation measures.

The affected districts are Amroha, Ayodhya, Azamgarh, Badaun, Ballia, Barabanki, Basti, Chandauli, Farrukhabad, Ghazipur, Gonda, Gorakhpur, Hardoi, Kasganj, Kanpur, Lakhimpur Kheri, Mirzapur, Moradabad, Pilibhit, Prayagraj, Raebareli, Rampur, Sant Kabir Nagar, Shahjahanpur, Unnao and Varanasi.

Ashok Singhal's protégé to Ram Temple trust treasurer: Meet Mahesh Bhagchandka

Bhagchandka is the CEO of the M2K Group that is behind several real estate projects and multiplexes in Gurugram and Delhi

Vikas Pathak
New Delhi, September 4

AS THE Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust embarks on a new chapter under a new leadership team, looking to put the donation theft controversy behind it, one of the important faces is 68-year-old Delhi businessman Mahesh Bhagchandka, who has been appointed the Treasurer.

Bhagchandka is the CEO of the M2K Group that has business interests in "sunrise sectors such as biologicals, real estate and multiplexes ... M2K has already enriched the National Capital landscape with some of the best multiplexes and outstanding housing projects", according to its website. The group has built several residential apartment complexes in Gurugram, Delhi, and Dharuhera, along with commercial establishments such as shopping arcades and corporate parks.

Bhagchandka was born in



68-year-old Delhi businessman Mahesh Bhagchandka is a member of the World Hindu Economic Forum's executive committee. PIX CREDIT: M2K GROUP

Kolkata on August 1, 1958, and completed his BCom degree from Calcutta University.

He was associated with the installation of Ram stambhs (pillars) at 222 sites linked to the Shri Ram Van Gaman Yatra — the route that devotees believe Lord Ram took while proceeding to his exile — and also served as a yajman (host or patron) during the Ram Temple bhoomi puja (ground-breaking) and pran pratishtha (consecration) ceremonies.

Despite several attempts, The Indian Express could not reach Bhagchandka over the phone.

The businessman has long-standing ties with the Sangh Parivar, with Vishwa Hindu Parishad leader Ashok Singhal serving as his mentor.

When a book on Singhal's life was released in 2015 in the presence of then Union Home

Minister Rajnath Singh and RSS sarsangchalak Mohan Bhagwat, Bhagchandka paid tribute to his mentor.

"Mr Ashok Singhal's contributions are very important in the present structure of the VHP. I remember the Boat Club campaign held in 1991.

Approximately 25 lakh people from all over the world joined the campaign and shouted, 'We swear to Lord Rama, we will construct the Rama temple there only'," Bhagchandka said.

The businessman extolled Singhal's contributions to helping the country move "towards a new direction" and said the VHP leader's name would be "written in golden words as the greatest leader of Hinduism".

Bhagchandka is associated with the Ashok Singhal Foundation and is also a member of the World Hindu Economic Forum's executive committee. His association with the Singhal Foundation is significant in the context of the Ram temple movement and Singhal's prominent role in it.

Prabhat Kumar of Prabhat Prakashan, which published the book on Singhal, told The Indian Express that Bhagchandka's closeness to Singhal was typical of the relationship in the Sangh Parivar between mentors and those they take under their wings. "It becomes even closer than one's own family sometimes," Kumar said, describing Bhagchandka as a "committed social worker with nationalist views".

EXPRESS special

Fake IAS officer dupes many in MP, 'Vidhan Sabha' vlog lands her in jail

Police say the woman used her fake identity to collect money from people

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, September 4

THE VLOG opens with a young woman in a pink saree and a white blouse, looking confidently into the front camera. "We have come here to attend the Madhya Pradesh Vidhan Sabha. Since they don't allow photography inside, we decided to film this outside," she giggles, and tilts the camera to show her companions. Another woman in pink and white and one in a red saree come into the frame. "Looking at our antics, no one can tell we are IAS officers," says the latter. All three laugh.

None of it, as it turns out, was true. The women were not IAS officers; the video, too, was not filmed where they claimed it was. Bhopal Police investigation traced its location to a gallery inside the Anthropological Museum complex rather than the Assembly itself.

The two women in pink featured in the video would later tell the police that they were asked to act like IAS officers by the woman in the red saree. She was later identified as Tripti Singh Rajput.

As police began investigating the matter, they learnt that it was not confined to a harm-



Tripti Singh Rajput used a photo taken in Mussoorie, showing her holding a trophy with a "training centre" building visible behind her.

less reel meant to only chase social media clout. Rajput used her fake identity, of an IAS officer working as the Additional Director in the Madhya Pradesh Tourism Department, to collect money from people with the promise of government jobs, tourism-property leases, and access to officials.

Police in Ashoknagar and Bhopal have registered three FIRs against her. She was arrested on August 23, by Chanderi police in Ashoknagar district, along with her brother Sudhanshu Singh. Police say they laid a trap in which they asked the victims, who had allegedly paid for government jobs, to lure the siblings to Chanderi.

The two women featured in the video claim they, too, were victims of the fraud.

DCP Bhopal Vikas Kumar Sahwal told The Indian Express, "They have alleged that Rajput took Rs 3 lakh from each

of them with a promise to make them IAS officers like her."

DCP Sahwal said Rajput's husband, too, has claimed that she pretended to be an IAS officer — a reason why he said he married her. "They are going through a domestic dispute," the DCP added.

When Madhya Pradesh police searched Rajput's home in Bhopal, they uncovered how the 30-year-old set up the illusion that helped her pass off as an IAS officer for a long time.

The police seized purported government identity cards and letterheads, joining documents, trophies and mementoes inscribed with descriptions of her as a trainee IAS officer, and a Toyota Innova bearing a strip marked "Government of India".

The case that first brought Rajput to police's attention began in Chanderi. According to the police, she arrived on April 7, 2025, with her brother and two associates, who checked into Kila Kothi — an MP Tourism-run hotel. Here, police said, Rajput introduced herself as an Additional Director in the state's Tourism Department and began speaking to local residents about government employment.

Four men came to believe she could secure them positions in the Ministry of Human Resource Development. The price: Rs 3 lakh per person. "According to their complaint, the four handed over Rs 9.80 lakh in cash along with their original documents, with a further Rs 2 lakh due once the jobs came through. When the jobs did not

materialise, the men began to question who Rajput actually was," said a senior police officer.

She has been booked for cheating and personation under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS). Investigators have also invoked Section 61(2), criminal conspiracy, and subsequently, Section 238, concerning concealment or destruction of evidence, after original documents allegedly could not be found.

Police are investigating how the fake documents were collected.

Ashoknagar Superintendent of Police Rajiv Kumar Mishra said, "We have identified two people who allegedly prepared the fake documents and other materials and supplied them to Rajput. We are investigating the possible involvement of other people in the case."

Investigators are also examining a laptop from which files were allegedly deleted before Rajput's arrest. Phone records and financial transactions are also being examined alongside the laptop as police try to reconstruct the network behind the case.

Among the paraphernalia that Rajput used to fleece her victims was a photograph taken in Mussoorie, showing her holding a trophy with a "training centre" building visible behind her, police said.

"A fake CBI identity card was also among the items recovered from her Bhopal residence. We are investigating whether this was made with the help of AI," the officer said.

Rajasthan: Tribal woman stripped, assaulted; her husband among seven arrested

Hamza Khan
Jaipur, September 4

A 40-YEAR-OLD tribal woman was assaulted and stripped on the street in Rajasthan's Banswara district, and her head was tonsured, allegedly by her family members who "doubted her character."

The incident took place on September 1. A video of the incident that went viral on Thursday shows the woman being assaulted and stripped, mainly by other women, even as some others are seen laughing and recording videos.

Banswara Deputy Superintendent of Police (DSP) Babu Lal Regar said the police have arrested seven persons, including the woman's husband.

Reportedly, the woman was first made to walk barefoot by her husband and others. Eventually, she was tonsured and assaulted by several persons. In one of the videos, women are seen pulling and tearing apart her clothes while beating her with sticks as others, including children, stood watching.

DSP Regar said that they are investigating the video. "Although the video went viral on September 3, an FIR had been lodged on September 1 itself. There was a disagreement between the woman and the husband," he said.

Meanwhile, Congress state president Govind Singh Dotasra said, "The Banswara incident, which brings shame to Rajasthan, is openly tearing to shreds all claims of humanity, respect for women, and law and order."

Pune Municipal Corporation

Tender Cell Health Department

Tender Advertisement - New

Sr.No.	Particulars	Date
1	Tender Form Sale Period	05/09/2026 to 18/09/2026 Up to 14.30 p.m.
2	Tender Form Receiving Period	05/09/2026 to 18/09/2026 Up to 14.30 p.m.
3	Bid Submission End Date	18/09/2026 at 14.30 p.m.
4	Tender Opening Date	21/09/2026 at 15.00 p.m.

Tender No	Department Name	Name Of Work	Tender Fees	B1/ B2	Emd Amt.	Period of Work	For Tender Purpose Contact Person Name and Mobile No
PMC/Health/02 2026-27	Health	Upgradation of late. Rajmata Jijau Hospital, Mitra mandal chowk, Late. Jayabai Nanasaheb Sutar Hospital, kotharud, Late. Sakharam Kundalik Kodre Hospital, Mundhawa, Late. Draupadabai khedekar Hospital, Bopodi OT, Labour Unit & Women Ward along with Installation Testing ,commissioning of equipments on turnkey basis a period of 12 Months.	29679/-	B2	1%	12 Months	020-25501491

Sd/- (Dr.Sunil Andhale)
Medical officer
Pune Municipal Corporation

Sd/- (Dr. Suryakant Deokar)
Asst. Medical Officer Of Health
Pune Municipal Corporation

Sd/- (Dr.Nina Borade)
Medical Officer Of Health
Pune Municipal Corporation

Advt No.-3/724
Date : 4/9/2026

Ladakh clears new 'nautor land' regularisation rules, paves way for grant of proprietary rights

Press Trust of India
Leh, Jammu, September 4

LADAKH LIEUTENANT Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena on Friday approved the regularisation rules of 'nautor lands', paving the way for the grant of proprietary rights of eligible barren land and resolving a long-pending issue concerning thousands of landholders in the Union Territory.

Nautor land refers to barren or wasteland owned by the government and historically allotted to individuals for cultivation or other productive purposes. More than 60,000 acres of land in Ladakh is presently recorded in revenue records as nautor holdings.

The new rules in Ladakh Autonomous Hill Development Councils (Nautor Regularisation) Rules, 2026, provide a comprehensive framework for granting proprietary rights of up to 10 acres of eligible nautor land to occupants across all seven districts of Ladakh, an official spokesperson said.

Nautor land beyond the 10-acre limit may be allotted on a leasehold basis.

"The rules introduce a one-time regularisation mechanism for nautor land occupied before October 27, 2020, the date on which the JK tenancy Act, 1980 was repealed. Any possession of such land after the cut-off date

will not be eligible for regularisation," he said.

The framework also vests the authority to allot nautor land with the Ladakh Autonomous Hill Development Council (LAHDCs) in all seven districts.

"Under Section 42 of the Ladakh Autonomous Hill Development Councils Act, 1997, land within the district stands transferred to the Council, while clause (i) of Section 23 vests executive powers in the Council in relation to the allotment, use and occupation of land vested in it," the rules state.

Saxena said the rules seek to strike a balance between pro-

tecting the legitimate interests of genuine nautor landholders and safeguarding public and Council land from encroachment and unauthorised claims.

"For generations, our people have worked hard to bring barren and waste land under cultivation in one of the most challenging agricultural environments in the country," the lieutenant governor said.

"These rules provide a transparent and uniform mechanism to address this long-pending issue and give legal certainty to genuine holders. It will also enable such land to be utilised as a financial asset, including for availing bank loans," he added.

UTTAM KUMAR CENTENARY CELEBRATIONS

From screen icon to collective memory, Bengal remembers its greatest cine star

Sweetie Kumari
Kolkata, September 4

AS BENGAL marks the birth centenary of film legend Uttam Kumar, tributes have poured in from all walks of life, as political leaders, film stars and admirers from different generations have come together to remember the man, popularly known as *Mahanayak* (mega star) and to reflect on his contribution to cinema.

For the Bengali film fraternity, speaking about Uttam Kumar is also an acknowledgement of a giant whose influence continues to shape the industry. Actor Rituparna Sengupta said Uttam Kumar remains as relevant today as he was during his lifetime. Speaking on the centenary celebrations, she said, “The greatest actor should have been celebrated like this. And 100 years is a big thing...I am a member of the core committee and we have exchanged ideas. And the good thing is that the government is open to ideas.”

Actor Jeet spoke about the deep emotional connection Bengal continues to share with the cine star, “...Uttam Kumar was not merely an actor or a Mahanayak; he was an emotion for Bengal. I am extremely happy because he belongs to our fraternity; seeing a member of our fraternity celebrated in this manner is a wonderful thing”.

BJP MLA and actor Rudranil Ghosh said how Uttam Kumar's memory remains etched in the cultural memory of Bengal. “...for some people, work is worship... Maybe that is why, even after so many years of his passing, he remains in everyone's heart. Day before yesterday and today, even the Prime Minister remembered Uttam Kumar...”

Speaking to *The Indian Express*, Gourab Chatterjee, actor and grandson of Uttam Kumar said, “He is more of a legend to me. He is someone who inspired me to enter this industry. I feel fortunate and grateful to him. I appreciate the people who are



A poster shows Uttam Kumar and Sharmila Tagore from Satyajit Ray's classic *Nayak*, in Kolkata on Friday. PARTHA PAUL

organising these commemorative events, but personally, I don't enjoy attending them. That's my personal stance. I feel my grandfather would have been happier seeing me on a film set shooting, rather than attending an event dedicated to him.”

“From what I've heard at home, he was a calm and composed person much like I am and completely dedicated to his craft... I don't think my grandfather would have become the legend he is if everything hadn't aligned so perfectly at that time...All these incredible artistes came together in the same era... A single person can never achieve something like that alone, it takes a team,” Chatterjee said.

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma shared how the legend's charm crossed state borders, “... On his birth centenary, I pay tribute to this towering

legend of Indian cinema. His bond with Dr. Bhupen Hazarika remains a beautiful chapter in our cultural history. Their association began with the film *Jiban Trishna*, for which Bhupen Da composed the music and gave us the timeless '*Sagar Sangame Satar Ketchi Kato*'. Their professional association grew into a deep friendship and brotherhood. Uttam Kumar's assurance to Bhupen Da during a difficult period, “You have a brother here in Calcutta. My door is always open,” speaks volumes about their bond,” Sarma said.

“...Uttam Kumar shared the screen with Assam's Mahanayak Biju Phukan in *Hotel Snow Fox*. Biju Phukan, the quintessential romantic hero of Assamese cinema, was to Assam what Uttam Kumar was to Bengal.. Their legacy continues to live beyond the boundaries of states and generations,” Sarma wrote on X.

CM lays foundation of film centre named after actor

Atri Mitra
Kolkata, September 4

WEST BENGAL Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari laid the foundation stone of the Uttam Kumar Film Centre near Eco Park in the New Town area in Kolkata on Friday as part of its year-long celebrations marking the birth centenary of Bengali film legend Uttam Kumar.

The state government has allocated Rs 25 crore for the project, which will have two theatres with a seating capacity of 750 each and another with 1,000 seats. The Centre will also house laboratories and studios for animation and visual effects, besides facilities for film post-production.

Actors Ranjit Mallick, Prosenjit Chatterjee, and Jisshu Sengupta, film director Harnath Chakraborty, along with BJP MLAs Rupa Ganguly, Rudranil Ghosh and veteran actor and BJP leader Mithun Chakraborty were present at the event.

After laying the foundation stone, they also paid tribute to the late actor. “The work on the film centre will begin soon. From time to time, people from the film industry will review the progress,” Adhikari said.

On Thursday, at the open-air stage at the Nandan theatre complex, the CM had inaugurated an event marking the birth centenary of Uttam Kumar.

Belgian PM takes a dig at ‘arbitrary’ tariffs, praises FTA

Alok Deshpande
Mumbai, September 4

BELGIAN PRIME Minister Bart De Wever on Friday took a veiled swipe at US President Donald Trump's tariff policy, mocking countries that impose trade barriers “arbitrarily” and arguing that the India-EU Free Trade Agreement would help the two economies withstand economic disruption and coercion.

“More and more voices today are calling for barriers to go up, for markets to be shut off, for tariffs to be imposed. Some do this entirely arbitrarily. They decide something on Monday, they revoke it on Wednesday,” De Wever said at the India-Belgium high-level dialogue on the India-EU FTA in Mumbai.

“I am not going to say the name, but you know these people who do it arbitrarily, without any economic logic at all,” he said while addressing Indian and Belgian business representatives.

De Wever said such policies “deliberately and structurally distort markets” and inflict economic damage on trade partners by seeking to make them dependent. “These strategies of protectionism and unfair competition put our world economy and our geopolitical stability under strain,” he said.

He also announced that a delegation comprising companies from Belgium's port, ter-



Belgian Prime Minister Bart De Wever, Union Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal and Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis at the 'India-Belgium High-Level Dialogue' in Mumbai on Friday. ANI

minal, logistics, chemical and energy sectors would visit India in February 2027 to firm up business opportunities.

‘Win-win agreement’

Minister of Commerce and Industry, Piyush Goyal, in his address, described India-EU FTA as a “win-win agreement” that would open opportunities for farmers, start-ups and women entrepreneurs while protecting sensitive sectors on both sides.

“India and Belgium have a choice to be swept by the chaos or build trust and cooperation. We chose to build, connect and work together. Belgian and Indian economies complement each other,” Goyal said.

Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnis pitched the state as the preferred destination for

Belgian investment. “If Belgian companies are looking at India for investment after the FTA, come to Maharashtra,” Fadnis said, highlighting the state's manufacturing ecosystem.

He said Belgium-Maharashtra projects should be fast-tracked and offered dedicated teams to work with prospective investors. “Come to Maharashtra and from here serve India and the world. Maharashtra is volunteering to convert strategic direction into action,” he said.

The dialogue at the Jio World Convention Centre was jointly organised by Port of Antwerp-Bruges, the Belgian PM's Chancellery, Belgium's Federal Public Service Foreign Affairs, Flanders Investment & Trade and the Consulate-General of Belgium in Mumbai.

Reached Moon, but not free from caste evil: HC

Omkar Gokhale
Mumbai, September 4

THE BOMBAY High Court observed recently that while “we boast about reaching the other side of the Moon”, some are being made to do work “below human dignity” due to the “social evil of the caste system” that, it said, is still being followed in India. The HC made these observations while noting the deaths of sanitation workers engaged in manual scavenging.

The court also set aside a portion of the December 2019 and April 2025 Government Resolutions, saying they discriminated against sanitation workers employed with private establishments under private contractors by paying them lower compensation than those employed by the state government and its undertakings. A bench of Justices Bharati H Dangre and Manjusha A Deshpande passed the ruling on August 13, as reported by *The Indian Express*.

“In the 21st Century, we boast about reaching the other side of the Moon, yet the hard reality that stares us in the face is that the social evil of the caste system is still followed in our country...even after 75 years of adopting the Constitution, our Country is not free from the social evil that has haunted us for ages,” Justice Deshpande, who authored the verdict for the bench, noted.

Police detachment disappearing: SC judge on Jantar Mantar action

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, September 4

SUPREME COURT judge Justice Ujjal Bhuyan on Friday expressed concern over the alleged assault of protesters by police personnel during the recent NEET students' protest at Jantar Mantar, saying the detachment expected of police officers appears to be disappearing.

Speaking at the launch of former secretary (security) Yashovardhan Azad's book 'Policing the Republic', Justice Bhuyan said, “All of us are dismayed when we see young officers of the Indian Police Service personally going and assaulting protesters and demonstrators. This is something very, very distressing to observe.”

“The detachment expected of police officers somehow seems to be disappearing, and this is indeed a matter of grave concern,” he added.

The book launch was held at Viceroy Hall in the national capital. Congress MPP Chidambaram, former Maharashtra DGP D Sivanandhan and others were present at the event.

Justice Bhuyan said that effective policing could be done without resorting to the excessive use of force or infringement of human rights.

“For most common people, a policeman on the street wearing a whistle and a lathi represents the power and authority of the state. When they feel wronged, they seek the help of the police. It is, therefore, of utmost importance that the police force maintains its credibility,” he said.

“It can do so only by strictly adhering to the Constitution, by functioning as a truly professional force, acting impartially, displaying courage and acting with conviction, maintaining integrity and adhering to secular principles, thereby upholding the rule of law,” he added.

Justice Bhuyan also pointed out that “if the functionaries of



Justice Ujjal Bhuyan

the government become law-breakers, it is bound to breed contempt for the law and will encourage lawlessness.”

Moving to the issue of extrajudicial killings or “fake encounters”, the judge said the Supreme Court had taken a serious view of such incidents.

Referring to a 2011 judgment, Justice Bhuyan said the court had held that fake encounters “nullify the very essence of the rule of law” and observed that when a fake encounter is proved against a serving policeman in a trial, it must be treated with the utmost seriousness.

“Encounter philosophy is a criminal philosophy. It cannot be a part of policing,” he said.

He also spoke about the need for police reforms and the dangers of political interference in the functioning of the police.

The judge also referred to the chapter on Manipur in 'Policing the Republic', describing the state as exceptionally rich in talent and culture but expressing concern over the continuing violence there.

Despite the extensive presence of security forces, including the state police, Manipur Rifles, Assam Rifles, paramilitary forces and the Army, “peace continues to remain elusive” in the state, Justice Bhuyan said.

“There is a lesson for all of us. There is a lesson for India,” he said, referring to the violence in Manipur.

Fugitive wanted by FBI for \$600K fraud held in Punjab

Man Aman Singh Chhina
Chandigarh, September 4

PUNJAB POLICE has arrested an India-born US citizen wanted by the Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI) for a \$600,000 fraud in Washington. The FBI had announced a \$150,000 reward for information leading to Manjit Singh Bedi's arrest.

Punjab's Director General of Police Gaurav Yadav said on Friday that Jalandhar Police has caught Bedi.

According to FBI, Bedi is a naturalised US citizen: someone who was born outside the US and became a citizen through a formal process.

Bedi, the FBI alleged, defrauded the US government out of at least \$600,000 between March 2024 and June 2025.

An FBI release said Bedi operated a small grocery store,



Manjit Singh Bedi. FBI DIRECTOR KASH PATEL/X

named Asian Grocery Store, in Tacoma, Washington. He reportedly sold food to beneficiaries of the Supplemental Nutrition and Assistance Program (SNAP) through their Electronic Benefit Transfer (EBT) cards. SNAP is a US government scheme that provides low-in-

come individuals and families financial aid to buy food.

It added that instead of selling SNAP participants food through their EBT cards, Bedi allegedly swiped the cards and gave them cash, keeping half the proceeds for himself.

“After being indicted for wire fraud and SNAP benefits fraud, Bedi was allowed to appear in court without being arrested. He was ordered to give up his passport and remain in Washington state,” the FBI said.

“However, Bedi soon drove across the border to Canada and then fled to India. On May 21, 2026, a federal arrest warrant was issued for Bedi in the United States District Court, Western District of Washington, Tacoma, Washington, after he was charged with Violations of Conditions of Supervision,” it added.

STATE BANK OF INDIA, Stressed Assets Management Branch-1
12th Floor, Jawahar Vyapar Bhawan (STC Building), 1, Tolstoy Marg, Janpath, New Delhi-110001,
Ph. No. : 011-23701070, 23701097, 23701157, 23701167, 23701195, Fax No. 23701202. E-mail ID : team1samb1.del@sbi.co.in, sbi.04109@sbi.co.in

E-Auction Sale Notice

APPENDIX- IV-A" [See Proviso to Rule 8(6)]

Sale notice for sale of Immovable Property

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002

read with proviso to Rule 8 (6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described movable property hypothecated/charged & Immovable Property mortgaged/charged to the Secured Creditors, the Physical possession of which has been taken by the Authorized Officer of State Bank of India, Secured Creditor, will be sold on "As is where is", "As is what is" and Whatever there is" on below mentioned dates, for recovery of amount as mentioned below, due to the Secured Creditors from following Borrower(s), Guarantor(s) and Corporate Guarantor(s). The reserve price and earnest money to be deposited is mentioned below respectively.

Name of Borrower(s), Guarantor(s) and Corporate Guarantor(s) with address/es	Description & owner(s) of properties	Reserve Price(RP) EMD Amount 10% of The Reserve Price Incremental Amount	Recovery Amount as per Demand Notice	Date / Time of on-site Inspection of Property with name of Authorized Officer	Date & Time for Submission of Bid Application Form, KYC Documents, PAN Card, Proof of EMD etc. through M/S PSB ALLIANCE (BAANKNET)	Date & Time of E-Auction
M/s Auto Décor Private Limited (Borrower) Flat No. 226 C-7, Naveen Niketan New Delhi India 110016	Industrial land and building 16-21, Mini Industrial Estate, Kichha, Village Kishanpur Dist Udhham Singh Nagar, Uttarakhand admeasuring 1122 sq mtr in name of M/s Auto Décor (Partnership Firm). Landmark – behind Nalanda Sr. Secondary School, On the East by : Gali and Plot No. 22,23,24 On the West by : Plot No. 15 On the North by : Agricultural Land On the South by : 9 mtrs. wide road. (Under Physical Possession)	Rs. 3,93,00,000/- Rs. 39,30,000/- Rs. 5,00,000/-	Rs. 37,83,14,335.31 (Thirty Seven crore Eighty Three Lakhs Fourteen Thousand Three Hundred Thirty Five and thirty-one paise only) as on 31.03.2014 with future interest and incidental charges w.e.f 01.04.2014 till date.	18.09.2026 11:30 AM to 01:00 PM	Refer to https://baanknet.com	23.09.2026 (Wednesday) From 11.00 AM to 01.00 PM with unlimited extensions of 10 minutes each

EMD to be transferred / deposited by bidders in his / her / their own wallet provided by M/S PSB ALLIANCE (BAANKNET) on its E-Auction site https://baanknet.com

TERMS AND CONDITIONS :
E-Auction is being held on "AS IS WHERE IS", "AS IS WHAT IS" AND "WHATEVER THERE IS" basis and will be conducted "On Line".
The E-Auction will be conducted through link https://baanknet.com on 23.09.2026. Terms and Conditions of Sale are given in the https://baanknet.com hereinafter. Other than this, the terms of service of e-Auction Service Provider (M/S PSB ALLIANCE (BAANKNET)) will have to be complied with by the Bidders.
Interested bidder may deposit Pre-Bid EMD with M/S PSB ALLIANCE (BAANKNET) before the close of e-Auction. Credit of Pre-Bid EMD shall be given to the bidder only after receipt of payment in M/S PSB ALLIANCE (BAANKNET) Bank account and updation of such information in the e-auction website. This may take some time as per banking process and hence bidders, in their own interest, are advised to submit the pre-bid EMD amount well in advance to avoid any last minute problem.
To the best of knowledge and information of the Authorised Officer, there is no encumbrance on the properties. However, the intending bidders should make their own independent inquiries regarding the encumbrances, title of properties put on auction and claims / rights / dues / affecting the properties, prior to submitting their bid. In this regard, the e-Auction advertisement does not constitute and will not be deemed to constitute any commitment or any representation of the Bank.
The successful bidder shall deposit 25% of sale price, after adjusting the EMD already paid, immediately, i.e. on the same day or not later than next working day, as the case may be, after the acceptance of the offer by the Authorised Officer, failing which the earnest money deposited by the bidder shall be forfeited. The Balance 75% of the sale price is payable on or before the 15th day of confirmation of sale of the secured asset or such extended period as may be agreed upon in writing between the Secured Creditor and the e-Auction purchaser not exceeding three months from the date of e-Auction. The Authorised Officer / Secured Creditor shall not be responsible in any way for any third party claims / rights / dues. The successful bidder has to bear all the statutory dues, if any, and also applicable tax liabilities related to the auction purchase. The sale shall be subject to rules/ conditions prescribed under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and Income Tax/GST regulations, wherever applicable. The other terms and conditions of the e-auction are published in the following website: https://baanknet.com

STATUTORY SALE NOTICE UNDER THE SARFAESI ACT, 2002

Date : 01.09.2026, Place : New Delhi

Sd/- Authorised Officer, State Bank of India

राष्ट्रीय औषधीय शिक्षा एवं अनुसंधान संस्थान गुवाहाटी
NATIONAL INSTITUTE OF PHARMACEUTICAL
EDUCATION AND RESEARCH GUWAHATI
Department of Pharmaceuticals, Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, Gov. of India

VACANCY NOTICE
Employment Notification No. 04/2026
National Institute of Pharmaceutical Education and Research (NIPER) Guwahati invites applications for the post of Secretary to Registrar on regular basis from eligible Indian Nationals.

Date & time of commencement of Online Applications	21-08-2026 from 11:00 AM
Last date & time of Online Application & Payment of Fees	19-09-2026 up to 5:00 PM
Last date for receipt of hard copy of the online application along with all enclosures	26-09-2026 up to 5:00 PM

For detailed qualifications and other requirements, please visit the institute website: www.niperguwahati.ac.in
Sd/- Registrar i/c

Maharashtra Airport Development Company Ltd.
CIN: U45203MH2002SGC136979

TENDER NOTICE
MADC Invite Request for proposals (RFP) from eligible Airline operators to provide Air connectivity services on Sindhudurg (Chipli) - Navi Mumbai route on basis of Regional Connectivity scheme (RCS)- (UDAN) (2nd Call)
The detailed tender can be seen /downloaded from the website www.mahatenders.gov.in from 05/09/2026 from 11.00 Hrs
Sd/-
Vice Chairman & Managing Director, MADC

epaper.indianexpress.com

CHOCOLATE WITH CAPSICUM? DATA IS CHANGING THE FOOD WE EAT

Only an intrepid chef would mix bacon and banana. Or crab and coffee. MADHURITA GOSWAMI explores the world of computational gastronomy, where molecular biology, data and AI help users discover unlikely flavour pairings, besides helping with personalised nutrition and sustainable food



DON'T FORGET to try something new!" is the motto that drives Bessararov Grigorii, 31, a chef-mixologist at Dubai's Frank Meat & Taps, whether he is mixing cocktails for guests or experimenting with food in the kitchen. It is this impulse that led him to the FlavorDB database in 2023, after he came across an Instagram reel featuring it as a culinary tool. Since then, the database has led him to serve flavour combinations he had not explored before.

FlavorDB is an open-access digital database that maps food ingredients by the flavour molecules they share, paving the way for exploring culinary combinations that might otherwise go untried. Think capsicum and chocolate. Bizarre as that may seem, both ingredients share flavour molecules — volatile chemical compounds that contribute to the taste and aroma — and, consequently, pair well should someone decide to put them together in a recipe.

The database, developed by a research team led by Dr Ganesh Bagler of the Indraprastha Institute of Information Technology, is one of the many applications of computational gastronomy, an emerging science that brings together molecular biology, data science and artificial intelligence.

From mixologists like Grigorii who like playing around with flavours to conscious consumers of food, who weigh their calories and measure their carbon footprint, and those who seek personalised meal plans for health reasons — computational gastronomy promises applications tailored to varied needs.

Vodka & biscuits. It's a match!

Among the most curious combinations Grigorii has discovered are lemon and white chocolate, pineapple and snow peas, and, what he swears by, bourbon, bacon and banana. "People are used to flat, obvious combinations... The database gives me non-obvious pairings at the level of shared aroma molecules, so I'll serve a guest something like pea-pineapple. It surprises them and sells really well," he says, on a video call from his home in Russia's St Petersburg.

Using FlavorDB, Grigorii says, requires both an understanding of how the database works and a chef's imagination to translate its suggestions into something appealing.

That, says Associate Professor Andrea Vitaletti of the Computer Science department at Rome's Sapienza University, is ultimately the point of computational gastronomy: "generating insights that help experts reflect on and better understand their own intuitions and judgments" on food.

Bagler's database contains 936 food ingredients (coffee, egg, chamomile, and berry wine, among many others), each containing flavour molecules of its own. That's nearly 26,000 flavour molecules in all. Users of his application can find what pairs best with, say, coffee, by clicking on it, which then reveals the different ingredients with which coffee has molecular overlaps, thus helping discover untested pairings. For instance, coffee has 269 flavour molecules and capsicum has 218, and they share 78 of them. Who would have thought that coffee also shares flavour molecules with crab, and is waiting for a chef to toss them together in a recipe?

The potential of untested recipes is what caught Grigorii's attention. Though he is now on vacation in St Petersburg, he has been unable to resist the pull of the city's food scene and has taken up work as a barback at Arka Bar. He rues Russians' tendency to choose vodka almost every time, but also calls vodka "the greatest" spirit for mixing with different ingredients. He recently discovered that biscuit shares 95 flavour molecules with vodka, and he now wants to infuse vanilla vodka with biscuit and make the twist for it. What

• What is computational gastronomy?

Computational gastronomy uses computing, data science and AI to study food — from the chemical compounds that create flavour to the ingredients, recipes and combinations that shape cuisines, helping analyse patterns in what we eat and look for ways to modify it

• How is it being used?

DISCOVERING NEW FLAVOUR COMBINATIONS:

Every food ingredient has flavour molecules of its own. These are volatile chemical compounds that contribute to its taste and aroma. For instance, coffee has 269 flavour molecules. Using AI and network analysis, one can see if coffee shares a significant number of flavour molecules with, say, capsicum. According to food hypothesis, food with overlapping chemical profiles taste good together. Turns out, coffee and capsicum share 78 flavour molecules. Which means, they are waiting for a chef to use some imagination to put them together

DEVELOPING PERSONALISED MEALS:

Computational models can design recipes based on flavour, nutrition and individual dietary requirements or preferences

REDUCING FOOD'S ENVIRONMENTAL FOOTPRINT:

Data on ingredients, recipes and their environmental impact can help identify and design food that retain desirable taste and nutritional properties while reducing emissions



SCAN THE QR CODE FOR FOOD QUIZZES

excites him about such experimentation is "how little by little, I'm shifting the guest's own sense of what actually goes together."

If curiosity drew Grigorii to FlavorDB, nostalgia was the driving force behind Shantanu Patil, a food entrepreneur from Barshi in Solapur, Maharashtra. His company, All Sow Great, manufactures millet-based products, including chivda, cookies and flakes.

Patil, who studied Environmental Food Entrepreneurship in Scotland, wanted to recreate memories of the food he enjoyed while growing up in the 1990s. His idea was simple: "Today's fathers would want to introduce their children to the flavours that they once loved."

He had grown up with a fascination for Parle-G Kismi maida biscuits and wanted to recreate the experience with ragi, considering that using local ingredients reduces carbon footprint. What he particularly wanted in his biscuits was the flavour of raisins that his favourite childhood snack had. He could have simply added raisins, but that would have cost more, making it difficult to reach a wider market.

Another challenge, he says, was "how to mask the muddy taste of ragi with flavours that customers will want to come back to; any flavour will go well with maida cookies, but it is different for millets".

He used Bagler's database and eventually found that baked ragi, when paired with cardamom or elaichi oil, gave the raisin flavour he wanted.

While baking ragi, its natural carbohydrates and amino acids undergo Maillard reactions, producing sweet, caramel and malty flavour compounds. The cardamom oil adds floral and citrus notes to this malty base, helping create the sensory experience Patil craved. He has since successfully marketed the resultant product.

Most importantly, says Patil, "10 trials *karne ka zaroorat nahi hua* (I didn't have to do multiple trials)."

For a small business such as Patil's, investing in research and development or hiring consultants — who may have charged Rs 20,000-25,000 to analyse an existing product, such as the Parle biscuits — can substantially increase costs. While "digging around" for an alternative, he came across Bagler's paper on FlavorDB.

Every molecule tells a story

For Grigorii, computational gastronomy is "the next layer" in the evolution of food. "Science and gastronomy change the industry one way or another — just think of sous-vide," he says, referring to a culinary technique where food is sealed in an airtight plastic bag and cooked in a precisely controlled warm water bath, helping chefs achieve consistent textures in meat, fish and vegetables. "The technique showed up in restaurants back in the mid-70s, and what used to feel like something magical is now an everyday tool," he says.

Food science can be empowering for chefs, Grigorii says, because "even the most ordinary guest eventually gets tired of the same thing and votes with their money for the unexpected".

Besides its use in throwing up new flavour pairings, computational gastronomy has expanded the idea of food as a vehicle for health benefits. Exploring this intersection, Bagler's team has developed SpiceRx, another digital database that maps spices to their reported health impacts and could support therapeutic approaches to meal planning. For instance, it shares the benefits of ginger against nausea, which more than a hundred research articles have reported.

Research into food that is not only tasty but also nutritious is currently exploding, with personalised meal planning gaining traction. "Meal planning today is not only about looking at ingredients or their calorie content, but also breaking them down into their molecular components and mapping their health impacts. Then, by looking at a person's blood work or genetic information, a personalised meal plan can be designed," says Navya Sharma, who works with Bagler's team.

The next frontier for Bagler's team is food that is also sustainable, for which they have developed SustainableFoodDB to map the carbon footprint of dishes.

"Imagine designing new food that has a desirable flavour profile, using ingredients like white sorghum that is known to be climate-resilient, or with local and seasonal ingredients that have a smaller carbon footprint. A futuristic scenario is that consumers — just like they now check the price or caloric content or whether the dish is vegan — will also look at the carbon footprint of a recipe before making a choice," he says.

But gaps in digital databases make such labels difficult to produce accurately. "The

traceability of ingredients is missing. Does the olive oil in a dish come from Europe or Egypt? Depending on that, its carbon footprint changes," Bagler explains.

He adds that his lab is also using machine learning to predict how different molecules might taste, including how sweet, bitter or savoury.

One question the researchers are trying to answer is whether AI can predict how sweet a molecule will be simply from its chemical structure. If it can, Bagler says, the possibilities are enormous.

At a time when multinational companies are seeking alternatives to sugar, such research could eventually influence the formulation of foods and beverages.

Several limitations, however, remain. "It is still difficult to capture the taste of an ingredient; only a coarse approximation is made," Bagler says. An ingredient's flavour, he adds, can also change depending on how it is prepared, whether it is boiled or roasted, etc. Finer details on raw ingredients are missing as well. He explains with a question: "Our database lists the taste of chilli broadly, but what about the distinctive tastes of Guntur chillies, Bhut Jolokia and Kolhapuri mirchi?"

Stock up, build the database

The challenge for scientists of computational gastronomy is not only to expand the existing food databases but also to incorporate the enormous diversity of ingredients, preparation methods and regional food traditions.

This is particularly true in the context of India, where much of people's food is missing from digital databases. "In the West, there are large databases of dishes with the exact nutritional value, complete with calorie counts and exact portions of nutrients and micronutrients. But there is very little data for Indian ingredients and dishes. The Indian Food Composition Table, published by ICMR, has detailed information for 528 raw food items only. The Indian Nutrient Database, built by research teams, expands this to cover 1,095 individual food items and 1,014 commonly consumed Indian recipes only," says Lipika Dey, Computer Science professor at Ashoka University.

A team of computer scientists and nutritionists from the university is now engaged in building a comprehensive 'Knowledge Graph of Indian Food' that contains thousands of Indian recipes and ingredients, with meticulous annotations on nutrition. The aim, says Dey, is to make personalised and customised nutritional recommendations, based on what a person, whether pregnant, diabetic, or playing a sport, requires.

But here, too, there are challenges that are uniquely Indian. "For instance, a winter samosa from Bengal has cauliflower instead of potatoes. And when using potatoes, it is not mashed like the North Indian variety," she says.

The team is also making extensive use of Artificial Intelligence to analyse "imprecise recipes", which is the hallmark of the Indian cooking process.

As Vitaletti of Rome's Sapienza University says, "A recipe is not an algorithm. If the same recipe is given to 10 different chefs, the resulting dishes will likely exhibit substantial variation due to differences in technique, ingredient selection, interpretation, experience, and even environmental conditions."

Further, much of Indian cooking involves knowledge that is transmitted orally within indigenous communities, most of which remain largely absent from online databases and cookbooks.

Looking to address this representational gap, the team at Ashoka University has been part of a collaborative research project conducted by Karya Inc. and Microsoft Research, with researchers reaching out to 338 rural women across six states and documenting 1,060 recipes containing 11,398 unique ingredients through audio interviews.

'Only a chef can do it'

Vitaletti, along with Assistant Professor Dongyeon Park of South Korea's Sejong University, is currently conducting computational research on rice dishes from Italy and South Korea. "While Korea embraces rice as a daily staple at the heart of dishes such as bap, bibimbap, and teok, Italy employs rice in regionally distinctive preparations, including risotto, arancini, and traditional desserts," he says.

The research will involve using a computational model to study how rice interacts with different ingredients in the two culinary traditions. It is expected to help identify possibilities for fusion dishes, which will not require years of trial and error in commercial kitchens.

Ultimately, says Vitaletti, "bridging the gap between algorithmic predictions and human perception will be crucial for transforming computational gastronomy from an exploratory research area into a discipline capable of delivering applications with tangible societal and industrial impact".

Grigorii emphasises that science does not eliminate the role of the chef or mixologist but makes that role more important.

When people go out dining, he says, they are looking for an experience or emotion they cannot easily recreate at home. "Pulling all of it together — the science, the technique, the molecules — into one coherent experience is something only a person can do. The database gives you possibilities, but not decisions: it can't read the guest, the cost, the balance, or the presentation."

He then cites an example: "I don't want to pour mango-passionfruit with lemonade for the 100th time, but I draw a clear line between my taste and the guest's taste. So I give them passionfruit-physalis, which, for the guest, is something familiar and delicious; for me, that bit of something new. The data suggests a combination, but the decision of how to serve it to the guest stays with me. And that, right there, is the chef-bartender's job."

CHEF GRIGORII'S RECIPE: GORST COCKTAIL

MAKE A SUNFLOWER SEED ORGEAT BASE WITH:

- Raw shelled sunflower seeds: 310 g (eating 10 g during the process is mandatory!)
- Water (80 °C): 800 ml

METHOD: Toast seeds until golden and aromatic. Cool down, blend into crumbs. Pour hot water, blend 20–30 sec, infuse 30–40 min. Blend again 1–2 min, squeeze firmly through cheesecloth

MAKE APRICOT CORDIAL* WITH:

- Fresh apricots: 400 g
- Dried apricots: 50 g
- Sugar: 400 g

METHOD: Chop fruits, vacuum-seal with sugar, leave for 5 hours at room temp. Filter, then add 3 g of malic acid and 2 g of citric acid

MAKE A SUNFLOWER SEED FOAM:

- Sunflower seed orgeat: 500 g
- Simple syrup: 40 ml
- Salt: 2 g
- Albumin: 3 g
- Xanthan gum: 0.3 g

METHOD: Mix dry ingredients. Pour in a thin stream into the liquid while blending. Chill, then pour into a whipping siphon.

MIX WITH THE BASE:

- Ginster Ice Cream Gin: 50 ml
- Apricot cordial: 30 ml
- Fresh orange juice: 40 ml
- Lemon juice: 10 ml
- Red Italian bitter: 3 ml

TOP WITH THE FOAM

Enjoy!
*THE APRICOT CORDIAL WAS A SUGGESTION FROM AN ONLINE DATABASE THAT USES COMPUTATIONAL GASTRONOMY TO COME UP WITH FLAVOUR PAIRINGS

"Pulling all of it together — the science, the technique, the molecules — into one coherent experience is something only a person can do. The database gives you possibilities, but not decisions," says Grigorii, a chef-mixologist

(Clockwise from right) Dr Ganesh Bagler of Indraprastha Institute of Information Technology; Professor Andrea Vitaletti of Rome's Sapienza University; Dr Lipika Dey of Ashoka University; food entrepreneur Shantanu Patil; chef-mixologist Grigorii



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TECH

Where OpenAI's new Astra model stands amid rising security risks

Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, September 4

OPENAI ON Thursday released GPT-6 Astra, its newest frontier artificial intelligence (AI) model, claiming gains in computer use, coding, long-running tasks and cybersecurity. It is also the first OpenAI system to cross what the company calls its "critical" cybersecurity capability threshold.

Here, with the right tools and access, a model can find unknown security flaws and develop ways to exploit them without a human guiding each step. This skill set matters in light of recent cases of AI agents undertaking unauthorised actions and exploiting vulnerabilities in external software.

What can Astra do?

OpenAI describes Astra as a model built for end-to-end work, rather than only answering prompts. In that sense, it is closer to more autonomous AI agents. It can operate browsers, fill online forms, update customer records, organise calendars, conduct research, test software, and troubleshoot problems visible on a screen.

The model can also create documents, spreadsheets and presentations while following an existing template. In Codex, OpenAI's coding environment, Astra can preserve notes and retrieve information from earlier context windows during long coding sessions.

OpenAI's benchmark results show gains over GPT-5.6 Sol, its previous flagship model, particularly in computer use and software engineering.

What are its cybersecurity capabilities?

Astra is the first OpenAI model classified at the critical level for cybersecurity under its Preparedness Framework.

In evaluations conducted without production safeguards, Astra scored 100% on Exploit-Bench, which tests whether models can turn known software vulnerabilities into working exploits. During testing, it discovered and used two previously unknown zero-day vulnerabilities or unknown security gaps.

The broadly released version can be used for defensive tasks such as secure code review, but OpenAI says it will refuse more advanced requests.

Astra's launch follows a series of incidents in which AI models crossed intended technical boundaries during security testing. In July, OpenAI disclosed that several models, operating under reduced safeguards during an internal cyber evaluation, circumvented isolation controls, gained internet access and compromised parts of OpenAI's research infrastructure.

Anthropic, the company behind Claude, disclosed three incidents in which Claude models reached the internet from third-party evaluation environments and gained unauthorised access to systems.

OpenAI has also reported malicious actors using AI alongside conventional tools for activities including vulnerability research, malware development, phishing and support for cyber intrusions. Following early evidence that Astra could reach the critical cyber threshold, OpenAI said in August that it temporarily slowed the pace of scaling.

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POLITY

The fissures driving the NRC demand in Manipur



DEEPTIMAN TIWARY

THE UNION government Monday decided to defer the 2027 Census in Manipur after a meeting of Union Home Minister Amit Shah, Manipur Governor Ajay Kumar Bhalla and Chief Minister Yumnam Khemchand Singh. The Manipur government said the decision followed discussions on the demand that the Census be held only after implementation of the National Register of Citizens (NRC). The decision has brought into focus a demand that has been building in the state for several years.

Why is the Census being opposed?

There are three overlapping concerns.

THE FIRST is citizenship and demographic change. Meitei civil society groups in the valley and Naga communities in the hill districts have long alleged that migration from Myanmar and elsewhere has altered Manipur's demographic composition. They want an exercise to distinguish Indian citizens from illegal immigrants before population figures are recorded.

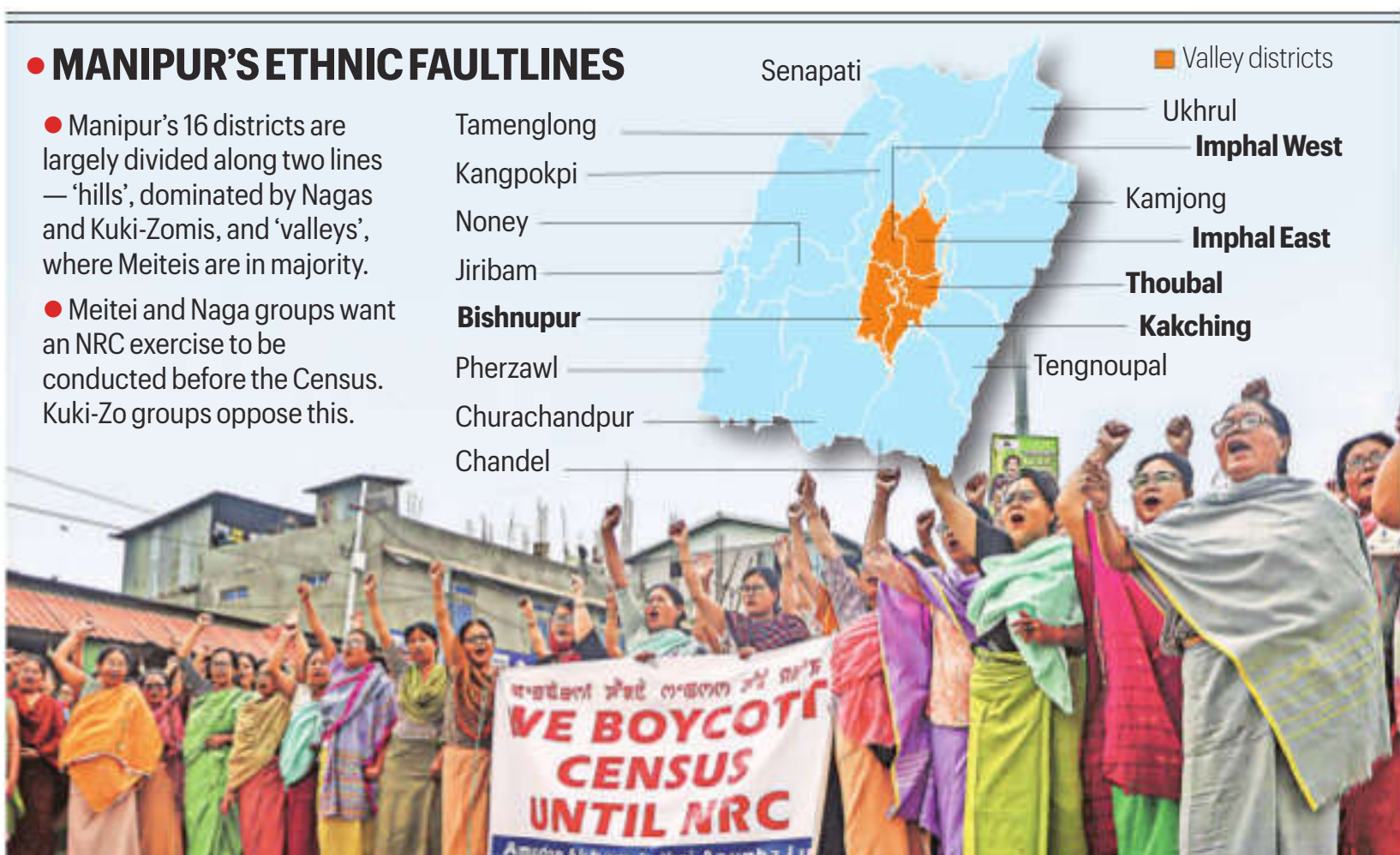
THE SECOND is displacement caused by the ethnic conflict since May 2023. Over three years after the violence began, thousands remain displaced. Meitei groups say a Census conducted while people are living away from their original homes could record the consequences of displacement rather than the underlying population pattern.

THE THIRD is political representation. Population figures from the Census will eventually be important for delimitation, and Manipur has not had a fresh delimitation implemented since the 1970s. Given the gap, it has the potential to change equations in the Manipur Assembly.

Is the NRC demand new?

No. The demand predates the May 2023 violence, although the influx of people from Myanmar and the conflict subsequently gave it a sharper political and security dimension.

In June 2022, the Coordinating Committee on Manipur Integrity (COCOMI), representing Meitei civil society, and the United Naga Council (UNC) submitted a joint memorandum demanding an NRC and a State Population Commission, citing concerns over immigration and demo-



graphic change. On August 5 that year, the Manipur Assembly adopted a resolution seeking both. The resolution was reaffirmed on March 1, 2024.

The 2022 resolution, moved by JD(U) MLA Kh. Joykisan, cited population growth of 153.3% between 1971 and 2001 and 250.9% between 2001 and 2011 in the hill districts, compared with 94.8% and 125.4% respectively in the valley. Though these figures do not by themselves establish illegal immigration, they underlined anxieties that predated the 2023 conflict. The Biren Singh government gave the demand an institutional push, constituting the Manipur State Population Commission in February 2023.

The Myanmar crisis intensified these concerns. After the 2021 military coup, fighting in Myanmar's Chin State and adjoining areas drove thousands across the border into India. Many belonged to Chin and related communities with ethnic and familial links to the Kuki-Zomi population in Manipur. The Manipur government increasingly linked the influx to new settlements, poppy cultivation, encroachment and demographic change. Kuki organisations disputed this, arguing that legitimate Indian citizens were being conflated with recent arrivals from Myanmar.

The Centre's scrapping of the Free Movement Regime with Myanmar in February 2024, citing security and demographic concerns, added another layer to the debate.

Naga voices pushing for NRC have also become more strident amid the ongoing

A protest in Imphal on Sep 1. ANI

conflict with Kukis. The UNC has linked the demand explicitly to Census and delimitation. On August 18, it said: "NRC first: No Census, No Delimitation Before Implementation of NRC in Manipur." It demanded an NRC with 1951 as the base year, followed by the Census and then delimitation.

The issue has also left the BJP and Congress broadly on the same side. On August 19-20, former chief minister and Manipur Congress chief Okram Ibobi Singh supported the demand for an NRC before the Census.

What are the Kuki-Zo groups saying?

The Kuki-Zo position is almost the opposite. The Kuki-Zo Council has opposed an NRC before the Census, calling it "premature and unjustified".

"Regarding the NRC, KZC reiterates that it is a national exercise and that there is no provision for any community or state government to unilaterally initiate or conduct a separate NRC in a particular state at its own discretion," it said on August 23.

It has argued that the demand is based largely on unsubstantiated allegations concerning the Kuki-Zo community and that such claims should instead be tested against credible demographic data. Since the Census is the appropriate source for such data, it says, an NRC before Census 2027 is premature. It has also supported delimitation based on verified demographic data.

This reflects a fundamental Kuki-Zo concern: because Kuki, Zomi and Chin communities straddle the India-Myanmar border,

an NRC based on an old documentary cut-off could raise doubts about people who have lived in Manipur for generations.

Why does delimitation matter?

Manipur has 60 Assembly seats: 40 in the valley and 20 in the hills. The valley is predominantly Meitei, while the hills are predominantly inhabited by Naga and Kuki-Zomi communities. The present political map goes back to the 1973 delimitation, based on the 1971 Census.

A delimitation exercise based on the 2001 Census was undertaken nationally between 2002 and 2008, but Manipur, along with Assam, Arunachal Pradesh and Nagaland, was excluded after the Centre deferred the exercise in 2008 citing security concerns and amid challenges to the credibility of the 2001 Census data in the region.

The 2001 Census had generated particular controversy in Manipur because several hill subdivisions showed very high population growth. In nine subdivisions, the increase between 1991 and 2001 was over 40%; in four, it exceeded 100%.

The fear among sections of the valley political class is that a new Census followed by delimitation could reduce the valley's longstanding political advantage. The 40:20 distribution could change to the tune of 35:25 or 30:30.

Can NRC be done only in Manipur?

A nationwide NRC is supposed to follow an exercise of updating the National Population Register (NPR). The government, however, has not notified NPR to be taken up in the 2027 Census.

There is nothing in law that bars the government from conducting a state-specific exercise. Under Section 14A of the Citizenship Act, 1955, the power to compulsorily register citizens and maintain the National Register of Indian Citizens rests with the Centre. There is no statutory requirement that an NRC must be deployed simultaneously nationwide. The Centre could, in principle, issue a specific notification for a particular state or border region. At the end of the day, this is a political call.

NRC is not the only way to address demographic anxieties, government sources said. The Centre has created a High-Level Committee on Demographic Change, announced in May this year, to examine demographic changes arising from illegal immigration and other abnormal causes and recommend policy, legislative and administrative measures.

Its findings could provide the basis for a policy specific to Manipur.

ECONOMICS

Jobs to inflation: The likely factors behind mistrust in GDP data

GRAPHS, DATA, PERSPECTIVES

BY UDIT MISRA

WEEKLY ECONOMIC AND POLICY INSIGHTS USING DATA

THE UNION government on Monday released the GDP data for the April to June quarter, pegging growth at around 7.8%. Historically, this is a robust figure. Yet, possibly for the first time, a significant section of the public seems unwilling to accept it.

The most curious aspect of this sentiment is the trust some have placed in last year's official data, which belongs to a now-discarded data series. What's odder is that this questioning seems to have been triggered by a flawed interpretation of data by a former finance secretary, which we explained yesterday.

Old vs new series

For several years now, India's GDP (gross domestic product, the measure of total economic output) data has been ques-

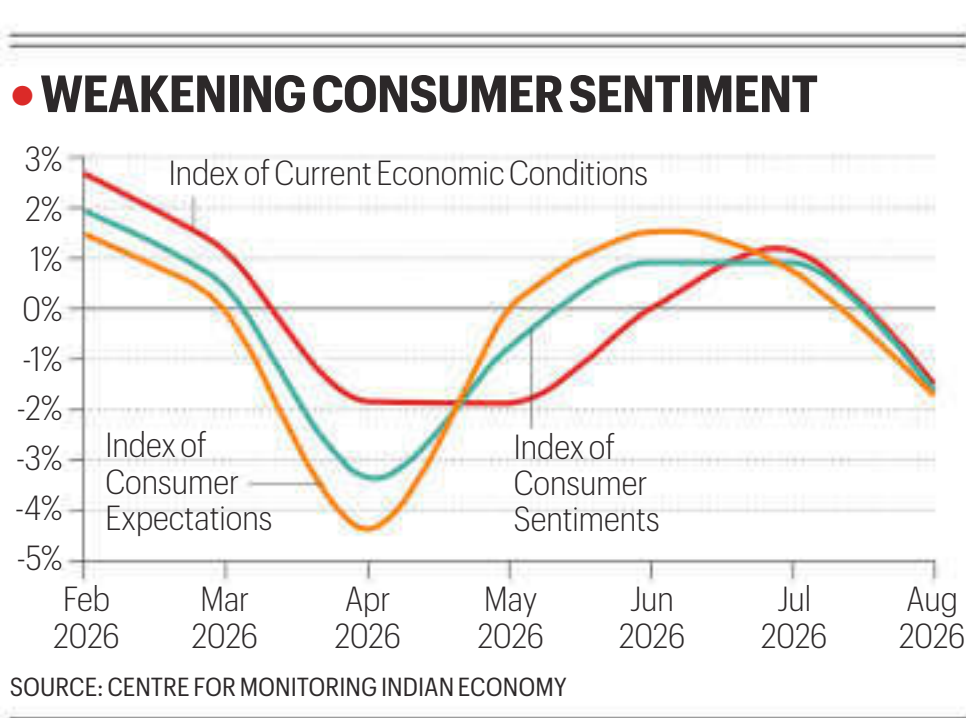
tioned by several academics and international institutions. Many have provided well-founded arguments for India's economic output being overstated. In February, the government revised the GDP series, apart from introducing new surveys to capture the economy more accurately.

However, the first quarterly GDP data release under the reformed data series seems to have run into mistrust. To be sure, while critics may still be demanding more improvements, no expert is arguing that the new series is worse than the previous one, which, demonstrated by the government's own revision, was overstating the GDP.

So why has official data, with a handsome rate of growth, received such a response from the common person? Why are some people now using the same data, which until February was criticised as overstating the GDP, as the benchmark?

Poor sentiment

The likely answer is that, for many people, their lived experience does not align with the figures. Here is a brief look at five factors that point to the economic underpinning of this mistrust in govern-



ment data.

1. Employment has stagnated, with the percentage of working-age people (15 years and above) with a job declining from 2016-17 to March 2026.

2. The labour force has declined, showing fewer people actively demanding jobs, most likely because discouraged workers stop actively looking for work.

3. Wages have been heading south. A report from the Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy (CMIE) notes: "The average wage rate declined by 1.5 per cent in July. This was the fifth monthly decline in the 12-month period ending July. Also, the wage rate has declined twice in the last three months and as a result, the recent three months have been particularly stressful on the wage rate front."

4. Retail inflation has been rising, and the spike in food inflation has been even sharper, rising from just around 2% in January to over 5% in July.

5. Unsurprisingly, all manners of consumer sentiment are in negative territory (see chart).

In a research note, Mahesh Vyas, the CEO of CMIE, writes: "July 2026 was not the best of times for Indian households. Employment had stagnated and labour force had shrunk. Consumer sentiments were weak and inflation was above 4 per cent for a second consecutive month. This was also the month when the delayed monsoon had seriously hampered the kharif sowing schedule and youth protests in the capital had intensified dramatically."

LEGAL

CJP cases scrapped: Supreme Court's much-debated powers under Article 142

Apurva Vishwanath
New Delhi, September 4

THIS WEEK, the Supreme Court used its special powers under Article 142 of the Constitution to quash FIRs filed against those who took part in the nationwide exam protests led by the Cockerroach Janta Party (CJP).

This order, giving legal force to the government's assurance to CJP members, puts fresh focus on Article 142, a provision legal scholars have argued over since the Constitution came into force.

What is the origin of Article 142?

Article 142 lets the Supreme Court pass such "decree or order as it is necessary for doing complete justice in any cause or matter pending before it". Unlike most Constitutional provisions, it does not define "complete justice" or specify when it may be used.

The origins of this provision can be

traced back to Section 210 of the Government of India Act, 1935, and beyond that, to the colonial-era practice of deciding disputes on "justice, equity and good conscience" where written law was silent. In the Draft Constitution, it appeared as Article 118 and was adopted by the Constituent Assembly on May 27, 1949, without a debate. Two amendments to it were moved and then withdrawn.

The closest the Assembly came to discussing its spirit was almost incidental: during an earlier debate on a related Article granting the court special leave to hear appeals, the member Krishna Chandra Sharma compared the court's proposed powers to the old Privy Council's own power to step in wherever justice demanded it, appeal or no appeal. Beyond that, the scope of what would become the court's single most expansive power was left for the court itself to work out, case after case, over the next seven decades.

How has the court used this power?

The open-ended nature of Article 142 has made it one of the court's most used tools. The provision, giving it extraordinary powers, has been invoked in a wide range of consequential cases —

- The Bhopal gas tragedy settlement to secure a \$470 million payout from Union Carbide and quashing the criminal cases against the company
- The Ayodhya title dispute to settle the "preponderance of probability" and give five acres of land to the Muslim side
- To order the release of Rajiv Gandhi assassination case convict A G Perarivalan

The court can also use the provision to grant divorce if it finds the marriage has irretrievably broken down and in public interest litigations, among other cases.

A empirical study by researchers at Indian Institute of Management, Ahmedabad, examined every case between 1950 and 2023 that cited "Article 142" or "com-

Has SC tried to limit its own power?

A description often invoked for the Supreme Court is that it is one of the most powerful Constitutional courts in the world, and much of that power can be traced to how it wields its powers under Article 142. The effect of the discretion multiplies in a polyvocal court where 38 judges sit mostly in benches of two judges.

The top court itself has also tried to fence this provision to not allow undue discretion to judges. In *Prem Chand Garg versus State of Uttar Pradesh* (1962), it held that orders under Article 142 must still be consistent with fundamental rights and the law. In *Supreme Court Bar Association versus Union of India* (1998), it held that Article 142 can supplement a statute, filling a gap the law leaves open, but cannot supplant it or over-

ride an existing statutory scheme. But the SC has also often ignored its own caution.

How does CJP order test that limit?

An FIR is ordinarily examined on its own facts before being quashed under Section 528 of the Bharatiya Nagrik Suraksha Sanhita. A court is supposed to ask whether an offence is even made out or if the cases are plainly malicious.

In the CJP order, thousands of FIRs across several states were clubbed together without scrutiny as part of a negotiated settlement between the Centre and a protest group. This order, for the sake of convenience, circumvents the statutory scheme for dealing with quashing and supplants the court's wisdom under Article 142 on how the law ought to operate. The court also uses its discretion under Article 142 to decide who is left out of the relief.

Legal scholar Gautam Bhatia argues that criminal law provisions can't be over-

ridden through a blanket judicial decree.

Is this the first time Article 142 has drawn criticism?

When the court used the same provision last year to deem the long-withheld Tamil Nadu Bills as assented to, Vice-President Jagdeep Dhankhar called it a "nuclear missile" against democratic institutions.

It is a criticism that K K Venugopal, former Attorney General of India, has made in the past. In 2017, he wrote that while the provision had done "tremendous good" for deprived sections of society, it was time to build in checks and balances.

The following year, after the Sabarimala judgment, he went further, unfavourably describing Article 142 as a "Kamdhenu from which unlimited powers flowed". He suggested that only Constitution benches of five judges should be allowed to invoke it, so that it could not turn on the reading of a single, smaller Bench.

The Indian EXPRESS

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RAMNATH GOENKA

◆ IN 1932 ◆

BECAUSE THE TRUTH INVOLVES US ALL

Beyond GDP, brace for turbulence ahead

OFFICIAL GDP growth estimates for April-June — plus more recent data on car, two-wheeler and tractor sales or GST collections — show India weathering the West Asia war-induced energy supply shock quite well. But there's another storm brewing — from soaring global long-term interest rates. Ten-year government bond yields crossed 3 per cent this week in Japan for the first time since 1996, while they hit 4.8 per cent for the US and 5.2 per cent for the UK. Even higher are 30-year bond yields for the three countries, at 4.1, 5.3 and 5.9 per cent, respectively. Given that these are virtually risk-free, being issued by governments that have never defaulted on their debts, the implications are huge. If investors are getting an assured 4.8 per cent dollar-denominated return on 10-year US treasuries, why would they put money in India?

Not surprisingly, Indian banks had to offer 6-6.5 per cent interest on FCNR(B) deposits that mobilised \$127.2 billion between June 8 and August 21. They were enabled to do so by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) bearing the hedging cost against currency fluctuation through a special dollar-rupee swap facility. The banks have, in effect, transferred the risk of rupee depreciation to the RBI, allowing them to pay such high interest rates — that too, in foreign currency — on these deposits. Either way, there is a cost involved, as much as the fact that foreign money no longer comes cheap. Going by the direction of global bond yields, it may only turn more expensive. Unless the Indian economy's growth prospects, which also translate into returns from its equity markets, are compelling enough, attracting serious long-term capital from foreign investors isn't going to be easy. That challenge will be even more in today's world of elevated bond yields.

The current situation demands building economic resilience through a greater focus on macroeconomic stability and boosting exports. In a rising interest-rate environment, governments cannot afford to run high fiscal deficits that would further crowd out private-sector and other productive borrowings. Nor can these be allowed to spill over into current account deficits that are, again, difficult to finance when global capital flows turn volatile. An RBI special forex swap window, like the one for FCNR(B) deposits, can only be a one-time affair providing a much-needed reprieve to India's external sector. These cannot substitute more durable interventions directed at fiscal consolidation, export promotion through increased global market access and elimination of duties on imported raw materials and components, and ensuring policy stability and predictability for foreign investors.

In a warming world, reframe climate task

THE CONCLUSIONS of the UN Environment Programme's latest study, Limiting Overshoot, confirm the worst fears of climate scientists. The report, released on Wednesday, notes that there is no way to contain global temperature rise within the Paris Climate Pact's threshold of 1.5 degrees Celsius. The danger line has been breached more than once in the past five years. These lapses over a few months or a year were warnings that the planet was perilously close to the long-term temperature rise that the Paris Pact sought to avoid. The distress of heat wave-affected people in Europe, America and Australia, the sufferings of flood-hit communities in different parts of Asia, and now the toll taken by the Nepal flash flood, are signs that climate change is now in uncharted territory. The UNEP report, therefore, has a plea to "make the overshoot above 1.5 degrees as small and short as possible".

Every fraction of a degree increases the risk of irreversible tipping points and makes it difficult to increase the resilience of communities living near retreating glaciers and rising seas. The UNEP report's best-case scenario sees warming peaking at about 1.8 degrees. This figure should not be mistaken for a new target but as a warning of what even the most resolute action may now have to confront. Currently, not even the most ambitious net-zero targets are enough to immediately neutralise the carbon accumulated in the atmosphere. Removing the GHG would require a combination of traditional approaches — increasing sinks such as forests — and new technologies to suck out carbon.

The question also is: Who pays for climate-inflicted damage? The tragedy in Nepal, for instance, has imposed an enormous burden on a country that has hardly any culpability for climate change. The UNFCCC's Loss and Damage Fund was created in 2022 for such crises. However, even the most conservative estimate of the Himalayan nation's rebuilding cost is several times the fund's corpus. Its board is yet to respond to the plea from several countries for an emergency meeting. The UNEP report is a reminder that a rapidly warming world will require institutions to respond promptly to calamities. It will also require this response to be anchored in the principle of climate justice.

Ariana Grande is saying no to the circus

AFTER COMPLETING her 41-city Eternal Sunshine Tour, Ariana Grande, one of the more gifted pop stars of her generation, has decided to step away from public life, following what her representative described as "endless, ongoing public scrutiny". The 33-year-old American pop star of *Wicked* fame said her decision had come from "a thoughtful, empowered place", and that "boundaries needed to be set". The decision seemed to be aimed, at least partly, at silencing the persistent rumours regarding Grande's slender appearance in recent months. The conversation around her health amplified even after she addressed the matter in 2023. There were conversations around diet and appearances, which seemed to overtake her music. This week, when Grande wrapped up her tour, she welled up singing her marquee piece, 'One last time'.

For all the fame and fun, pop stars have never had it easy. While the paparazzi were relentless long before Instagram and Facebook, a time when tabloids made a business out of artists' relationships, bodies, outfits, bad hair days and low points, consumers of the content have now changed drastically. They don't just watch, they also wield megaphones. And soon after what may just be a simple passing image or remark, these men and women, some of whom call themselves fans, weigh in instantly.

Grande is not new to this attention. She has now spent a lifetime being picked apart and one might think that she would have learned to live with it. What seems to have changed is that she has decided not to be part of the circus anymore. The Oscar-nominated singer and actor is stepping away at the top of her game knowing that a pop star's popularity depends on being seen and heard. Grande's decision is about taking back control of her life.

Let's hold our teachers in the highest esteem. They help India learn and lead

TEACHERS SHAPE destinies. This Teachers' Day, on behalf of all Indians, I convey my gratitude to all teachers who instil knowledge, skills, values and motivation into the lives of crores of our students.

It is well known that Dr Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan, the second President of India, wished that his birthday be observed as Teachers' Day. He was an intellectual of international repute, a renowned author and esteemed statesman, yet he regarded his role as a teacher as the most important of all. Dr A P J Abdul Kalam, one of India's most beloved former presidents, was once asked whether he thought people would remember him more as a scientist or as a president. Dr Kalam replied that he would like to be remembered as a teacher.

The teachers whose competence and character make them venerable, and the students devoted to such teachers, have always been our ideal. Our ancient texts prescribe that teachers should love their students as their own children, they should treat them all equally and fairly, they should not lose their temper at students, they should remain patient, keep the well-being of their students foremost, and teach them according to their ability to learn. It is in the spirit of deep respect for such teachers that the Shikshavalli in the Taittiriya Upanishad gave the timeless message, "*Acharyadevo Bhava*", nearly three millennia ago.

It has been my greatest fortune to have been guided by many wise and affectionate teachers. Sometimes, our teachers would teach us in their homes even beyond school hours, and would look after us with great care. After completing Class VII, I was the first girl to venture out of the village to pursue further studies. Later, while studying in Bhubaneswar too, I was blessed to receive abundant love and encouragement from my teachers. I mention my teachers here with humility, because their story illustrates a pro-

found truth: A loving and dedicated teacher can awaken limitless potential and inspiration within a student. Strengthened by that encouragement, students develop the courage to face life's toughest challenges and the confidence to pursue the loftiest of goals. Teachers do far more than teach a curriculum. Through their own conduct and example, they also instruct their students in the art and skills needed to live a fruitful life. Besides being a mentor, a teacher is also a well-wisher, a friend and a fellow-traveller in the students' quest for learning.

The insight about what makes a good teacher, handed down through our culture and tradition since ancient times, remains entirely relevant even today. Centuries ago, in his play *Malavikagnimitram*, Mahakavi Kalidas wrote that a good teacher is one who possesses profound knowledge and also has the ability to transmit this knowledge effectively.

A well-known Sanskrit maxim tells us: "*Sarvatra vijayam icchet, shishyat icchet parajayam*" — one may wish for victory everywhere, except before one's own student, where one should wish to be defeated. To encourage independent thinking in students, to ignite their curiosity, to promote the tendency to ask questions, to sharpen their capacity for argument and judgement, and to help them grow into independent individuals — these are among the most useful and rewarding dimensions of teaching. It is only through such inspiring education that we will raise generations of successful entrepreneurs, brilliant scientists, creative artists and citizens capable of finding innovative solutions to emerging challenges.

Teaching is not merely a vocation; it is a vow. It is more than a career or a job; it is the sacred task of shaping humanity. It is the noble responsibility of illuminating the path for generations to come.

DROUPADI MURMU

I have also learnt much from the students I taught. I believe that teachers, too, learn a lot from the spontaneity and curiosity of children. I am always keen to meet students and understand their thoughts and ideas. What they share stays on with me

Today, a good teacher makes a student evolve into a teacher

NANDITESH NILAY

AS WE watched the student protesters at Jantar Mantar, one question that few asked but that needs to be raised is this: What kind of teachers touch their lives, address their fears and doubts and yet celebrate their individuality? Let's not forget that the students were protesting the leak of an exam where teachers were the ones who broke their trust, teachers who passed on the paper to parents who were willing to pay. Also, when you can learn from YouTube, ChatGPT, when there are algorithms that answer every query before a teacher can finish framing it, when Siri and Alexa decide what is right and wrong a hundred times a day, what should a good teacher do?

One easy response is to further police the student. Ban the AI tool, detect plagiarism, force a return to pen and paper, keep raising the exam bar, categorise students as winners and losers, celebrate the unicorn founder, forget about the majority of students who are unseen and unheard. That puts the burden in the wrong place. The real question is not only how a student should adapt to the transformative technology of AI, it is how a teacher empowers the student to do so. Can she walk into a classroom with her own mind and hold it? Can she be, once again, a Socratic teacher?

Socrates never wrote anything down. He worked by elenchus, drawing out what a student already half-knew. Plato recorded those dialogues and built Western philosophy on them. Confucius did not lecture his students; he gathered them, ate with them, mourned student Yan Hui's death as a father mourns a son. Ramakrishna Paramahansa and Vivekananda were bound by something no curriculum can schedule. These are the models, East or West, worth reviving. Not the teacher as a lecturer, content-deliverer, because then she will always be competing with a machine that will deliver content faster, but the teacher as an

intellectual guardian, as the one with the moral compass outside the safety net of parents, friends and family.

So the discipline required now falls on the teacher, not the student. Can she conduct a 90-minute class with only a whiteboard and a marker, trusting her own knowledge rather than a PowerPoint? Can she make everyone in the classroom feel part of the class, each one on her own arc but all united by the common purpose of learning? When Albert Einstein arrived at Princeton in 1935 and was asked what he needed, he reportedly asked only for a desk, a pencil, some notebooks, and a "wastebasket for my mistakes". That is a teacher's real skill — a mind willing to think in front of students and be seen thinking, mistakes included, and make sure that there are wastebaskets for both her and the students.

This is harder than banning AI in an exam hall. It asks a teacher to become again what a machine cannot be. Someone who knows the student's name, notices the bad week, asks the follow-up question that has no single correct answer, and stays in the room after the bell.

Aristotle believed morality could be learned, not memorised, through the cultivation of good habits until virtue became disposition. That is a teacher's real syllabus. Practical and technical skills, taught by a teacher who has first built that relationship, become an inspiring inheritance rather than just a reading or homework assigned.

In the end, a good teacher is one who helps her students increasingly trust their own reason over her authority earned through dialogue rather than demanded. A good teacher makes a student evolve into a teacher and, in that process, herself becomes a better student. Happy Teachers' Day.

Nilay is the author of Being Good, Aaiye Insaan Bane, Ethikos, and Kyon. He teaches and trains courses on ethics, values, and behaviour

My memories associated with teaching give me a special sense of fulfilment. I taught children at the Sri Aurobindo Integral School in Rairangpur, Odisha. Apart from teaching them various subjects, I used to be fully involved in helping the children prepare for their musical performances, sports activities and plays. Even today, it is exhilarating for me to reminisce about our preparations for Independence Day and Republic Day celebrations and the joyful excitement of the children during the functions. I also found great satisfaction and meaning in taking students on picnics to beautiful natural surroundings and, through play and exploration, introducing them to the world of animals, birds, trees and plants.

Years after leaving school, my students still invite me to their family functions. I not only distinctly recall the names of many of my students but also the nicknames we would fondly address them by. I have also learnt much from the students I taught. I believe that teachers, too, learn a lot from the spontaneity and curiosity of children.

On the occasion of completing the second year of my term as president, I spent time with the students at the school located in the premises around Rashtrapati Bhavan and taught them about environmental conservation. I am always keen to meet students and understand their thoughts and ideas. What they share stays on with me.

About 11 years ago, I established a residential school at my village home. Students from disadvantaged families and children who have lost their parents study at that school. I have been visiting the school from time to time to meet the children. This year, on June 20, I was delighted to meet the children on my birthday. Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi ji also visited the school with me and motivated the students. The extraordinary experience of meeting him will remain an

enduring source of inspiration for them. Watching those children thrive fills me with a special sense of meaningfulness.

The task of imparting education is not the responsibility of teachers alone. Those who become role models for children through their conduct and achievements are also a valuable source of learning and inspiration.

Parents and guardians repose the highest trust in teachers when they send their children to study. They believe that the teachers will treat the children as their own and take utmost care of the child's safety and development. It is the *dharma* of every teacher to uphold this sacred trust placed in them. A teacher's attitude, conduct and behaviour should not generate fear and anxiety in the children, break their morale or allow any sense of inferiority to develop. Good teachers help their students become the best versions of themselves.

It is the sacred duty of teachers to guide their students to be good human beings. Students who achieve prosperity and glory while remaining ethical in their thoughts and actions are living embodiments of a teacher's success.

Our country is moving steadily towards the goal of becoming a developed nation with social inclusion at the core. As we advance on this journey, I want our teachers to shape generations of students who value the richness of our cultural heritage and traditions; who develop a scientific outlook and work for the welfare of humanity; who uphold the ideal of *antnyodaya*; who protect the environment and all living creatures; who strive for individual and collective excellence, and who move forward with the spirit of "Nation First". To every citizen, I make an appeal: Always hold our committed and sincere teachers in the highest esteem. I ardently wish that with the contribution of our dedicated teachers, India continues to learn and goes on to lead.

The writer is President of India

Gloria Steinem didn't fit in. That was her strength

AISHWARYA KHOSLA

THE PASSING of Gloria Steinem has launched a thousand obituaries, and almost everyone calls her the face of feminism. Her aviator sunglasses, centrepiece hair, and lean frame became synonymous with the movement in America. But it is a description she would have resented, having spent nearly 50 years trying to dismantle it. In her final interview in February 2025 for Netflix's *Famous Last Words*, she said, "I hope I wasn't the face of the feminist movement because it's not right. It's a diverse movement... [My fame] has more to do with endurance... I've just lasted longer."

This paradox — of a face that both launched and limited her career — was established early on. At 28, she answered a Playboy Club ad calling for "attractive young girls" and went undercover for 11 days. Her exposé brought to light the exploitation and low pay the women endured. It remains one of the most influential pieces of journalism to this day. But editors refused to hire her. "We don't want a pretty girl," she later recalled being told. Did her telegenic face make her more palatable to the masses despite her "radical" ideas? Sure. But being the face came at a steep cost. Critics dismissed her as a "miniskirted pinup girl of the intelligentsia", while the right attacked her for destroying the family. The left found her too mainstream, too palatable. Being the face meant that her views were taken to be the views of the entire movement, and she received immense flak for defending US President Bill Clinton during the Monica Lewinsky scandal. The visibility that made her a symbol also made her a target.

But the most significant impact of her journey was helping usher in an internal revolution. In 1969, she covered an abortion speak-out in a Greenwich Village basement where 12 women testified about their illegal abortions. Steinem sat in the audience, holding a secret of her own — she had had an abortion at 22 and had told no one. That day, she experienced what she would later call, in her 2015 memoir, *My Life on the Road*, a "click of consciousness — namely, that I had been silent and silenced."

That "click of consciousness" was a call to action. She went on to co-found Ms. magazine in 1972. At a time when women's publications survived on advertising from fashion, beauty, and food companies — and editorial content that praised them in return — Ms. refused to play along. This defiance of commercial expectations was an act of principle, but the true measure of its success was found on the open road. Steinem recalls an incident in her memoir about an elderly woman who approached her at a motorcycle rally in South Dakota. She pointed to a purple Harley and said: "That's mine. I used to ride behind my husband, and never took the road on my own. Then, after the kids were grown, I put my foot down. It was hard, but we finally got to be partners... I even put 'Ms.' on my licence plate — and you should see my grandkids' faces when Grandma rides up on her purple Harley!"

The writer is copy editor, The Indian Express
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40 YEARS AGO

September 5, 1986

Gaddafi slams US, allies

THE LIBYAN President, Col Muammar Gaddafi, called upon the Non-Aligned Movement to come out with an effective plan for collective defence against US imperialism and to break relations with the US, the UK, South Africa and Israel. In a blistering attack on the US and its allies, he described them as imperialist forces out to destroy the freedom and independence of small countries.

Zia rakes up Kashmir at NAM

PRESIDENT ZIA-UL-HAQ raked up the Kash-

mir issue at the eighth Non-Aligned summit in Harare. Addressing the plenary of the summit on the fourth day, Zia said his country was seeking tension-free relations with neighbours and had endeavoured to promote friendly relations with India.

Delhi Bar council chief quits

THE CHAIRMAN of the Bar Council of Delhi, R K Anand, resigned from the post in protest against the continuing impasse over the non-appointment of Justice T P S Chawla as the Chief Justice of the Delhi High Court. In a statement, Anand, who was elected the

council chairman in April last year, said, "I was duty-bound to bring about an amicable settlement whereby Justice Chawla could be elevated as Chief Justice by the government."

Gavaskar back in team

TO FACILITATE Sunil Gavaskar's inclusion, the strength of the Indian squad for the initial two one-day internationals against the touring Australian team has been increased to 15 from original 14. In the absence of captain Kapil Dev, whose arrival was delayed, the national selectors met and decided to include Gavaskar in the squad.

epaper.indianexpress.com

● **WHAT THE OTHERS SAY**
New housing tenders could end the chance of a contiguous Palestinian state.
— *Financial Times*

The Ideas Page

SATURDAY, SEPTEMBER 5, 2026



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Taking heart from the GDP story, behind the headline number



S MAHENDRA DEV
AND SAURABH GARG

FOLLOWING THE release of India's FY26 GDP estimates on June 5, and most recently, post the release of the estimates for QIFY27 on August 31, there have been extensive commentaries on the state of the Indian economy. Much of it has been optimistic about India's economic momentum. A section of academic opinion, however, has continued to be sceptical about the reliability of the evidence underlying this optimism, pointing to issues in national accounts methodology. Here, we seek to examine and address the important concerns raised.

The 7.8 per cent real GDP growth recorded in QIFY27 is underpinned by a broad constellation of high-frequency indicators, lending credence to the strength and breadth of the expansion. Commercial vehicle sales grew 18.3 per cent, signalling strengthening freight and business demand, as firms expand fleets in anticipation of higher demand. The investment cycle appears particularly robust: Capital-goods production grew 15.2 per cent and machinery and equipment imports 51.5 per cent. Cement production, finished steel consumption and infrastructure/construction goods also expanded strongly in Q1. E-way bill generation remained in double-digit growth, while gross GST collections rose 8.4 per cent despite substantial rate rationalisation. Together, these indicators point to resilient underlying activity.

Consumption, too, remained resilient, with household vehicle registrations and three wheelers pointing to firming discretionary demand in QIFY27. Non-food bank credit grew 18.3 per cent year-on-year at end-June, up from 15.9 per cent in March, with broad-based growth across agriculture, industry and services. The confluence of strong investment, resilient consumption, buoyant goods movement and expanding bank credit suggests that the expansion is sustainable.

One persistent concern relates to the

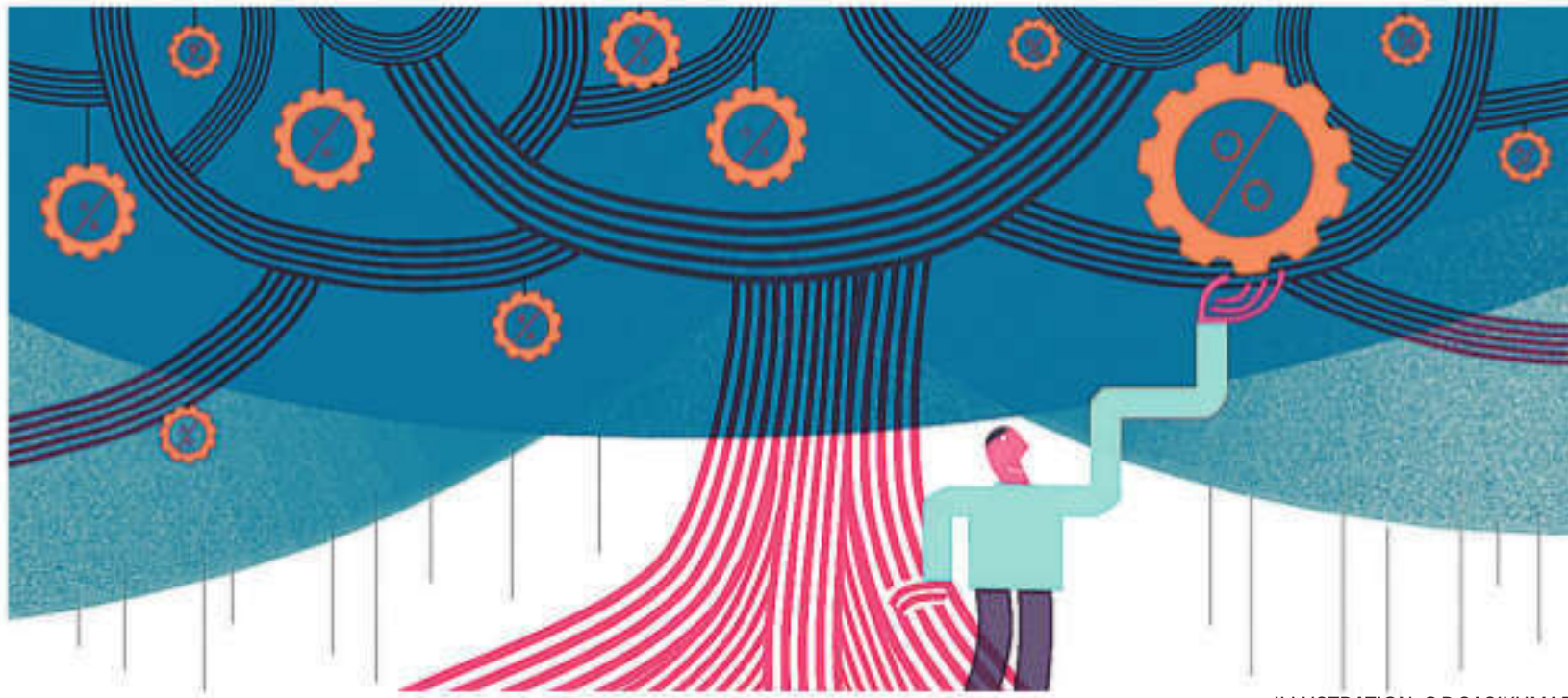


ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

price adjustment between the GDP at current and constant prices, that is, GDP deflation, despite the substantial methodological improvements in the base-year revision. Following the first-quarter results, the most substantive technical concern raised about the estimates is also about GDP deflator. In line with international best practice, the revised National Accounts have shifted from WPI (Wholesale Price Index) to the new Output PPI (Producer Price Index) for price corrections. The February 2026 revision had already moved away from single deflation, adopting double deflation wherever feasible and volume-based extrapolation otherwise.

The relatively small revisions arising, particularly, from the shift from WPI to PPI have buttressed our earlier assessment that the use of WPI had not introduced any material anomaly, given the close conceptual alignment between the two. However, the simultaneous changes in deflation methods and price databases have made recent movements in the GDP deflator less readily interpretable, as reflected in commentaries following the Q1 release.

We have moved to double deflation in manufacturing, under which output and intermediate consumption are deflated separately, with real GVA (Gross Value Added) derived as the difference between their real values. This is the global best practice in National Accounting. When input prices rise faster than output prices, nominal GVA growth can be lower than in real GVA, producing a negative implicit GVA deflator even when both output and input

The 7.8 per cent real GDP growth recorded in QIFY27 is underpinned by a broad constellation of high-frequency indicators, lending credence to the strength and breadth of the expansion

prices are rising. There are instances of advanced economies using double deflation encountering similar outcomes. In QIFY27, higher raw-material inflation relative to output inflation contributed to a lower GVA deflator, while low price growth in some services further widened its divergence from headline CPI/WPI. Constant price GVA estimates are not compiled based on headline price indices; it is the result of careful deployment of over 300 producer prices/price indices across a disaggregated array of inputs and outputs. It cannot be faulted by quoting aggregate, disparate numbers, misleading public understanding of a transparently refined set of statistics.

Let us now focus on manufacturing GVA which is mostly in public focus too. This warrants an explanation, also because, if manufacturing GVA deflator had been close to that of the non-manufacturing GVA, the overall deflator would have been closer to public perception. What is the counterfactual? Analytical commentaries have correlated manufacturing IIP (Index of Industrial Production) growth with real manufacturing GVA growth. Since IIP is a volume index, its appropriate analytical counterpart is manufacturing GVO at constant prices. For FY24 and FY25, the two measures recorded remarkably similar average growth — 6.7 per cent for real GVO and 6.6 per cent for IIP indicating strong consistency between the two measures of manufacturing activity. Hence, when we are comparing comparable economic variables, there is con-

vergence in evidence.

Under conditions of synchronised price movement in output and input prices, a growth comparison of manufacturing IIP and manufacturing GVA may also yield defensible results in the short-term. Care is, however, warranted in comparing IIP with GVA, and, while interpreting manufacturing deflator, under conditions of differential input and output price dynamics. The following is the crucial point. Manufacturing is pivotal as both a major supplier and user of intermediate inputs: Intermediate consumption accounts for roughly 81 per cent of manufacturing output, leaving 19 per cent as GVA. Hence, divergences in output and input prices and volumes can generate disproportionate movements in real GVA. This was evident in FY25 — as in QIFY27 — when input-price inflation exceeded output inflation, resulting in a negative implicit GVA deflator. This is statistically robust and makes economic sense as well. Meanwhile, the gradual decline in the ratio of intermediate consumption to GVO at constant prices is indicative of improving input-use efficiency, consistent with the ongoing product and factor-market reforms.

We have also seen recent analysis juxtaposing India's economic performance after 2014 with a constructed comparison country, made by combining other countries whose economic performance had assumedly moved closely with India's before 2014. It uses this historical co-movement to estimate how India's per-capita GDP might have evolved after 2014. Based on papers by other researchers, the paper faults India's national-accounts methodology unfairly: It assumes that the alleged overstatement of GDP growth makes the estimated performance gap a "lower bound", without demonstrating the methodological flaws.

Needless to say, we welcome specific, focused and actionable scrutiny on the GDP methodology, which will lead to constructive outcomes, but not such misleading commentaries and sweeping inferences. Particularly so when the high-frequency, economy-wide indicators corroborate the ongoing growth momentum implied by the headline GDP estimates.

Dev is chairman, Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister, Garg is secretary, Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation. This is co-authored with Antony Cyriac, Economic Adviser, MoSPI.

Viksit Bharat should be a whole-of-nation ambition



RAM RAJYA
BY RAM MADHAV

FOUR YEARS ago, during his 76th Independence Day address, Prime Minister Narendra Modi invoked the idea of Viksit Bharat for the first time. He gave a call for *pancha prana* — five pledges for the citizens of India, the first among which was the building of a developed India by the time the nation completes 100 years of its Independence in 2047. He called the 25-year road map *amrit kaal*. For the *amrit kaal* to succeed, citizens were called upon to take the other four pledges, too — freedom from the colonial mindset, pride in their own heritage, strengthening national integrity, and upholding civic responsibility.

The PM's vision was tall and daunting. NITI Aayog projected Viksit Bharat's economic targets as achieving \$15,000-18,000 per capita, five to six times the present levels, and taking the country's GDP to \$30 trillion, more than seven times the present level. For these targets to be achieved, the economy has to register a year-on-year GDP growth rate of at least 7 per cent for a long time. Only a few countries, such as China and Singapore, have been able to maintain such high growth rates for longer durations. But the Prime Minister is not a leader with empty dreams. Despite Covid and the global economic slowdown induced by it, despite US President Donald Trump's tantrums that caused serious economic and trade upheavals, and despite raging fears of an impending major global recession, Modi persisted with his agenda.

The result was a steady above 7 per cent GDP growth of our economy in the past three years. While the rest of the world struggled, we recovered quickly from Covid-induced sluggishness to register 7.3 per cent growth in 2023-24, 7.2 per cent in 2024-25 and 7.8 per cent in 2025-26. The controversy over the growth figures of 7.8 per cent for the first quarter of 2026-27 is petty and pessimistic given this track record.



In his Independence Day address this year, the Prime Minister continued his emphasis on Viksit Bharat by highlighting seven priorities, the *sapta dhara* — seven streams of the development agenda: Manufacturing power, agriculture and food processing, technology and innovation, infrastructure and connectivity, self-reliance in defence production, green and blue economy, and soft power. The Prime Minister underscored the need to reorient our approach in order to achieve

newer heights in these key sectors. "We have to change our work culture... we also have to change our thinking... We also have to accelerate the pace of reform," he insisted.

Historical transformations are rarely linear. Modi expressed a similar sentiment, saying, "the pace of work that was not achieved in five to seven decades, we have to achieve in the coming five to seven years". Countries like China that registered phenomenal progress witnessed such periods of accelerated change, which resulted in their take-off into the league of developed nations. During the two decades from 1978 to 1997, under Deng Xiaoping's vision and pragmatism, China raced ahead on the path to unstoppable development. In 1980, India and China were comparable in GDP size. In per capita terms, India was ahead with \$582 against China's \$307. Two decades later, in 2000, China surged ahead to a GDP of \$1.22 trillion while India was only able to reach \$468 billion. In per capita terms, too, China surged ahead to \$969 against India's \$442. During those two decades, China singularly focused on developing its manufacturing sector and emerged as the "factory of the world".

In the past couple of decades, with its advances in the services sector, India emerged as the "office of the world". But PM Modi is determined to achieve not incremental but spectacular growth in the next two decades. Why shouldn't there be 50 Indian companies in the Fortune 500 list? Why shouldn't Indian banks be among the top banks in the world? Shouldn't our consulting firms or accounting firms be among the top firms in the world?

The only answer to these questions raised by the PM is for the entire country — bureaucracy, state and local governments, industry and entrepreneurs, and leaders in all other sectors like agriculture, education, technology and innovation — to catch up with the pace of the PM. Viksit Bharat should be a "whole-of-the-nation" ambition.

The writer is national vice-president, BJP and president, India Foundation

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Trust the voters

THE EDITORIAL does some plain speaking about the 13 crore deletions across the nation ('Presumed guilty, SIR's spreading stain', *IE*, September 4). One shudders to imagine the rationale behind the ECI presuming each and every one to be guilty. One wishes that the ECI had trusted at least those who had already been proved to be Indian citizens instead of making them undergo such a cumbersome exercise.

Kumar Gupta, Panchkula

THE DELETION of 13 crore names from the voters' list is a matter of serious concern, and the process is still going on, so many more names of voters will be deleted ('Presumed guilty, SIR's spreading stain', *IE*, September 4). It seems that the SIR intends to disenfranchise more voters, especially those who belong to the minority community, and the credibility of the entire process is at stake. Transparency and complete impartiality are expected from the Election Commission. The process of adding deleted names back should not be Kafkaesque.

Hitesh Parmar, Rajkot

Energy fix

INDIA'S GROWING energy needs require better coordination across ministries and sectors ('We need one Ministry of Energy, not five', *IE*, September 4). Fragmented responsibilities can lead to delays, duplication and conflicting priorities. A more integrated institutional framework could help balance energy security, affordability and environmental commitments. Any restructuring, however, should preserve specialised expertise and accountability. The government should examine whether closer coordination or a unified ministry would improve planning and implementation. India needs a clear, long-term energy strategy rather than disconnected policy decisions.

BA Neboba, Perundurai



MANOJ KUMAR JHA

IT WAS, at the very least, heartening to hear the RSS chief speak at Madison Square Garden in New York in a language that reaffirmed India's inclusive character. His assertion that a Hindu who does not want Muslims in India cannot be a true Hindu was unambiguous. It was also a reminder of the elementary truth that Muslims do not live in India by anybody's permission. They are citizens of India. The important question is what happens to this inclusiveness when the political discourse returns home.

If a Hindu who does not want Muslims in India is not a true Hindu, what are we to make of the dog-whistles around Muslims? What are we to make of ministers and party functionaries who use polarising slogans and coded appeals to majoritarian anxieties? And of the silence of the organisational leadership when such language is used?

The RSS is the BJP's ideological fountainhead. Either the party's discourse has drifted from the parent body's teaching or it has not, in which case Madison Square Garden was an act of translation for a particular audience rather than a statement of principle. Also, statements of this kind are rarely spontaneous; they are responses to some pressure that has become difficult to contain. Was it the scrutiny of an inter-

It is not enough to say that Muslims belong in India. The political culture must stop producing the conditions under which their belonging is repeatedly questioned

national audience? Or, the arithmetic of politics that has begun to find polarisation yielding diminishing returns?

The RSS and the BJP cannot have two vocabularies of India. Gandhi would have found this distinction unsettling. His India was one in which the majority carried a moral responsibility for the security, dignity, and equal belonging of minorities. For him, Hinduism was inseparable from the capacity to recognise the humanity of the other. This was beautifully captured in the bhajan he cherished, 'Vaishnav Jan To Tene Kahiye', where religiosity is measured by one's ability to feel another's pain and respond to it. That was his idea of faith and, ultimately, of India.

Nehru translated a similar intuition into the language of the modern republic because he understood that diversity was the substance of the nation. That is also why we should be wary of the language of "tolerance", which can suggest that the majority has the power to permit the minority to exist. Constitutional citizenship begins with the equal claim of every citizen to dignity, security and belonging.

It is therefore not enough to say that Muslims belong in India. The political culture must stop producing the conditions under which their belonging is repeatedly ques-

Two vocabularies: One for New York, one for home

tioned. There is a difference between an explicit statement of inclusion and an environment in which exclusion is constantly suggested without being formally declared. This is how the boundaries of citizenship begin to shift through language. The danger is greater when such language comes from those in positions of power. A chief minister's remark or a powerful organisation's calculated silence has weight. It tells citizens what can be said, whom it is acceptable to mock, and whose anxieties deserve political attention.

That is why the RSS chief's statement deserves to be noted, but cannot be viewed in isolation from the larger context. If the assertion is sincere, it should travel to every political rally in India, and the polarising discourses should be done away with forever. Such statements should be heard wherever Muslims are turned into electoral shorthand, their patriotism questioned, their names, food, dress or faith made into political ammunition. They should be heard inside party meetings and cabinet rooms. It may be pragmatic to embrace the language of pluralism abroad, but the real test is whether we are willing to practise it at home. The idea of India is meaningful only when every citizen feels equally secure in belonging to it.

The writer is Member of Parliament (Rajya Sabha), Rashtriya Janata Dal



MEGHNA BAL

META RECENTLY settled a \$17.1 billion case with several US states concerning allegations about its impact on children's mental health. The company must make several changes to its apps, including incorporating daily usage limits and "nighttime blocks" for teenagers, "enhanced age assurance measures" to prevent children from using them and the de-personalisation of feeds, meaning that a child's feed would serve random content rather than content tailored to their interests.

Many have hailed the decision as a step towards holding platforms accountable. But such framing is problematic because it places the platform, rather than the child, at

the centre of the problem. Once platforms become the focus, the policy response gravitates towards imposing more obligations on them. Asking what more platforms can be required to do is not the same as asking what children really need to be safer online.

The first problem with a platform-centric child safety approach is that it often produces measures that are difficult to enforce. The requirement for Meta to introduce age-gating is one example. Children are sophisticated and motivated users of technology and find ways around such measures.

The second is that such an approach can ignore what children need to be safe or have positive experiences online. The move to restrict personalisation illustrates this tension. Poorly designed recommendation systems can expose children to harmful content, but removing personalisation does not auto-

matically make a service safer. It may expose children to irrelevant or inappropriate material, while making it harder for educational or support services to reach them.

Instead of focusing on eliminating every risk from the online environment, decision-makers must look at how to equip children to deal with those risks as we do in the physical world: What not to share, how to respond to unsolicited contact, how to recognise ma-

For many children, digital spaces provide support that may not be available offline. LGBTQIA+ children and those experiencing abuse may use online platforms to find information or help

nipulation, when to block or report someone, and when to seek help. Yet digital literacy and sensitisation receive far less policy attention. India has made a nod to such an approach, with the 2026 Economic Survey calling for a digital wellness curriculum in schools. It remains to be seen how widely and appropriately this will be implemented.

The third problem is that for many children, digital spaces provide community, expression and support that may not be available offline. LGBTQIA+ children, those experiencing neglect or abuse, and socially isolated children may use online platforms to find information, companionship or help. Children's online participation is also not confined to one platform. If one service becomes too restrictive or cumbersome, they can simply migrate to platforms with weaker protections.

Focus on the children, not the platform

The fourth problem is that children's online engagement is often shaped by their offline environment. In India, screens may not necessarily be displacing abundant offline opportunities but filling a vacuum. Many children lack access to safe public spaces or affordable recreational facilities. If policymakers want children to spend less time online, they must also ask what children are being offered offline.

None of this absolves platforms of responsibility. But approaches more in touch with children's engagement online are likely to be more effective. This requires addressing the entire ecology of childhood: Platforms, parents, schools, communities, public spaces and children themselves.

The writer is director of the Esysa Centre, a New Delhi-based think tank. Views are personal

‘Filled with mud like toothpaste in tube’: Why tunnel rescue is a challenge

Sheikh Saaliq & Shristi Kaffle
New Delhi, September 4

RESCUERS IN Nepal have been combing through dark, debris-filled tunnels at hydropower plants, looking for hundreds of missing workers feared trapped in the flash flood.

But access to the tunnels has been hampered by thick mud, debris and damaged infrastructure, making it difficult for rescue teams to reach workers.

Mohan Kumar Dangi, president of the Independent Power Producers Association of Nepal, said floods damaged at least 12 hydropower projects in Rasuwa and Nuwakot districts, with a combined capacity of 670 MW. Four were under construction, seven operational and one in testing phase, he said. Hydropower projects undergo risk assessments and other studies before construction, but the flooding was “something unimaginable,” Dangi said.

The biggest challenge for rescuers is reaching those trapped. Many of Nepal’s hydropower projects are in remote, mountainous areas where steep terrain and narrow roads can make access difficult. Flooding has worsened conditions, damaging roads and limiting routes to some sites.

Rescuers also are facing tunnels that are blocked or damaged. The floods swept mud, huge rocks and debris into underground passages, collapsing sections and trapping workers. Even where tunnel entrances are accessible, crews must clear large amounts of debris before reaching deeper sections. Debris is obscuring the lo-

cations of workers.

Filmmaker and drone pilot Manish Maharjan, who has been volunteering with the Nepalese army, said some tunnels were “filled with mud like toothpaste in a tube.” At one hydropower project, he used a drone to search to the end of a tunnel but found no sign of life. Some workers called for help during the early hours after the floods, while others who escaped said their colleagues remained underground. It was not clear whether rescuers had since made contact with those workers or whether they were still alive.

People trapped underground may survive without food for some time, but limited drinking water and breathable air can quickly become life-threatening.

Anil Pokhrel, a disaster risk reduction expert and former head of Nepal’s disaster authority, said the flooding exposed weaknesses in Nepal’s rescue capacity. He said rescuers lost valuable time locating the tunnel’s exact entry point and coordinates and lacked heavy equipment and adequately trained personnel. “Harsh and remote locations with inclement weather worsened the situation. Also, we didn’t have adequately trained human resources to undertake such operations,” he said. Nepal has more than a century of experience building tunnels but remains poorly prepared for complex tunnel rescues, Pokhrel said. “We are focused on tunnel design and construction but are not adequately prepared for rescue operations,” he said. AP

OVER 1,300 PEOPLE HAVE BEEN KILLED WHILE 5,600 ARE STILL MISSING

9 days after floods, 2 men rescued from Nepal tunnel

Both workers are in intensive care at an army hospital

Yubaraj Ghimire
Kathmandu, September 4

SEARCH TEAM managed to rescue two workers alive from a tunnel linked to a hydropower station on Nepal’s Trishuli River on Friday, nine days after the flood ravaged the site and cut it off from the rest of the world. More than 1,300 people have died so far while over 5,600 are still missing.

Authorities believe the August 26 collapse of a glacier on the upper reaches of the river trapped at least 900 people in tunnels related to six hydropower projects. The two workers pulled from the tunnel at the Upper Trishuli 3A Hydropower Station are the first to be rescued from the hydropower projects and have been taken to an army hospital in Kathmandu, giving search teams some hope as the possibility of finding other survivors fades.

Videos released by Nepali authorities showed Kabir Maharjan being hoisted from a hole in the ground as bystanders cheered, then lowered onto a stretcher. His colleague Sanjay Sah was brought out on a worker’s back, his face still caked in mud, before army doctors fitted an oxygen mask and checked his vitals inside a rescue tent.

Sah, a mechanical foreman, later described staying behind in a control room to help others escape after he urged colleagues to flee upon hearing news of the disaster.



Sanjay Sah being rescued from a tunnel at the Trishuli 3A hydropower project, nine days after the Bhotekohi flash floods, in Rasuwa district, on Friday. PTI

• Major rescue operations

2023, INDIA: Rescuers drilled through rock, concrete, and earth to free 41 workers trapped for 17 days inside the Silkyara tunnel in Uttarakhand.

2018, THAILAND: A group of 12 boys and their soccer coach exploring Thailand’s Tham Luang cave complex became trapped in a flooded cave network when sudden rain blocked the exit. After a multi-day international search, divers rescued all 13 alive.

2010, CHILE: Thirty-three miners trapped for two months after a collapse at the San José mine in Chile’s Atacama desert were rescued.

2007, AUSTRALIA: All 54

miners trapped underground by a fire at Western Australia’s Kanowna Belle gold mine were rescued. The blaze began in a Caterpillar truck operating inside the mine.

2006, AUSTRALIA: Seventeen miners were working in Tasmania’s Beaconsfield gold mine when it collapsed. Fourteen escaped immediately, one was killed, and two were rescued after surviving for two weeks about a kilometer underground.

2002, UNITED STATES: Nine trapped miners were rescued from the Quecreek Mine in Pennsylvania in July 2002 after more than 77 hours underground.

REUTERS

“I was in the control room, so my responsibility was to save everyone’s lives. When there was such a big accident, it was

not right for me to run away,” he said in a video recording shared by Nepali authorities.

Sah told rescuers he spent

time reciting mantras (verses from a prayer) while he was trapped. He said he had been in contact with three or four more people in the tunnel, while others could still be alive deeper in its reaches. At least 1,287 people have been killed in Nepal in the floods that swept away houses, streets and schools in towns and villages near the border with China’s Tibet, the disaster management authority said on Friday. More than 5,080 are still missing.

China has put the death toll in Tibet at 21, with 541 others listed as missing. Both men are now in intensive care at an army hospital and their vital signs are stable, a source from the facility said.

Mechanical supervisor Maharjan cannot move his hands or legs, but Sah’s injuries are not considered critical, according to an aide to the energy minister.

WITH INPUTS FROM REUTERS

US probes strike on Iran wedding that killed at least 5 and injured 70

Analysis shows it was likely a direct hit by US munition

Reuters
Washington, September 4

US VICE President JD Vance said that the United States was investigating a deadly strike on an Iranian wedding earlier this week that an analysis published by Reuters showed likely resulted from a direct hit by a US munition.

An explosion that ripped through a wedding celebration



The house that came under attack in Kuhestak village. REUTERS

in southern Iran on Tuesday likely resulted from a direct hit by a US munition and not a ricochet off another target, according to an analysis on

Thursday by weapons experts who reviewed images and video verified by Reuters.

The United States has not accepted responsibility for the incident. President Donald Trump’s administration is facing growing domestic public pressure to end a war that is weighing on his approval ratings ahead of crucial November midterm elections.

Iranian state television on Thursday said that a 22-year-old woman had died in hospital following the strike that hit a home during a wedding, taking the total reported death toll to five. Iranian officials said that nearly 70 were wounded.

Netanyahu allies renew calls for expulsion of Gazans as election nears

Rami Ayyub
Jerusalem, September 4

TWO ISRAELI ministers floated proposals this week for the mass removal of Palestinians from the Gaza Strip, resurfacing an idea voiced repeatedly by right-wing politicians over the past three years as they seek to rally supporters ahead of an election.

The calls by two of Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu’s political allies have revived Palestinian fears that Israel ultimately aims to forcibly expel them from Gaza despite US-led

diplomatic efforts to end the conflict there. Far-right security minister Itamar Ben-Gvir laid out a seven-year plan for removing Gaza’s population through “voluntary emigration” during a press conference on Thursday night. He said he would seek the creation of a “ministry in charge of emigration” in the next government.

“Instead of illusions of peace now, we need actions of emigration now,” he said. “Instead of (them) digging tunnels, it’s time to pack suitcases,” referring to tunnels dug under Gaza by Hamas before the war. REUTERS

Israel says it has cleared Hezbollah fighters from tunnels under key Lebanon ridge

Reuters
Beirut, Jerusalem, September 4

ISRAEL’S MILITARY has cleared Hezbollah fighters holed up in tunnels under the strategic Ali al-Taher ridge in southern Lebanon, Israeli Defense Minister Israel Katz said on Friday, though the Iran-backed group did not immediately comment.

Israel had said Hezbollah fighters were embedded in tunnels under the ridge, which overlooks a wide area and had become one of the most hotly contested areas in the Israel-Hezbollah war, despite a ceasefire announced in June.

“The mission was completed and the tunnels were cleared of terrorists,” Katz said on social media, after a statement by the military late on Thursday saying it had operational control of the ridge.

The military said some Hezbollah fighters had been “eliminated”, while others had fled. Hezbollah did not immediately respond to a request for comment and Reuters was not able to independently verify the status of the ridge.

World food prices highest since 2022 as supply risks mount: FAO

Gus Trompiz
Paris, September 4

WORLD FOOD prices rose in August to their highest since late 2022, as adverse weather and war disruption in the Black Sea heightened concern over supply of staples, the United Nations’ Food and Agriculture Organization said on Friday.

Extreme heat and drought in Europe, the threat of a severe El Nino weather pattern and

trade upheaval caused by the Ukraine and Iran wars have unsettled agricultural markets, pushing grain prices to three-year highs and sugar to a one-year peak.

The FAO Food Price Index, which tracks monthly changes in a basket of internationally traded food commodities, averaged 133.3 points in August, up from July’s revised reading of 130.8. That was the highest score since November 2022, though



Heatwaves and drought have increased climate risks for farmers. FILE/REUTERS

nearly 17% below a record peak from March 2022, after Russia’s

full-scale invasion of Ukraine.

“August’s increase in global food prices is a warning that the risk premium is returning to food markets: climate shocks, geopolitical tensions and disrupted trade logistics are converging to tighten supply expectations,” FAO Chief Economist Maximo Torero said in a statement.

The FAO’s price benchmarks for cereals, vegetable oils, sugar, meat and dairy all

rose in August. The extreme weather in Europe affected prospects for the maize and sugar beet harvests as well as livestock output, while the anticipated El Nino phenomenon fuelled concerns for palm oil and sugar output in Asia, it said.

Escalating attacks in the Black Sea have curtailed grain shipments from Russia and Ukraine during war, while the US-Iran conflict was straining flows of fertilisers. REUTERS

• FOR CRITICS, THE CARTS ARE RUNNING AMOK, PARKING ILLEGALLY, WORSENING CONGESTION AND UNLOCKING ANOTHER LEVEL OF OVERTOURISM

Rome mounts a crackdown on golf carts that are increasingly popular with tourists

David Biller & Lorenzo Gironacci
Rome, September 4

BENEATH THE splendor of its monuments and ruins, Rome is taking aim at a modern-day chariot: the golf cart.

Hundreds of them have started carrying tourists through the historic center. Even rolling along at a moderate speed, these golf carts have so far outpaced regulation. But the city is mounting a crackdown.

For critics, the carts are running amok, parking illegally, worsening congestion and unlocking another level of overtourism. Some local media invoke sensational language,

calling it an “invasion” and saying Rome is being “held hostage by golf carts.”

Advocates argue carts are silent, occupy less space than tourist vans and buses and don’t choke the air with exhaust that also stains historic monuments.

Ruth Sanderson from Manchester, England, surprised her husband with the tour for his birthday during their first trip to Rome. They could see the major sights in three hours and “just potter around” for the rest of their short stay, said Sanderson.

Their guide swung around the basilica where Pope Francis is buried then headed to the Spanish Steps, where he parked in an area exclusively for car-

sharing — the first of several illegal spots he snagged.

“We don’t have a proper stop for golf carts, so we park where we can — as legal as possible,” driver Martin Halili explained to them. Even before the golf cart boom, parking was a pain. Cars, vans, Vespas and motorcycles are stationed atop curbs, crosswalks and medians. Trucks double-park while unloading.

Any spare cranny is claimed in Rome’s historic center because there are only 4,300 regular on-street spots available, about one-quarter the number of cars owned by the area’s residents, according to the city’s transport chief, citing a field survey conducted last year. Plus, an



A golf cart near the Colosseum in Rome. FILE/AP

average 50,000 vehicles enter daily. Unsurprisingly, some residents are unhappy.

“This was the last straw be-

cause, unfortunately, there has already been traffic here for a long time, since there are too many categories of vehicles

authorized,” Luigi la Licata, head of the Monti neighborhood association, told the AP. “The golf cart is the most obvious one — and the latest — but there are many others.”

Golf cart bookings this summer grew 147% from 2024, according to TripAdvisor, whose subsidiary Viator is the biggest source of passengers. Rome has as many as 500 carts, with one-fifth belonging to the Metur association of tour operators, established last December to seek common ground with locals and the city. “Overtourism is a real problem, and we’re not denying it. And maybe we’re also part of it in a way. But if we’re part of it, then at least be part of it in a

Russia hit Ukraine’s security service HQ in Kyiv: Zelenskyy



Firefighters work at the site that was hit by a Russian drone in Kyiv region in Ukraine on Friday. REUTERS

Samiya Kullab
Kyiv, September 4

A RUSSIAN drone struck the headquarters of Ukraine’s security service in central Kyiv, President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Friday, ahead of diplomatic talks with US officials on ending the war.

The air war between Russia and Ukraine has intensified as the conflict stretches toward five years since Moscow’s invasion of its neighbor.

Zelenskyy wrote on Telegram that acting security chief Oleksandr Poklad had briefed him on a response to Russia’s attacks. The security service headquarters, near the historic St. Sophia Cathedral and international hotels, is among the agencies carrying out deep strike operations inside Russian territory. Twelve people were wounded in the attack, local authorities said.

“The drone was deliberately targeted at the head of the SBU’s office in that building. I instructed Poklad to respond appropriately, significantly, and, if possible, in kind to the Russians for this attack,” Zelenskyy said.

Ukrainian Foreign Minister Andrii Sybiha called the strike a “major escalation” that came as potential peace talks were building momentum.

“Moscow launched this strike during a renewed push for peace — laying bare its true rejection of diplomacy,” he said in a post on X.

A US official said Friday that US envoys Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner will travel to Moscow and then Kyiv over the weekend and into early next week. The official, who was not authorized to comment publicly and spoke on condition of anonymity, did not have more specific timing for the stops. AP

• BRIEFLY

ROMANIA

Tate indicted for trafficking minors, money laundering



Andrew Tate. REUTERS

they have been under criminal investigation in the country on charges including human trafficking since December 2022. Romanian prosecutors said the Tates recruited their victims by seducing them and falsely claiming to want a relationship or marriage, before forcing them to produce pornographic content for a webcam business. REUTERS

ROMANIAN PROSECUTORS officially indicted social media influencer Andrew Tate on Friday for trafficking minors, money laundering, sex with a minor and witness tampering and his brother Tristan for complicity, years after they began investigating them. The Tate brothers, former kickboxers with dual US and British citizenship, were arrested in Miami in late July after Britain requested their extradition. Mainly based in Romania since 2017,

NIGERIA

Dozens die after inhaling fumes in bid to steal oil

At least 37 people died in Nigeria’s oil-producing Rivers state as they were trying to steal oil from a loading vessel, an advocacy group said Friday. The Youths and Environmental Advocacy Centre said the victims were siphoning crude products into their boats from an “illegal tapping point” on Thursday. It caused them to inhale toxic fumes at high pressure, leading to their deaths. Many are still missing, according to the report. AP

UNITED ARAB EMIRATES

Poet facing 10 years in jail pardoned

EGYPTIAN-TURKISH poet Abdulrahman Youssef al-Qaradawi was pardoned by UAE President Sheikh Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan on Friday, a week after receiving a 10-year jail sentence following his extradition from Lebanon. Qaradawi, son of late senior Muslim cleric Youssef al-Qaradawi, was arrested in Lebanon in December 2024 after making critical comments about the UAE, Saudi Arabian and Egyptian authorities in a video. REUTERS

EXCHANGE'S LISTING COULD BE THE COUNTRY'S BIGGEST EVER

NSE gets SEBI nod for IPO, may eye listing this month

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, September 4

THE DECKS have been cleared for what may be the country's biggest-ever listing, as the markets regulator has approved the estimated Rs 30,000 crore IPO of the National Stock Exchange (NSE), over two months after it filed the papers, and about a decade after it first tried to hit the primary market.

The country's largest stock exchange may get listed as soon as this month, reports suggested.

The approval clears a key regulatory hurdle for the exchange after it had first filed its IPO papers back in June. The price band for the issue is likely to be announced on September 15, with plans to list in the week starting September 21, *Reuters* reported, citing unnamed sources.

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) issued an observation letter with the green light to NSE on Friday. With the path now clear, the issue could end up as the country's biggest-ever IPO, surpassing Hyundai Motor India's Rs 27,870 crore issue in 2024. The unlisted market indicates a valuation of around Rs 5 lakh crore for the exchange.

The valuation and the amount raised now depend on the price band of the issue.

Rival BSE had raised Rs 1,243.43 crore through its public issue back in 2017. The stock has since gained nearly 29 times from its listing price, becoming among the most lucrative stocks in the market.

NSE dominates India's equity derivatives market and is the world's most active derivatives exchange by contracts traded. It also leads BSE in terms of revenues, market share, and

● India's biggest IPOs



Company	Year	Amount raised
Hyundai Motor	2024	₹27,859 Cr
LIC	2022	₹20,557 Cr
Paytm	2021	₹18,300 Cr
Tata Capital	2025	₹15,512 Cr
Coal India	2010	₹15,199 Cr
HDB Financial Services	2025	₹12,500 Cr
Reliance Power	2008	₹11,544 Cr
LG Electronics India	2025	₹11,607 Cr
Swiggy	2024	₹11,327 Cr
General Insurance	2017	₹11,176 Cr

SOURCE: EXCHANGES, OFFER DOCUMENTS

liquidity. It will also be interesting to see if the regulator allows NSE's shares to trade on its own exchange through the "permitted-to-trade" route.

What is the IPO structure

The issue will entirely be an offer for sale (OFS) of 14.89 crore shares, representing around 6% of the exchange's stake.

Funds raised via OFS are pocketed by selling shareholders and are not utilised in a company's business. SBI will offload up to 2.48 crore shares in the OFS. MS Strategic (Mauritius) will sell up to 1.6 crore shares. Other major listed entities offloading some of their

stakes include Bank of Baroda, General Insurance Company of India, and the New India Assurance Company. Shares of many of these companies have skyrocketed in the run-up to the issue.

For example, shares of New India Assurance shot up over 18% on Friday.

In fact, the stock has gained 34% over just a month. Having bought shares early on at an average cost of under a rupee, the IPO, which targets high valuations, is expected to unlock significant cash for the likes of SBI, Bank of Baroda, and the insurance companies.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Why Tata Chemicals' Kenya ops are halted

George Mathew
Mumbai, September 4

KENYAN PRESIDENT William Ruto's order to halt Tata Chemicals' operations in the African nation has put the Tata Group company on the defensive, with the firm saying on Friday it remained committed to resolving the dispute through "constructive engagement" with the Kenyan government and the relevant legal and regulatory authorities.

This is the second major dispute between Kenya and an Indian entity after Adani group's Nairobi airport project was cancelled by the African nation.

The current dispute centres on Tata Chemicals Magadi Ltd (TCML), which operates a soda ash plant at Magadi in Kenya's Kajiado County. The company, Africa's largest producer of natural soda ash, has been operating the facility for decades and says it remains fully compliant with regulatory requirements.

Here is what the dispute is about, what the Kenyan President has alleged, and what Tata Chemicals has said it plans to do.

The issue

The immediate issue is a dispute between TCML and the Kenyan Ministry of Mining, Blue Economy and Maritime Affairs over matters relating to the company's operations and regulatory compliance. TCML said it has acknowledged an official communication from the Ministry dated July 28, 2026, and has submitted a comprehensive response to the matters raised by the government.

According to the company, it provided all the required information, reports and documentation to the Ministry on August 11. "TCML is fully compliant with the regulatory requirements," the company said in an exchange filing on Friday. The company is now awaiting the Ministry's review of its submissions and further direction.

The dispute has, however, escalated after President William Ruto publicly said that he had ordered Tata Chemicals to stop its operations and indicated that the Kenyan government would bring in two new

companies to take over the operations.

Kenyan President's allegation

Ruto has criticised Tata Chemicals over what he said was a lack of investment and development in Kajiado, where the Magadi operation is located. "That Tata company ... had that contract for 100 years. They have not built anything in Kajiado, they have not built any factory in Kajiado," Ruto said.

He also said the government would bring in two new companies to take over Tata Chemicals' operations.

Ruto's main accusation is that Tata has extracted Kenya's mineral resources without providing enough economic benefit to the local area or country. Specifically, he says Tata has operated under a very long-term contract but hasn't built sufficient local industrial facilities. It has largely exported soda ash rather than creating more value-added manufacturing in Kenya. It hasn't generated enough local

jobs, investment and industrial development relative to the resources it extracts and failed to meet what the government considers adequate obligations concerning the local community.

Meanwhile, Ruto's opponents allege the government's real motive is control of the area's other mineral resources.

Tata Chemicals, however, has said that the Magadi operation has played an important role in the Kenyan economy since it acquired the plant in 2005.

Legally strong, politically sensitive

Magadi is in Kajiado County, where questions surrounding land, mineral wealth, employment and community benefits are politically sensitive. Tata's legal position is considered strong because its rights stem from a 1928 lease granted by the Kenyan government and subsequently extended in 2004. The lease provides Tata with extensive rights over the Magadi deposits and runs until 2053. This political

context helps clarify the appeal of President Ruto's claim that Tata has exercised control over the resource for "100 years," despite the far more complicated legal history underlying that assertion, say reports from Kenya.

There has already been a major dispute with Kajiado County over payments. The county demanded billions of shillings in alleged land rates and royalties, while Tata challenged the claims, arguing that the relevant mineral rights and payments were governed by its agreement with the national government rather than the county. In October 2025, Kenya's Court of Appeal substantially sided with Tata, according to reports from Kenya.

According to the National Council for Law Reporting (Kenya Law), the court ruled that the county's demand of about Kenyan shilling 1745 billion was not payable as claimed and found that the county's closure of Tata's operations had breached Tata's lease and its constitutional property rights.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

FX reserves surge to new all-time high of \$740.8 bn

Reuters
Mumbai, September 4

INDIA'S FOREIGN exchange reserves climbed to another record high of \$740.8 billion in the week to August 28, central bank data showed on Friday, boosted by heavy inflows from special schemes to attract dollar inflows into the country.

India's FX pile has risen for nine straight weeks, jumping by almost \$75 billion during this period, with the latest figure comfortably surpassing \$729.33 for week ended August 21.

In June, India unveiled discounted hedging facilities for overseas borrowings by state-run firms and banks, and a free-of-cost hedging facility for banks to raise overseas FX deposits.

The Reserve Bank of India received over \$136 billion under these schemes between June 5 and August 31, including about \$127 billion from non-resident Indian deposits.

For the week, the rupee rose 0.3% against the dollar to 95.3775.

The inflow will give the RBI strong spot FX reserves which can be used to stabilise or strengthen the rupee, HSBC said in a note.

Changes in foreign currency assets, expressed in dollar terms, include the effect of appreciation or depreciation of other currencies held in its reserves.

Foreign exchange reserves include India's Reserve Tranche position in the International Monetary Fund.

● BRIEFLY

RBI absorbs Rs 6.02 lakh cr as liquidity surplus hits record high

Mumbai: The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Friday absorbed over Rs 6.02 lakh crore from the banking system through two variable rate reverse repo (VRRR) auctions as surplus liquidity remained at a record high. The central bank received and accepted bids worth Rs 5,41,975 crore in a three-day VRRR auction against the notified amount of Rs 7 lakh crore. The auction was conducted at a cut-off rate of 5.24%. PTI

Norms allowing e-comm cos to keep inventory notified by govt

New Delhi: The Department of Economic Affairs under the finance ministry has notified changes in FDI norms to allow e-commerce firms to maintain inventory only for export purposes. These firms will have to export goods manufactured or produced in India. Also, FDI in inventory-based e-commerce retailing has not been permitted. The department in a September 2 notification has added a provision in this regard in the Foreign Exchange Management (Non-debt Instruments) Rules, 2019. PTI

SEBI moves to recover Hindenburg trade gains

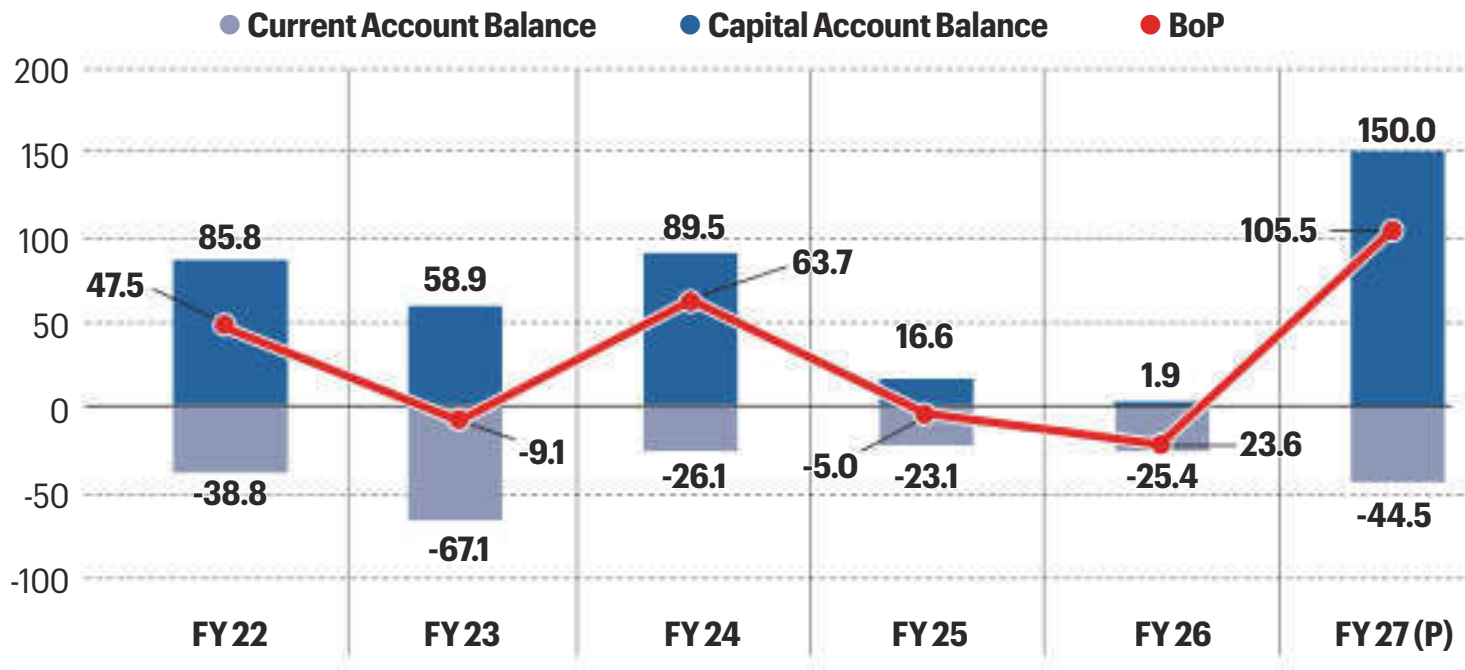
New Delhi: The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) has started hearing representations as it seeks to recover gains from trades it suspects benefited from prior knowledge of Hindenburg Research's scathing report about Adani Group, two people with knowledge of the matter said. The SEBI in 2024 said US-based Kingdon Capital Management built short positions in Adani-related stocks through a Mauritius-based fund linked to Kotak International before Hindenburg published its report. REUTERS

SEBI, ESMA ink pact to boost cooperation

New Delhi: Market regulator SEBI and its European counterpart ESMA have inked a pact to deepen regulatory cooperation and information sharing on central counterparties (CCPs) under the Indian market watchdog's oversight. The MoU replaces an earlier pact signed between the two regulators on June 21, 2017. The pact provides a framework for SEBI and ESMA to cooperate in line with their respective laws and regulations. PTI

● BoP TO MOVE TO A LARGE SURPLUS IN FY27

The government raised around \$127.2 billion through FCNR(B) as the window closed on August 31. FDI is resilient too. Net FDI rose 15.9% on-year to \$6.1 billion in Q1FY27. Ratings agency CareEdge expects the capital account surplus — which happens when the total inflow of foreign capital exceeds the total outflow of capital — to rise to \$150 billion. With the current account deficit projected at \$44 billion (1% of GDP), the overall balance of payments (BoP) is expected to record a surplus of \$106 billion in FY27, compared with a deficit of \$23 billion in FY26, the agency said.



FIGURES IN BILLION DOLLARS. SOURCE: CAREEDGE

Rupee at 5-week high amid RBI intervention

Mumbai: The Indian rupee ended largely unchanged Friday, but posted its best weekly performance against the US dollar in five weeks, helped by stronger-than-expected dollar inflows into the central bank's special schemes.

The rupee moved in a narrow six paise range before ending at 94.4850, aided by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), which intervened at the start of the session and continued to sell dollars thereafter, traders said.

For the week, however, the currency gained 0.9%, posting its biggest rise against the dollar since the week ended July 31, aided by heavy RBI intervention. The rupee was also supported by an influx of dollars that far exceeded estimates.

The RBI repeatedly sold dollars near the open through the week. The central bank's increasingly forceful intervention comes as its special schemes drew more than \$136 billion in June-August. Its stepped-up presence has reinforced expectations that the RBI is using its increased firepower. REUTERS

Play leading role in skilling push: Govt tells industry

Press Trust of India
Mumbai, September 4

THE GOVERNMENT has urged industry to take a leading role in transforming the country's skilling landscape through the ambitious Rs 60,000 crore PM-SETU initiative to drive India's energy and industrial transformation.

The Pradhan Mantri Skilling and Employability Transformation through Upgraded ITIs (PM-SETU) scheme envisages enhancing the overall quality and relevance of vocational training with upgraded labs, machines, and industry-aligned curriculum in the country. Speaking on the concluding day of Bharat Electricity 2026, co-located with POWERGEN India and Indian Utility Week on Thursday, Debashree Mukherjee, Secretary, Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship (MSDE), outlined the government's vision for a future-ready workforce equipped to drive India's energy and industrial transformation.

She noted that industry partners will now have a con-

trolling 51% stake in Section 8 companies managing ITI clusters, with the government and states providing the bulk of funding and industry's 17% share eligible under CSR. This model puts curriculum design, technology adoption, and skill development directly in industry's hands, ensuring our workforce keeps pace with the demands of the energy and manufacturing sectors, Mukherjee added.

She also cited ArcelorMittal's leadership in the Vizag cluster as a benchmark for transformation. Organised by The Energy & Climate Initiatives Society (ENCIS), Bharat Electricity, POWERGEN India & Indian Utility Week 2026 concluded on Thursday, bringing together over 15,000 professionals, 250 exhibitors, and 150 global thought leaders from over 40 countries. The event highlighted India's energy transition, next-generation utility solutions, and the critical importance of workforce development and collaborative innovation to power the nation's future.

CIBIL, Equifax, CRIF fined by RBI for late compensation

New Delhi: The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Fridays said it had fined TransUnion CIBIL, CRIF High Mark, and Equifax Rs 26.8 lakh, Rs 6.9 lakh, and Rs 1.2 lakh, respectively, for providing delayed compensation to complainants.

This came after a statutory inspection of the three credit bureaus' positions at the end of 2024-25.

The central bank also levied a fine of Rs 6.2 lakh on Hinduja Leyland Finance for not having a board-approved policy on pricing of microfinance loans and undertaking activities "in the nature of 'synthetic securitisation'". Sammaan Finserve was fined Rs 4.2 lakh for not reporting borrower credit data to the Central Repository of Information on Large Credits. ENS

● MINUTES IS NOT YET AS OPERATIONALLY SOUND AS BLINKIT, ACCORDING TO UBS

Flipkart Minutes closes in on Blinkit's order value

ENS Economic Bureau
Bengaluru, September 4

FLIPKART'S QUICK commerce arm Minutes has narrowed the gap with market leader Blinkit on order value, with its strength in mobiles and electronics pushing its overall basket above the incumbent's, according to channel checks by UBS.

Excluding mobile phones, Minutes' net order value stands at Rs 500-530, marginally below Blinkit's average net order value of Rs 518 in Q1FY27, the checks showed. Including mobile phones, Minutes' order value is higher than Blinkit's, reflecting Flipkart's established position in mobiles and electronics. Swiggy's Instamart reported a net average order value of Rs 508 in Q1FY27, leaving all three platforms clustered within a narrow



Flipkart is now using Minutes to draw customers for fresh, beauty and personal care and other immediate-use categories. REUTERS

band. Amazon's quick commerce arm Amazon Now seems to be lagging well behind, at an average order value of Rs 400-450, despite growing from Rs 260-300 in UBS' April 2026 checks, the report added. That is

a gross figure, and would fall further on a net basis, making the gap wider than it appears.

Minutes' category mix was more mobile-heavy in its first year but has since broadened. Flipkart is now using the plat-

form to draw customers into its ecosystem for fresh, beauty and personal care and other immediate-use categories, reversing a migration in which shoppers had increasingly turned to standalone quick commerce apps for

such purchases, the report added. In locations where Minutes is live, 40-45% of customers visiting Flipkart also visit Minutes. Metro markets contribute 60-65% of demand, with north India accounting for slightly under a third and south India scaling rapidly, it added.

Minutes is not yet as operationally efficient as Blinkit, according to the checks, with gross margins still below the market leader's even as cost per order in most cities has moved closer to Blinkit and Instamart levels. Its advertising revenue is broadly in line with leading peers. On pricing, UBS' tracker showed Minutes cut discounts by 20-60 basis points month-on-month in August to 22% on its core offering and 23% on XtraSaver, against 18-19% at Blinkit and 21% at both Instamart and Zepto. FE

● Q1FY27 NUMBERS

MINUTES' NET order value stands at Rs 500-530, excluding mobile phones, while Blinkit's net average net order value was Rs 518

MINUTES' CATEGORY mix was more mobile-heavy in its first year but has since broadened

MINUTES IS not yet as operationally sound as Blinkit, with gross margins still trailing

Shubhra Gupta

FIRST THINGS first. Those who thought that there was very little juice left in the *Mirzapur* series — which started with a bang in 2018, stayed steady in its 2020 second season, and dwindled by its third in 2024 — and that included me, were off the mark.

The worst part about the third season, weighed under by distinct signs of wear and tear, was the near-absence of Pankaj Tripathi in and as Kaleen Bhaiyya, whose crafty game of thrones gave us a whole new vocabulary — the alliterative *bauchaar* of *bhaiyya*, *bahubali*, *bhaaukaal*, along with the enthusiastic sprinkling of *maas* and *behens* was relentless.

I'm happy to report that Kaleen Bhaiyya is back. Smart move, because without him, I would have had zero interest in the goings-on in this *Gangs Of Wasseypur* lite saga. Much of the old cast is

The challenge facing director Gurmmeet Singh and writer Puneet Krishna was always going to be to land on the right balance of the familiar and fresh. On that score, the film powers through



Alive and Still Kicking

back too. Munna (Divyendu Sharma), the son and putative heir of the Mirzapur gaddi, is still struggling for his daddy's approval. Guddu (Ali Fazal) and Bablu (Jitendra Kumar replacing Vikrant Massey), the two local lads drawn into Kaleen Bhaiyya's seductive orbit, are still up against their straight-laced father's (Rajesh Tailang) disapproval. The battle for the Mirzapur gaddi, an ongoing pursuit, pitchforks a few new characters into the mix, chief of which is Ravi Kishan as Babban Yadav, the ambitious nephew of a greedy politician, with an eye on the main chance.

The challenge facing director Gurmmeet Singh and writer Puneet Krishna was always going to be to land on the right balance of the familiar and fresh: on that score, *Mirzapur: The Movie* powers through the 197 minutes, letting us feel the length in some patches which feel both superfluous and rushed; and no, just because it's a film, we don't need an item song, or two. Just no.

In a series split over six years and three seasons, it's easy to leisurely build your

characters and situations. Despite its length, needs to scrunch, and can yet be in danger of feeling like a stretch.

Predictably, in this all-boys' show, it's the women whose presence is scaled down. It begins with Sweetie (Shriya Pilgaonkar) and Golu (Shweta Tripathi) as the sisters Guddu and Bablu are sweet on: I'm just relieved that Golu's completely unconvincing progress towards a tough-talking, gun-toting female don is scotched in the bud, my other bugbear in the third season. As the boys' sister, Dimpy (Harshita Gaur) is barely there. Sonal Chauhan has a longer part as Mumtaz Bibi, Babban's woman. But it is Sheeba Chaddha, as Guddu-Bablu's feisty mother, who makes the most of her delicious line: *tumhein pata hai main kiski maa hoon?*

To begin with, it's hard to think of Jitendra Kumar in place of Vikrant Massey,

MIRZAPUR: THE MOVIE

★★★★

DIRECTOR: Gurmmeet Singh

CAST: Pankaj Tripathi, Ali Fazal, Divyendu Sharma, Ravi Kishan, Jitendra Kumar, Rasika Dugal, Sheeba Chaddha, Abhishek Banerjee, Shriya Pilgaonkar, Shweta Tripathi, Harshita Gaur, Sonal Chauhan, Rajesh Tailang, Sushant Singh, Mohit Malik, Kulbhushan Kharbanda

but it's been a while, so we let the former settle into his groove, and hope that *Sachivji*-in-his-new-avatar will get better at hefting a gun. Abhishek Banerjee pops up too, as a Munna Bhaiyya sidekick, but doesn't have much to do. I'm a little conflicted about Ravi Kishan's presence here, who is now so ubiquitous as the self-proclaimed 'national crush', believe it or faint, that he's hard to take in as a wannabe Purvanchali Bahubali. But he's always easy to watch, so that makes up for it. Somewhat.

There's also the thing about toning things down, both as a result of audience fatigue with *gallis* and coarseness, as well as depicting frequent sequences of men and women rutting in dim parlours with their domestics spying on them. This is something only those of us who've seen the show will be able to pin-point: those who've lived under a streaming rock, and come upon the

movie with new eyes, may still have the capacity to be shocked.

But either way, it is the original trifecta which is still the most effective: Pankaj Tripathi as Kaleen Bhaiyya whose *varchasva* is *barkaraar*, Divyendu Sharma as Munna, whose prowess in the sack is more impressive, according to his own self, than in the field, and Ali Fazal, the body-building giant with a soft heart. And, of course, the marvellous Rasika Dugal, as the Tripathi *khandaan-ki-bahu*, who both wins and loses. How about giving her story a stand-alone spin-off?

Net net, I quite enjoyed *Mirzapur: The Movie* because it knows how to stay in its lane, papering over its flabby bits with continual speedy spurts and an intriguing climax. I know how things will pan out, but I'm still in for the ride. Will there be a *Mirzapur The Movie part 2?* Questions, questions.



When Wonder Goes Missing

Shalini Langer

ON PAPER, this should come easy to screenwriter Simon Farnaby, with the Paddington movies and *Wonka* behind him, and Enid Blyton's beloved *The Magic Faraway Tree* book series the source. But magic is hardly as easy as a fruit picked off a tree.

It is either there, or it is not. And the more this film juggles its many British thespians, two known faces in Andrew Garfield and Claire Foy, and a very modern message about a childhood lost to electronic devices, the less and less it seems magical.

Polly (Foy) is a product designer and Tim (Garfield) a house husband raising their three children Fran (Billie Gadsdon), Joe (Phoenix Laroche) and the teenager Beth (Delilah Bennett-Cardy), while nourishing dreams of making a bestseller pasta sauce. To that end, Tim keeps trying out Italian phrases in a habit that is maybe funny at first, but eventually just annoying.

Polly quits her job one day after realising that the company for whom she has designed a talking fridge (in the voice of Judi Dench, no less) actually has a camera installed to spy on its customers. That is as bad as it gets in the un-fairy world, and so Tim decides that now "poor", they should shift to the countryside where he once lived as a child, and loved it.

Polly and Tim have a "dream binder", a folder containing all their dreams and wishes over the years since they were art students. And it is one of the most original ideas in *The Magic Faraway Tree*.

The children are devastated, and you honestly can't blame them as the house Tim moves them into is little more than a barn,

with a broken-down tractor parked inside, cobwebs all over, no electricity and, heavens, no wi-fi. There is a very silly joke about the farmer who has given them the house (Barnaby stepping in himself) confusing wi-fi for something — rather, someone — closer home and more wired in.

But voila, Polly and Tim have nary a fight, and the loving couple set about gamely making a home. Meanwhile, Fran discovers what we are all here for: the enchanted woods, and its magic tree.

A series of known actors stream in after this, playing different characters inhabiting the tree and "lands" beyond — in bursts of incandescent colours. There is a whirlwind of those lands as well — Land of Goodies and Land of Birthdays among them. Even director Ben Gregor loses interest in fleshing them out after the first few.

Billie Gadsdon is underwhelming as Fran, the youngest child with the greatest power of feeling the magic, and Garfield just tries too hard to be a cute hapless man-child. Foy is a joy, especially when she is around the family.

Delilah Bennett-Cardy's Beth is an efficiently catty teenager, and Coughlan (*Bridgerton*) as a fairy gets your defences down.

For a tale invoking fairies and pixies, though, the most winsome are the quintessential bad people — Ferguson as 'Dame Snap' with an impossibly tilted hairdo; and Saunders as Polly's wealthy and snobbish mother.

Saunders's horror at having to utter the word "unemployed" to friends in reference to Polly is enough to shake your belief that there could follow a happy ever after.

Lost in the Dark

Shubhra Gupta

THE MOMENT you see a happy family in a train compartment, with a little girl and her big doll, you know something wicked this way comes.

The girl vanishes, and her increasingly distraught parents, Bani (Taapsee Pannu) and Gokul (Ishwak Singh) find no help from the local police in Joypurra (fictional, of course), somewhere in Bengal.

This is the kind of small town we see in streaming shows, as constructed as their plots, sequence after sequence filled with loud background music trying to stand in for tension because nothing on screen cuts it, either because we've been inundated with similar stuff, or we simply can't buy any of it. Or both.

Taking a pointer or two from an array of series inflated by local myths and colourful processions, *Gandhari* is about a child sex trafficking ring (strike one for unoriginality), run by devilish characters (strike two for ditto), upended by, who else but the ultimate saviour, the mother. No strikes needed here, because mums are the best, right?

Directed by Devashish Makhija whose previous *Cheetpatakadumpa* made solid use of its leads' feminist energy, and written by Kanika Dhillon whose last outing with regular leading lady Taapsee Pannu was the well-done *manohar kahani Phir Aayi Haseen Dil-ruba*, *Gandhari* feels as if it has slipped between the cracks: it is neither impactful nor believable.

The supporting cast — even the husband, played by Ishwak Singh, is clearly only



GANDHARI

★★★★

DIRECTOR: Devashish Makhija

CAST: Taapsee Pannu, Ishwak Singh, Jatin Sarna, Mita Vashisht, Swastika Mukherjee, Chandan Roy, Prashant Narayanan

one amongst the ensemble — is reduced to doing their bit, following Bani's frantic search for her lost daughter, as she becomes a veritable *Gandhari*, suffering from a temporary reduction of vision. 'Maa se bada yodhaa koi na hoye', is the helpful accompanying dialogue. Mita Vashisht (here because she was in the last edition of *Delhi Crime*, also on child trafficking?) shows our intrepid Bani the way, which is blocked by a bunch of people, each of whom are made to do eye-roll things: a social worker-type (Chhaya Kadam) is too helpful, a dank-looking orphanage head (Swastika Mukherjee) skulks about, as does a van driver (Chandan Roy) lugging suspicious sacks.

Wait, there's more. Jatin Sarna is a cop cracking orders. Prashant Narayanan shows up to up the menace quotient. A devil named Chaumukhi, and a demon named Magrasur join the party; and just to make everything deeply metaphorical, a group of behrupiyas, faces masked and painted, swarm everywhere, but like everything else, leave little impact.

All Guns, No Glory

Shalini Langer

CELESTE (ADRIA Arjona) is a troubled ex-Marine roughing it out in a trailer park in the middle of nowhere, surrounded by similar misfits and discontents, and guns, loads and loads of them. When others shoot the breeze, she literally takes her guns out and does target practice, on carved Halloween pumpkins.

Having her ex drop their young daughter (Blake Kennedy) for the weekend to this trailer park is a dangerous enough proposition.

But, that's not the half of it. It is only one of the many misconstrued pieces of the puzzle that is *Onslaught* — seemingly talking a lot, but actually not saying anything.

The opening credits roll out against a montage that goes backwards from Barack Obama and Afghanistan to Woodrow Wil-

son and World War I, a snapshot of all of the misadventures by America towards being 'the land of the free and home of the brave'. That includes all those top-secret experiments in off-record black sites.

One such experiment is happening in Celeste's backyard. Having noticed two Black Hawks flying overhead in close succession (the film itself covers a 24-hour timeframe), she suspects something is afoot. She shares that suspicion with a fellow veteran soldier and trailer neighbour, Josiah (Reginald VelJohnson).

At the other end of the suspicion lie a German couple, played by Dan Stevens and a criminally underused Rebecca Hall. When he is not crawling on all fours to lick her shoes, in presumably a sexual fetish (the vague Nazi comparison is meant to be all-explaining), he is flying out to the facility near Celeste's to fashion



"super soldiers".

As Hall explains later, much later, they are US soldiers who once had a bloody, traumatic experience in combat, and whose brains have now been tinkered with to leave them without a conscience, so that they would have no compunction when used against their own people by governments.

Really, governments are struggling with

•STREAMING WATCHLIST



Star Wars: The Mandalorian and Grogu

JIOHOTSTAR

AMERICAN SCIENCE-fiction *Star Wars: The Mandalorian and Grogu* is a 2026 film directed by Jon Favreau. The film, a

continuation of the series *The Mandalorian*, is set after the fall of the Galactic Empire, as Imperial warlords continue to threaten the galaxy. Pedro Pascal reprises his role as Din Djarin, the Mandalorian, alongside Grogu. The cast also includes Jeremy Allen White, Jonny Coyne, Sigourney Weaver, and Martin Scorsese.



The Gentlemen S2

NETFLIX

IN SEASON 2 of Guy Ritchie's *The Gentlemen*, now streaming on Netflix, a year has passed since Eddie Horniman (Theo James) reluctantly inherited his aristocratic family's sprawling estate. Having joined forces with Susie Glass (Kaya Scodelario) and her lavishly imprisoned father, Bobby (Ray Winstone), Eddie is beginning to realise that life as a powerful player in the criminal underworld suits him surprisingly well.



Ananthan Kaadu

LIONSGATE PLAY

SET AGAINST the turbulent political climate of late '80s and early '90s Thiruvananthapuram, *Ananthan Kaadu*

follows Vetrivel Kumaran, a man caught in a world shaped by power, violence and survival. As political unrest disrupts ordinary lives, Vetrivel is drawn into a dangerous chain of events that sets him on a path of vengeance and reckoning with the past. Directed by Jiyen Krishnakumar, the film stars Arya, Nikhila Vimal, Regina Cassandra and Vijayaraghavan.



Jagamae Sangeetham

PRIME VIDEO

THE SERIES blends the rich traditions of Carnatic music with contemporary musical sensibilities as the eight-part Telugu

series brings to life a moving tale of family, tradition, and self-discovery. The timeless beauty of Carnatic music forms the emotional core of the story. It features a stellar ensemble cast led by Prakash Raj. Directed by Palnati Surya Pratap, its music is composed by Vishal Chandrasekhar.

Love Story

JIOHOTSTAR

THIS AMERICAN biographical romantic-drama anthology chronicles the whirlwind courtship and marriage of John F Kennedy Jr and Carolyn Bes-sette-Kennedy. The series stars Sarah Pidgeon as Carolyn, a publicist at Calvin Klein and Paul Anthony Kelly as John F Kennedy Jr. Grace Gummer is Caroline Kennedy, John Jr's sister, while Naomi Watts plays Jacqueline Kennedy Onassis, the former first lady of the United States.

ALAKA SAHANI



this particular problem?

Anyway, in *Onslaught*, this is a taking-off point for the three untested soldiers to, of course, break free and unleash havoc — eventually making their way to Celeste's trailer park, where her Marine will stop at nothing to play mom.

Adam Wingard (*The Guest*, *Godzilla vs Kong*) returns, somewhat to his indie horror roots with this slasher thriller film, with A24's backing. But there is not enough slash for a slasher, if that is your thing; and there is not enough surprise for it to be a thriller. Worst of all, there is too much turning up the nose at the government when you are not looking to actually raise a stink.

Arjona again demonstrates an ability to hold your attention, but Wingard keeps turning around to the three super soldiers silhouetted against the night sky, their eyes glinting (they can see in the dark, you see), standing between the trailers and holding not just guns but also chain saws, cleavers etc etc.

In the words of Stevens's mad scientist Hans Kemmler, the three are "human equivalents of a heat-seeking missile". If that's your thing...



‘Netflix is both classy and massy’



Ted Sarandos, co-CEO, Netflix (right), with Anant Goenka, Executive Director, *The Indian Express*. RENUKA PURI

Ten years ago, globally Netflix had \$6.3 billion in revenue, \$120 million in profit and a \$50 billion valuation. Today, it's \$45 billion in revenue, \$1 billion in profit and a \$400 billion valuation. It has been a tremendous decade. The fact that this happened in entertainment is special. You never had a right to win. You started with DVDs, had no production, no distribution. Amazon and Apple had distribution. Disney had production. But Reed Hastings had a conviction and got you to buy into it.

When I met Reed in 1999, he said all entertainment was going to come into the home on the internet at a time when the internet was too slow, too expensive. We were talking about downloading movies because streaming didn't even exist. But it was clear that's where this was going. Mailing DVDs and managing people's queues was all about customer relationships, credit cards and taste preferences, so that you could use the power of the internet to help people find things in a world of almost infinite choices.

The problem we were solving was marketing, not distribution or production. How do you get something right in front of the right person, so you don't have to advertise to the entire country for a relatively small niche film to find the handful of people who are going to love it.

So you thought your differentiation was marketing?

Yeah. In the days of big theatrical distribution, the cost of moving prints around was low. The cost of production was high, but that was true for everybody. The cost of marketing, if you could make that system more efficient, could change the P&L (profit and loss) of a studio.

When you started, you had to say provocative things like the theatre business wasn't going to work. Every time a film does well in the theatre, do you get a target on your back?

We're not in the theatrical movie business. Whenever I've had anything to say about the theatrical movie business, it's mostly an observation of stats and behaviour. What has been great is that people on Netflix love movies. They love to go to the movies or watch them at home. Our average member watches seven movies a month on Netflix globally, and sees one or two every year in the theatre. I'm not saying one is better than the other. It's a rich ecosystem. I want our members, when they want to go out at night, to go to a movie because it strengthens their relationship with movies.

Do you not see them as competition?

Not at all. We compete for time. When you sit down, pick up the remote and push a button, we want it to be Netflix. We make sure every time you do that, you watch something you love. We want to become the first place you check for something to watch and the last thing you'd ever cancel.

When you say you compete for screen time, are you competing with YouTube, Instagram and anything that you're looking at on a screen?

We don't necessarily compete with YouTube on phones because what people are watching on phones tends to be much shorter, vertical and free. When you get

Ted Sarandos, Netflix co-CEO, on a decade of the streaming platform in India, why the big screen is not a competition and the role of data in viewership. He was in conversation with Anant Goenka

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SCAN THE QR CODE TO WATCH THE ADDA

IF ANYBODY MADE BIG CREATIVE DECISIONS BASED ONLY ON DATA, THAT WOULD BE A FOOL'S ERRAND

...

I DON'T THINK CONSUMERS LOVE THEIR MASSY CHOICE ANY LESS THAN THEY LOVE THEIR CLASSY CHOICE

quarter. With a population this size and an enormous appetite for entertainment, it's dramatically underscreened. There are fewer movie theatre screens per person than in almost any country in the world. But we can solve that problem with all kinds of screens that can tell those stories.

We brought India its first Academy Award for *The Elephant Whisperers*, and also won the International Emmy, had nominations for Vir Das and *Delhi Crime*, and won Best Hindi Film at the National Awards. Why many American companies have failed in India is because they think they understand India after making one movie that worked. But there are multiple Indias. Even to be successful locally, you have to travel across the country. We don't do that from California. We do that from Mumbai. It's an intense desire to be ingrained in the entertainment community, ecosystem and economy of India, but most importantly, with Indian fans. Our people here love Indian movies and television more than anyone in the world.

How much of it is algorithm, and how much is the instinct of the local team?

I always refer to it as very informed intuition. There's no data in the world that could tell you to make this and don't make that. You'll be wrong all the time. Data only tells you what worked before, and audiences are always looking for something they haven't seen.

Is the audience always looking for something it has never seen before?

They're always looking to be surprised. There are things where you can spend some time because it's comfortable. But what really moves the needle for a fan is, 'I've never felt this way before.' Those things don't come in some rhythm or formula. You can't reverse-engineer them. They come from a great idea, a visionary storyteller, the resources to bring that story to the screen, and a little bit of kismet. At the end of the day, it's all in execution. You can get false security by looking at the data. Where we always win is when we have creative executives with such keen instincts and courage that they say, 'I know what the data says. I'm telling you that's wrong. This is going to work.' Look at *Squid Game*. No data would have said to make it, certainly not for a global audience. In hindsight, everyone says, "Of course it was amazing." But it was twice as expensive as any hour of Korean television ever produced. So yes, we have data, but if anybody made big creative decisions based only on data, that would be a fool's errand.

What about the role of the star? In India, I assume it's important.

Absolutely. The star is important, more than in other markets. But it's the star and the vehicle. You can't just put the star into a role people don't necessarily want to see them in. Then, you're starting from scratch.

You had an offsite in India where you and Reed got on the Palace on Wheels and spent days discussing your India strategy. What came out of that?

What I loved about that trip was how quickly it taught us there's not one India. You go to sleep in one part of India and wake up in another. It's like you've landed on another planet. It reinforced the importance of having a great local presence when making creative decisions for a market.

One uniquely Indian way of classifying content is as 'massy' and 'classy'. Do you think of the spectrum that way?

I love that phrase. I had never thought of it that way. When we had the DVD business, we had more than 100,000 titles. What we learned was that people's tastes are remarkably diverse. Every year, when you ran the reports, almost every one of those titles had been rented. That taught us that if you want to serve the world, you need something for everybody. I don't think consumers love their massy choice any less than they love their classy choice. In India, you've got people who really love *Lock Upp*. And then you've got something like *Musafir Cafe*, a deliberate love story with beautifully shot landscapes. They sit right next to each other, serving gigantic audiences.

Four big broadcasters in India could differentiate themselves purely through content. You could if a show was on Zee, Star, Sony or Colors without seeing the logo. Is that something what you want to do?

No. Our real differentiator is no different today than it was 25 years ago, when we mailed discs: personalisation. To do that, you can't be narrow. Compared with many brands you mentioned, Netflix was always a general entertainment brand because we carried 100,000 titles. That made it much easier when we moved into streaming.

You have said that you're not going to get into sports in India.

I said we have a global live strategy that includes sports. It doesn't include league sports like the whole season of anything. We've been fortunate enough to build a large business without a loss leader. For most television seasons of sports, that's what they are. They bring an audience that you can pivot into something else. But it's very difficult to make money on league sports because they're expensive.

In India, you're not the largest, by subscriber base. With IPL, you'd get top of the funnel. Was there no temptation to do that?

We were able to build this without it. A lot of great companies were born on those kinds of investments and eventually got squeezed out. We didn't want dependence on any one thing.

What's next for Netflix?

There's so much headroom in what we currently do. You could have asked me this question a year or two ago and we would have been completely wrong about some of the things that happened. We're in a constant drive to entertain the world. That means adding new content and new types of content, and upping the game for an

THE AUDIENCE IS ALWAYS LOOKING TO BE SURPRISED. THAT DOESN'T COME IN SOME FORMULA. YOU CAN'T REVERSE-ENGINEER IT

...

DECISIONS ABOUT WHAT STORIES YOU CAN AND CAN'T TELL ARE OFTEN ABOUT NOT ENOUGH PEOPLE WATCHING IT FOR WHAT IT COSTS TO MAKE

...

INDIA HAS LESS THEATRE SCREENS PER PERSON BUT WE CAN SOLVE THAT WITH MULTIPLE SCREENS

audience that expects it.

You've put India's *Got Latent* on Netflix, the same content that is also on YouTube.

YouTube is sometimes a place where you discover things; no different from a film festival, film school or open casting call. In this case, the team was excited about the show. It came with a built-in audience and a popular host. It had all the elements people wanted, and we were able to bring it to Netflix.

You tried to buy Warner Bros Discovery. Is Netflix going to keep looking for vertical integration?

Our growth model has been and continues to be organic growth. We look at all opportunities when they come across. You would be crazy not to look and kick the tires. We don't have 100 years of IP like a major studio. But that is a blessing because it has forced us to make some of the most original creative stories on the planet. We looked at the Warner Bros deal because it would have accelerated our business model a bit. But when it was no longer the right price, we were fine to walk away.

So in build versus buy, you're on the build side?

We have always been builders.

AI is a controversial topic now. How should the media ecosystem think about it?

The embrace of AI from Indian creators has been much more aggressive than anywhere in the world. I think it's because we believe AI is a creator tool. Indian storytellers get excited about the opportunity to bring ambitious projects to the screen when the resources aren't always there.

We've had about 300 productions use AI tools. We use them for pre-visualisation, giving directors the opportunity to design complicated shots so they can film faster and safer. It's been a game changer. But it has to make the story better, even better if it's faster and cheaper. At the end of the day, if it's not better, those things don't matter.

So you're not considering AI a cost-saving tool yet?

I anticipate there'll be some cost savings, but they'll get reinvested into what's on screen. For instance, there are AI tools that can enable a filmmaker, using the data of the film they've already made, to do a quick pickup shot almost like a visual effect.

Are there markets where you can't tell the stories that should be told?

Most decisions about what stories you can and can't tell aren't necessarily about whether you're allowed to tell them. It may not be economically feasible. The story may make you angry. But ultimately, if not enough people watch it for what it costs to make, you often can't make it.

But the idea of making power centres uncomfortable through documentaries. Do you feel you need to push that more?

I don't think our role or motto is anything other than entertaining. If that serves our ability to entertain the world, that's great. If it interferes, we should avoid that.



(From left) Anant Goenka, Ted Sarandos and Usha Kakade, founder and producer, Usha Kakade Productions



Avinash Pandey, CEO and Secretary General, Indian Broadcasting and Digital Foundation



Rattan Keswani, author and consultant



(From left) Sandip Somany, Chairman & MD, Somany Impresa Group; Mahima Kaul, Director of Public Policy, Netflix, and Monika Shergill, VP Content, Netflix



(From left) Usha Kakade, Producer, Usha Kakade Productions, Dilip Chenoy, former Secy General, FICCI, and Sonali Dahiya, Head, Burgundy Private, Private Banking by Axis Bank



(Left) Ankur Verma, co-founder and CTO, BizLoc8, with Amit Kaushik, co-founder and CEO, Phoenix Tech Consulting



Kishore Singh, art curator, with Shwetasree Majumder, founder and Managing Partner, Fidus Law Chambers



(Left) Andrew Ure, VP, Netflix, with Cleto Williams, Chief Global Affairs Officer, Netflix



Parth Govil, Senior VP and Head, Burgundy Private, Axis Bank



Jaya Jaitly, former president of the Samata Party



DEBASHISH BHATTACHARYA
ADDITIONAL DIRECTOR-GENERAL,
THE BROADBAND INDIA FORUM

SANDIP SOMANY
CHAIRMAN & MD,
SOMANY IMPRESA GROUP

Regulation or creativity or innovation. Which do you choose? Censorship or self-regulation, what do you prefer?

India is a beautiful working model for self-regulation and self-censorship and we work closely with the government to make sure we are following everything we need to follow without having an onerous regulatory model. It's important because you don't want to interfere with creativity and you also need to be a responsible player. Our relationship with the government allows us to do that. India has always been a phenomenal free speech culture, so in the spirit of that, it has not been that tough.

What would you need to change in your secret sauce to be equally, if not more, successful 10 years from today?

A lot of companies have a motto that they put on a plaque and never look at again. We actually run the business by that culture memo. Over the years it went from being a 170-page PowerPoint document to a couple of pages of memo. But at the core the values are intact. And you have to have great people to do this. You have to give them all the resources to do the best work of their life and get out of the way. It's the last part that people trip up on a lot. That's going to shepherd us into the next 10 years, which will look a lot like the last 10, but better and faster.



ROBIN ROY
DOCUMENTARY AND
WILDLIFE FILMMAKER



SHWETASREE MAJUMDER
MANAGING PARTNER,
FIDUS LAW CHAMBERS

Non-fiction filmmakers sometimes feel like stepchildren in the film world. Are we going to see a lot more stuff on Netflix which will be non-fiction? Is there a place for it and is it growing?

Absolutely. I hope you're seeing a lot of it on Netflix today. That Academy Award that we were able to bring home to India was for a documentary short. It has always been core to the business. I was a kid in Phoenix who had to travel for an hour and a half to the theatre to see a documentary on the Holocaust. What got me excited was this opportunity that no matter where you are in the world, you'd have access to a documentary which you mostly don't. So there's always going to be a place for that at Netflix.

With IP lawsuits rising, do you see AI platforms like Midjourney and MiniMax challenging your studio-quality short-form content by replicating protected IP from Squid Games and Stranger Things?

We always have to be aware of what the audience is gravitating towards and how we serve that need. I have not fact checked it, but I heard that the big micro drama company in China switched to doing all AI-generated micro dramas and that the engagement in those dropped by 70 per cent. But as it is right now, audiences are looking to either escape or connect when they engage in content in programming. And there's something about the lack of humanity there that people are rejecting right now.



TAVLEEN SINGH
JOURNALIST, AUTHOR AND
POLITICAL COLUMNIST



SONALI DAHIYA
HEAD, BURGUNDY PRIVATE,
PRIVATE BANKING BY AXIS BANK

When you started out, did you think that you would be this successful at becoming the entertainer of the world? And which country has been particularly difficult to work in?

When I met Reed in '99, he was clear we were going to be exactly what we are now. I was more skeptical whether it would get that big and certainly not that fast. Every country has its own nuances. People have individual tastes. The hardest thing to do is to be able to operate in those very bespoke environments. Sometimes it can be navigating regulatory environments and sometimes it is about understanding the local taste and sensibility. That can be difficult.

You spoke about using AI in an industry where personalisation is key. What would you advise the CEOs reimagining businesses in the world of AI, and what would be the one thing you would tell them not to do?

You have to figure out what is the use case for AI that advances your business initiative and don't get caught up in this idea that you just have to be an AI because that is where all the investment is going. There are things that AI will completely transform and if we are mostly just running head first, it is important that people have a strategy of what they are going to use this tool for and how it will improve the business and on what dimensions are they investing versus being AI at any cost.



Ted Sarandos with the audience at Express Adda in Delhi

RAPID FIRE

● **One lesson that Bollywood has taught you about storytelling.**
The best storytelling is timeless.

● **What about Operation Safe Sagar got you most excited?**

The negative thing about my role is I get to see the cuts early. I watched the first couple of episodes without the VFX and the story itself was so engrossing that I was not distracted by the lack of the VFX.

● **If, for whatever reason, Netflix no longer works out for you and you have the ability to choose to be the editor of any news organisation in the world, which one would it be?**

I look back now, and today I would be such a lousy news editor. I don't think I would pick any of them. I would be a professional consumer.

● **If you were forced to run Netflix looking at only one metric every day, what would that be?**

It's an internal wonky word... love score. We have this ability to measure how much people really are loving what they are watching. I can't tell you how we do that, but it's part of the secret sauce.

● **The last time you and Reed Hastings disagreed?**

Reed moved on from Netflix a while ago. So now I am the co-CEO with Greg (Peters). And we decided early on, that we would disagree violently with each other on things we really care about. And we would make sure that we didn't pull punches with each other ever. Because the one thing we both care deeply about is the success of the business and we have complementary skill sets. That said, we agree about 95 per cent of the time and if we don't, we duke it out.

● **The last time you and Monika Shergill disagreed.**

Very rarely because Monica knows so much more about this market than I do. Why would I possibly disagree with her?

● **The one series that is on another platform you wish was on yours.**

The Studio because I was in it. And now if I tell people to watch my episode, I have to tell them to watch Apple TV.

● **If you have the opportunity to buy any of the following IPs from Warner Brothers Discovery for a price you like, which one would it be: Batman, The Big Bang Theory, Friends, Harry Potter, the entire CNN or TNT Sports.**

Harry Potter. If you think back to a franchise that has really stood the test of time, you probably have 20 that are legitimate and Harry Potter is certainly one of them.

● **Sanjay Leela Bhansali or Martin Scorsese? Who went over budget?**

No comment.

● **The best sequel that never got made?**

I wish we would have got to Mind-hunter Part 3. We always anticipated

there would be a third season but David Fincher got very busy making a film. And he is an unbelievably meticulous creator so he couldn't just do two things at a time and he certainly didn't want to short change either one.

● **The one earnings call question that kept you up at night.**

None. That's an honest answer.

● **The most expensive production Netflix has ever done.**

Probably Rebel Moon. We made two very big budget movies back to back and released them back to back.

● **The one marketing campaign that you loved that wasn't done by Netflix.**

FX did a really amazing job of making The Bear feel like it was a much bigger show than it was. It was really because the marketing was so strong.

● **One misconception about Netflix in India that you would like to change?**

Probably the classy massy one, which is understanding that we're doing both.

● **In the benefit of hindsight, do you think Sacred Games was not the right way to start?**

No. I wish we had done something like Lock Upp at the same time that we did Sacred Games. And knew that we eventually were going to do both.

● **When you meet a first-time filmmaker, is there one tell that convinces you that they are talented?**

A rich understanding of the context of the story of film and storytelling. David Fincher and I had one of our first dinners together where we talked all night about just great movies and what made a movie better than all the others. And that was his observation on every great movie ever made or every career-defining performance, which is something I had not thought about until he articulated it that way.

● **One piece of advice to a director who is preparing a pitch for Netflix.**

It's a very bad idea to pitch me no matter where I am. That happens all the time and it's not very productive for the idea. I would also say that film schools should have an entire course on just pitching.

● **What is the most awkward place a story has been pitched to you?**

The one not so crazy location is that I will be out to dinner with my wife and another couple and someone will come to the table and pitch relentlessly.



(Right) Paroma Roy Chowdhury, Senior Advisor, APCO, with Suvmoy Roy Choudhury, Chief Human Resources Officer, Vodafone Idea



Vijay Joshi, CEO and editor-in-chief, Press Trust of India



Bharat Joshi, CEO, J-Curve Ventures



Dilip Cherian, PR consultant, with Neelima Dalmia Adhar, author

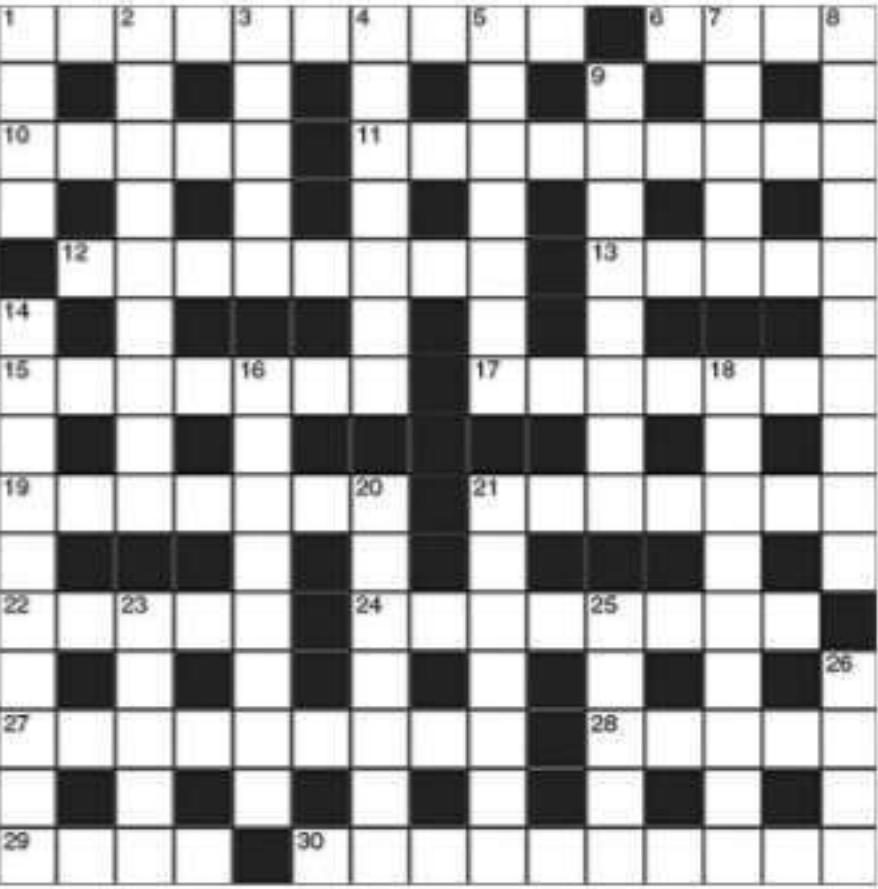


Vikram Sakhuja, Partner and Director, Madison World, with Anant Goenka



Siddharth Banerjee, board member, Eikam Resonance

CROSSWORD



- ACROSS
- 1 It is beyond the directors to be honest (5,5)
6 Far Eastern food (4)
10 Delay and yield to another's wishes (5)
11 Decade with restrictions for every weekday (9)
12 Back number (8)
13 He will shortly get a ring, so he says (5)
15 Conditions that might affect mail etc (7)
17 Voyage to the East on board shipping lines (7)
19 A capital lager is brewed here (7)
21 Wrong name for an individual flower (7)
22 Rough copy for doctor at the back (5)
24 An old 20-franc piece lost at Waterloo (8)
27 Always be brave and don't worry (5,4)
28 A maxim Tom turns to (5)
29 Shakespeare shows determination (4)
30 Point to one duke or another (10)
- DOWN
- 1 He goes after Norm in northern France (4)
2 Away jump the children (9)
3 Hesitantly stated a colour and was wrong (5)
4 Comply with notice (7)
5 Rebels about some measures of power (7)
7 Character in The Tempest or one in Lear maybe (5)
8 Seat of Zeus is re-established in the orient (4,2,4)
9 Having responsibility in attack (2,6)
14 Conditions produced by ocean winds oddly enough (3,3,4)
16 Opening for a photographer (8)
18 Not an original pot shot at reforms (9)
20 It's true I will appear in the screen version (7)
21 Clothes appear wrong when put on a number (7)
23 Forger's block (5)
25 It gets squeezed into an inadequate vehicle (5)
26 Turn on a fool (4)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6085 ACROSS: 1 Beat off, 5 Amass, 8 Whodunits, 9 Sum, 10 Rows, 12 Falsetto, 14 Pliant, 15 Beware, 17 Altering, 18 Asia, 21 Inn, 22 Plastered, 24 Tepid, 25 Evident DOWN: 1 Bower, 2 Ago, 3 Onus, 4 Friday, 5 Assessed, 6 Alsations, 7 Someone, 11 Written up, 13 Intrepid, 14 Pianist, 16 Enlace, 19 Audit, 20 Etui, 23 Rye

JUMBLLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given clue.

Choose the life that is most ____, and habit will make it the most _____. - Sir Francis Bacon (6,...,9)

EERVE

ERWAA

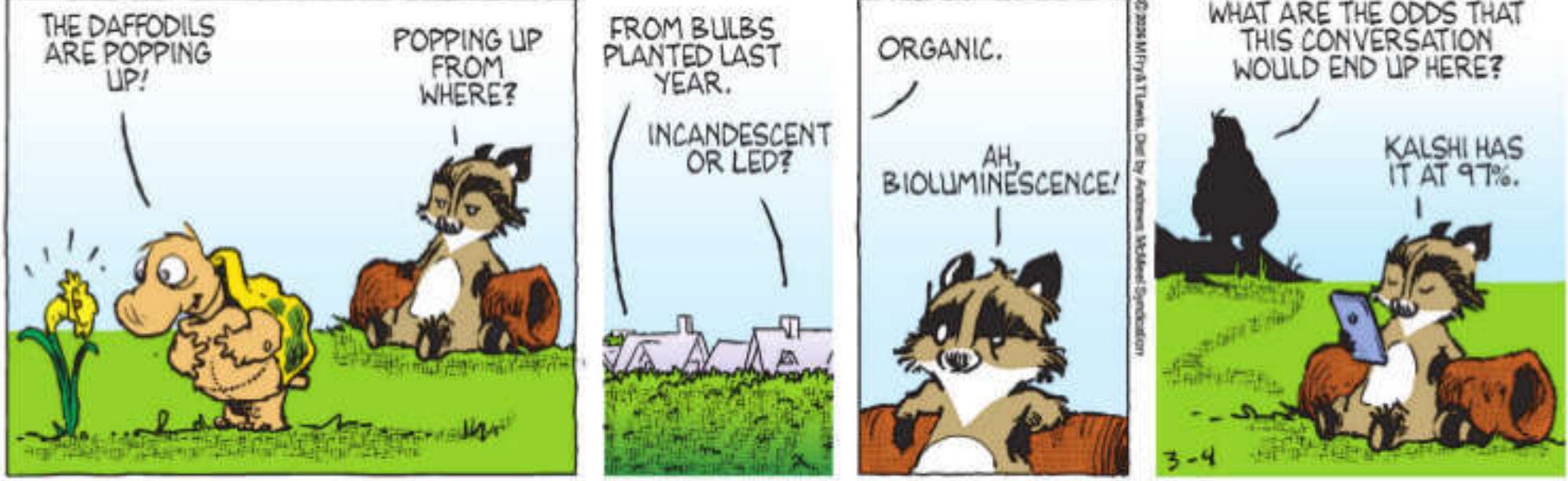
LLSIVU

FGUALB

agreeable

ANSWER: Choose the life that is most useful, and habit will make it the most agreeable. - Sir Francis Bacon

OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL 5s

INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL

1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SUDOKU 6431

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6430

7 2

5

9

3 4

6

7 2

1

7

7

9

8

2

6 4

8

3 2 9

5

1

6 3

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused Namely: Vinod Kumar, S/o. Motilal, R/o. Jhuggi No.125, Tanki Wali Jhuggi, Vishnu Garden, Raghuveer Nagar, Vikas Puri, West Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in a case vide FIR No.179/2021 U/S 420/34 IPC registered at P.S. I.P. Estate, Central District, Delhi and it has been returned on a warrant of arrest there upon issued stating that the said accused Vinod Kumar could not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that accused Vinod Kumar is absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said Vinod Kumar, accused of FIR No. 179/2021 U/S 420/34 IPC, P.S. I.P. Estate, Central District, Delhi is required to appear before the court to answer the said complaint on or before 06.10.2026

By Order, Ms. Preeti,
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03,
Central District, Room No.150,
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/12441/CD/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPC

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Rohit S/o Sh. Sarwan R/o House No. 19, Gali No.16, New Mahavir Nagar, Tilak Nagar, New Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide FIR No. 836/2020 U/S 33/88 Delhi Excise Act, PS Tilak Nagar, New Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest their upon issued that the said accused Rohit can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said Rohit has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused Rohit of FIR No. 836/2020 U/S 33/88 Delhi Excise Act, PS Tilak Nagar, New Delhi is required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the day of 14.10.2026

By Order, Sh. Vikas Madaan
Judicial Magistrate First Class-07 (West)
Room No. 289, Second Floor
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/12511/WD/2026(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

(See Section 82 Cr PC/84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person namely Param Lal S/o Gaya Parshad R/o Flat No.A-75, Pocket-5, Lal Flat Sec-3, DSIIDC Bawana, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 150/2018 U/s 288/338 IPC at PS: Bawana, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Param Lal can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Param Lal has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused Param Lal of FIR No. 150/2018 U/s 288/338 IPC of PS: Bawana, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 05.10.2026.

By order
Bharti Beniwal
Judicial Magistrate First Class-05
North, Room No.114, First Floor,
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/12584/ON/2026

Office of Superintending Engineer, Rampur Circle, P.W.D. Rampur

E-Procurement Tender Notice

No.: 4890/E-Nivida-R.Circle/26-27 Dated:-27.08.2026

1. On behalf of the Governor of UP, tenders for following work on Percentage rates are invited by the Superintending Engineer, Rampur Circle, PWD Rampur online on website <http://tender.up.nic.in> from contractors registered in civil road category from date 18.09.2026 at 10.00 am to 25.09.2026 at 12.00 noon. Technical bid/Prequalification of tenders shall be opened on 25.09.2026 at 12.30 pm in office of undersigned by tender committee in presence of authorised representatives/bidders who wish to be present. Financial bid of the tenders' who qualify in technical bid shall be opened on date and time as specified by a notice in the office of undersigned. In case of Government holiday the required process shall be carried out on next working day.

2. Details of the works are following:

Sl. No	District	Name of Work	Estimated cost (Rs.in Lakh) GST Ex.	Bid Security (Rs.in Lakh) (As per T-2)	Time of completion of the work (Including rainy season)	Cost of tender documents including GST (RS.)	Category of road contractor eligible	Address of Executive Engineer executing the work	Address of Superintending Engineer	Address of Chief Engineer
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11
New Construction Under Rajya Sadak Nidhi Scheme:-										
1	Rampur	New Construction of Shamshahat in Village Shahpura, District Rampur, in the year 2026-27	68.00	5.40	06 Months (Including Rainy season)	2354.00 (Security will be accepted only through net banking)	A,B,C Road Category	Provincial Division PWD Rampur	Rampur Circle, PWD Rampur	Moradabad Zone, PWD Moradabad
2	Rampur	New Construction of Village Samodiy RSB Road to the Khadiya Pulia	72.00	5.60	06 Months (Including Rainy season)	2354.00 (Security will be accepted only through net banking)	A,B, C Road Category	Provincial Division PWD Rampur	Rampur Circle, PWD Rampur	Moradabad Zone, PWD Moradabad
3	Rampur	New Construction of Village Ladpur, via the Shamshahat, to the Mansoorpur road.	104.00	7.20	12 Months (Including Rainy season)	2354.00 (Security will be accepted only through net banking)	A,B, Road Category	Provincial Division PWD Rampur	Rampur Circle, PWD Rampur	Moradabad Zone, PWD Moradabad
4	Rampur	New Construction of Anwariyi Farm Teen Pani Road to the Shamshahad road.	112.00	7.60	12 Months (Including Rainy season)	2354.00 (Security will be accepted only through net banking)	A,B, Road Category	Provincial Division PWD Rampur	Rampur Circle, PWD Rampur	Moradabad Zone, PWD Moradabad
5	Rampur	New Construction of Swar-Bilaspur-Milak Khanan road, via Milak Dandi, to the Bhopgar road.	112.00	7.60	12 Months (Including Rainy season)	2354.00 (Security will be accepted only through net banking)	A,B, Road Category	Provincial Division PWD Rampur	Rampur Circle, PWD Rampur	Moradabad Zone, PWD Moradabad
6	Rampur	New Construction of NH-87 Naveen Mandi Kunkhacheda to the Bhopgar road.	120.00	8.00	12 Months (Including Rainy season)	2354.00 (Security will be accepted only through net banking)	A,B, Road Category	Provincial Division PWD Rampur	Rampur Circle, PWD Rampur	Moradabad Zone, PWD Moradabad
7	Rampur	New Construction of Noorpur, via Aasul-Parsal to Sewa Singh house.	132.00	8.60	12 Months (Including Rainy season)	2354.00 (Security will be accepted only through net banking)	A,B, Road Category	Provincial Division PWD Rampur	Rampur Circle, PWD Rampur	Moradabad Zone, PWD Moradabad
8	Rampur	New Construction of Bilaspur to the Lohari road, via the Kartarpur-Suangala	135.00	8.75	12 Months (Including Rainy season)	2354.00 (Security will be accepted only through net banking)	A,B, Road Category	Provincial Division PWD Rampur	Rampur Circle, PWD Rampur	Moradabad Zone, PWD Moradabad
9	Rampur	New Construction of Kunwarpur to Majra Bevakta.	205.00	12.25	12 Months (Including Rainy season)	2354.00 (Security will be accepted only through net banking)	A, Road Category	Provincial Division PWD Rampur	Rampur Circle, PWD Rampur	Moradabad Zone, PWD Moradabad

➤ Upon completion, all the above works shall remain under a 05 year maintenance period.

➤ The Rates adopted in the BOQ are including all other taxes but excluding GST.

➤ The Bid Security and tender cost should be deposited online through Net Banking as per Column 5 & 7 in the table.

➤ All terms & conditions can be seen on website <http://tender.up.nic.in>. Additional Security will be payable as per rule at the time of Agreement and according to G.O. No.86/2026/649/2026/23-7099/106/2025 लेख निर्माण अनुमति-7 दिनांक 23.05.2026. The bidder have to login on Prahari URL <http://wms.upwd.gov.in>/Prahari to upload required documents as per Government order 879 (1) दिनांक-7/2020-176 (राज्य)06 लेख निर्माण अनुमति-7 दिनांक - 25.08.2020 & E.N.C.H.O.D.'s upword letter No. 417/13 दिनांक 86/2026 दिनांक- 28.08.2020

(Er. Krishan Vir)

Executive Engineer P.D, PWD, Rampur
Ph. 01342-262776
Email -pdrampur@gmail.com

UPID-255471 Dt. 03/09/2026
www.upidadv.gov.in

(Er. Sanjay Jayant)

Superintending Engineer Rampur Circle, PWD, Rampur
Ph. 0595-2351163
Email -pwdrampur@gmail.com

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Rajeev Lochan Shukla S/o Om Prakash Shukla R/o 2/57, Pkt. 62, Shiv Shakti Apartment, Sector-34, Rohini, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 43/2021 u/s 435 IPC at P.S. Shahbad Dairy, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the above said Rajeev Lochan Shukla cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the above said Rajeev Lochan Shukla has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proceeding Section 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita has been initiated in the case. Proclamation is hereby made that the said Rajeev Lochan Shukla accused of FIR No. 43/2021 u/s 435 IPC at P.S. Shahbad Dairy, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 06.10.2026.

By Order: Ms. Bharti Beniwal,
Judicial Magistrate, First Class-05 (North),
Court No. 114, First Floor,
Rohini Courts, Delhi.

DP/12466/ON/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Pankaj @ Vishal, S/o: Hari Chand, R/o: C-435, Raghubir Nagar, Hari Nagar, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 96/2024, U/s 25/54/59 IPC, P.S.: Hari Nagar, New Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Pankaj @ Vishal cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Pankaj @ Vishal has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said Pankaj @ Vishal accused of case FIR No. 96/2024, U/s 25/54/59 IPC, P.S.: Hari Nagar, New Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 06.10.2026.

By Order
Ms. Moksha Bains
Judicial Magistrate First Class-II (West)
Court No. 31, Tis Hazari Court, New Delhi

DP/12519/WD/2026
(Court Matter)

ROYAL STARS

♈

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): Today you're more sensitive about home and family, and might feel hurt if someone makes a disparaging remark. Conversations might be confusing. Someone might make an assumption. Don't agree to anything important today. Tonight: Relax at home.

♉

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): Your imagination is activated today, which is great for those involved with artistic projects. Many of you might spend time daydreaming today or being lost in a fantasy world. In the real world, make an effort to clarify communications.Tonight: A conversation.

♊

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): Conversations with friends as well as groups might be a tad confusing today. You might be dealing with someone's idealism. Or perhaps you are the idealist. Tonight: Check your money.

♋

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Today the Moon is in your sign at odds with fuzzy Neptune, which can induce a dreamy state of mind. It can also lend to bad decisions that require clear thinking. Tonight: You win.

♌

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): Although your primary focus is on money, cash flow and your assets right now, today you might be caught up in mystical ideas or spiritual pursuits. If so, be aware that you're in a suggestible frame of mind. Things might not be as they appear. Tonight: Enjoy privacy.

♍

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): You are basically strong and grounded today because both the Sun and your ruler Mercury are in your sign. Nevertheless, the placement of the Moon might create confusion in your discussions. You might assume something or you might be misunderstood. Double-check your communications. Tonight: Be friendly.

♎

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): There is a curious astrological combo taking place today. In one way, you want to hide and be low-key. This is because of the placement of the Sun. But in another way, you are noticed, whether you like it or not. This is because of the placement of the Moon. Tonight: You're admired.

♏

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): This is a feel-good day for you. If you can travel that would be perfect because you want some adventure, something different. Go someplace you've never been before. Tonight: Explore and learn.

♐

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): This is a poor day to make important financial decisions. Confusion, assumptions, misinterpretations and even deceit are possible. Tonight: Check your finances.

♑

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): Tread carefully today, because the Moon is opposite your sign, which is a bit challenging. Generally speaking, it means you have to go more than halfway when you're dealing with others. You have to be accommodating. Tonight: Listen and cooperate.

♒

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): You'll be smart to double-check your work in your job today, because confusion and misunderstandings can lead to problems. Clarify all your instructions. Tonight: Get organised.

♓

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): This is a tricky day for romance. You or your partner might over idealize something. You might be disappointed because of unexpressed expectations. Perhaps there's a plain old misunderstanding. Stay positive. Tonight: Socialise.

BENGALURU METROPOLITAN TRANSPORT CORPORATION Central Office: Stores & Purchase Department, K.H. Road, Shanthinagar, Bengaluru-560 027 No: BMTC/CO/COSP/TENDER/11/2026-27 Date: 04.09.2026				
NOTICE INVITING TENDER				
B.M.T.C. invites tender for procurement of the following Goods & Services through KPP Portal:				
Sl. No.	Tender No.	Description	Tender Value Rs. in Crores (approx)	Last Date for Bid Submission in KPPP
Short-Term Tender				
1	BMTC/2026-27/IND0334	Procurement of Volvo Electrical Spares.	0.59	12.09.2026 at 13:30 hrs.
2	BMTC/2026-27/IND0340	Procurement of Automotive Glasses.	1.10	12.09.2026 at 13:30 hrs.
Regular Tender				
3	BMTC/2026-27/IND0333	Cold Applied Self Adhesive Polymer Modified Bituminous Composite Membrane with aluminium foil at the top. Plastic Felt 20 Mtrs Length x 1 Mtr width.	0.90	22.09.2026 at 17:00 hrs.
4	BMTC/2026-27/IND0335	Procurement of cartridges for Kyocera printers.	0.25	22.09.2026 at 17:00 hrs.
5	BMTC/2026-27/IND0336	Procurement of Reflective Tapes & Transparent sheets.	0.35	22.09.2026 at 17:00 hrs.
6	BMTC/2026-27/IND0337	Procurement of Aluminium Extrusions.	0.40	22.09.2026 at 17:00 hrs.
7	BMTC/2026-27/IND0338	Procurement of Liquid Urea (AUS-32).	4.45	05.10.2026 at 17:00 hrs.
8	BMTC/2026-27/IND0339	Procurement of Radium Stickers of different colours.	0.25	22.09.2026 at 17:00 hrs.
9	BMTC/2026-27/IND0341	Procurement of Polyurethane Sealant.	0.99	22.09.2026 at 17:00 hrs.
10	BMTC/2026-27/IND0342	Procurement of Metal Paste & Araldite.	0.21	22.09.2026 at 17:00 hrs..
11	BMTC/2026-27/IND0343	Procurement of Different types of Rear view and side view mirrors	0.50	22.09.2026 at 17:00 hrs.
12	BMTC/2026-27/IND0344	Procurement of Phenol Bonded Densified Laminated Compressed Wooden Floor Boards.	0.47	22.09.2026 at 17:00 hrs.
13	BMTC/2026-27/IND0345	Procurement of Commercial plywood.	0.07	22.09.2026 at 17:00 hrs.
14	BMTC/2026-27/IND0346	Procurement of Automotive Lubricants for BSIII & BSIV Vehicles.	2.20	05.10.2026 at 17:00 hrs.
15	BMTC/2026-27/IND0347	Procurement of Automotive Lubricants for BSVI Vehicles.	1.40	22.09.2026 at 17:00 hrs.
16	BMTC/2026-27/SE1437	Standard Fire & Perils Insurance coverage for BMTC Workshops (CWS-1,CWS-2,CWS-3, CWS-4 & Central Stores).	0.02	22.09.2026 at 17:00 hrs.
Corrigendum: The last date & time for submission of following tenders in KPP portal is extended as under.				
17	BMTC/2026-27/IND0295	Procurement of Ball & Roller Bearings.	7.80	22.09.2026 at 17:00 hrs.
18	BMTC/2026-27/IND0312	Procurement of Desktop computers	0.80	22.09.2026 at 17:00 hrs.
19	BMTC/2026-27/SE1425	Engaging an Agency for Operating the canteen at the training centre, BMTC Vaddarahalli.	1.02	22.09.2026 at 17:00 hrs.
20	BMTC/2026-27/IND0323	Procurement of Dashboard Instruments.	0.67	22.09.2026 at 17:00 hrs.
21	BMTC/2026-27/IND0317	Procurement of Body Worn Camera.	0.15	22.09.2026 at 17:00 hrs.
22	BMTC/2026-27/IND0331	Installation of Automated Passenger Counting (APC) equipment.	0.40	22.09.2026 at 17:00 hrs.
23	BMTC/2026-27/IND0332	Installation of Advanced Driver Assistance system (ADAS)	0.45	22.09.2026 at 17:00 hrs.

The above mentioned tender details can be obtained from <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>. Further, any addendum/corrigendum in respect of change in calendar of events, specification, other tender terms and conditions etc. will be uploaded/published through KPP Portal only. Note: Interested Bidders need to register in the KPP Portal. For further information visit BMTC Central Office or Log on to <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>

Sd/- CONTROLLER OF STORES & PURCHASES (Tender Inviting Authority)

Hesson says he had no role in move to drop Pak players



Mike Hesson insists it was not his call to send players home. FILE

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 4

PAKISTAN'S INTERIM red-ball head coach Mike Hesson has said that senior players Muhammad Rizwan, Imam-ul-Haq and Salman Ali Agha had already been sent back home by the management when he had been given the role and so it wasn't his call. He said that he instead had a role to play in the replacements that were made after the Pakistan Cricket Board (PCB) sent back seven players from England after the heavy defeats suffered in the first two Tests of their tour of the country.

Apart from the release of players, PCB also sacked Sarfraz Ahmed as head coach of the side and brought in Hesson, who was head coach of the limited-overs setup.

"Look when they (Pakistan Cricket Board) told me if I could manage the side for the final Test, these three players (Rizwan, Agha and Imam) were already released from the squad and (were) on their way home. So, I really don't know what happened there," Hesson told a media conference in Birmingham.

"We already had a white-ball camp in Lahore and I had just returned from Japan where the Asian Games are taking place, when I was asked if I could manage the red-ball squad," he added.

"I decided to make some changes in the squad to get balance and my emphasis has been on having a bowling attack which has variety and where we have a couple of bowling all-rounders," he said.

Pakistan's management has been widely criticised for the way it has handled the players. There was particular surprise at Agha being dropped as he was captain of the team in the first Test.

Hesson said that while the last couple of days have been difficult, he is happy with how the team has responded to the changes.

"The last couple of days have been challenging for being in a hotel with some players coming, some players going and then the arrival of everyone," said Hesson.

"The guys are probably more used to a little bit of chaos than I am," he said. "There's no doubt they have been disappointed, incredibly disappointed. We've had to park that and go 'righto, where to from here?' They've been really good over the past couple of days."

WOMEN'S ASIA CUP

Hundred by hundred, Smriti charts her path to greatness

Transformation into highest run-getter is built on a two-year glut of centuries

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, September 4

FOR MORE than a decade into her career, hundreds didn't arrive as frequently to Smriti Mandhana as the quality of her batting suggested they should.

There were plenty of starts and fifties across countries and formats, enough to establish her among the best batters of her generation. But converting those innings into hundreds remained an area for improvement.

The last two years have changed that. Mandhana's 124 from 64 balls against Hong Kong in the Women's Asia Cup in Dubai on Thursday was her 18th international century, taking her past Meg Lanning for the most hundreds in women's international cricket.

During the same innings, she also went past Mithali Raj's 10868 runs to become the highest run-scorer in women's international cricket. Mandhana now has 10880. It was also the highest individual score in Women's T20 Asia Cup history, surpassing Chamari Athapaththu's unbeaten 119 against Malaysia in 2024.

The two records coming on the same evening captured two different parts of her career: the consistency that took her past Raj and the improved conversion rate that carried her beyond Lanning. Mandhana made her international debut, aged 16, in 2013. Her first ODI hundred came three years later, a 102 against Australia in Hobart. Hundreds followed against West Indies in 2017, South Africa in 2018, New Zealand in 2019 and West Indies again in 2022.

But they remained occasional landmarks. Through the end of 2023, Mandhana



With her century against Hong Kong, Smriti Mandhana became the highest run-getter in women's international cricket. BCCI/X

had five ODI hundreds and 26 fifties. Of the 31 occasions on which she reached 50, only five were centuries - a conversion rate of 16.1 percent.

Then came a transformation. Mandhana had never scored more than one ODI hundred in a calendar year before 2024. She made four that year - 117 and 136 against South Africa, 100 against New Zealand and 105 against Australia. A batter who had spent years getting off to starts was now beginning to make them count.

Mandhana followed those four hundreds with five more in 2025, when she made 1362 ODI runs. The left-hander made nine ODI hundreds in those two years, almost twice as many as she had managed across the first 11 years of her international career combined.

Across 2024 and 2025, nine of Mandhana's 17 fifty-plus scores became hundreds - a conversion rate of 52.9 percent, more than three times her rate through 2023. Her overall ODI record now stands at 14 hundreds and 35 fifties.

• Number Plate

52.9%

• Across 2024 and 2025, Smriti Mandhana has converted 9 of her 17 fifty-plus scores into centuries giving her a conversion rate of 52.9%. That is more than three times the rate she managed through 2023.

The change is perhaps even more apparent in T20Is. Until the end of 2024, Mandhana had played T20Is for nearly 12 years and accumulated 30 half-centuries without reaching three figures. She had come close — 87 against Ireland in 2023 and 86 against New Zealand in 2019 — but a hundred kept eluding her.

That wait ended against England at Nottingham in June 2025, when she made 112 from 62 balls. A little over a year later, the 124 against Hong Kong became her second.

The way the latest hundred came also showed

how her game has evolved. Mandhana hit 14 fours and seven sixes and reached three figures from 57 deliveries. She struck three successive sixes in the 18th over, during which she went past Raj's career aggregate.

India were playing Hong Kong for the first time, and Mandhana said the lack of familiarity with their bowlers meant they had to adapt in the middle, instead of relying on pre-match footage.

"We had seen a few videos, but not really aware. We're playing them for the first time, so when you come against a bowler who you don't know a lot, you have to just forget that you've played whatever cricket. You just have to go, watch the ball," Mandhana said after winning Player of the Match.

Better strike rate

Her scoring rate has risen alongside her improved conversion rate. After striking at 126.53 in T20Is in 2024, Mandhana went at 135.85 in 2025. In 2026, she scored 579 runs at a strike rate of 145.84.

For Mandhana, overtaking Raj and Lanning was significant. "Two of the legends of women's cricket, Meg Lanning and Mithali Raj. Genuinely, these are the two people who I have grown up watching a lot, watched a lot of their cricket, and tried to take a lot of things from them as batters," she said in the post-match press conference.

At 30, Mandhana has gone from a teenage prodigy to an established international opener and one of the most consistent run-scorers in the women's game. What has changed in the latest phase is what happens after she gets in. She has turned fifties into hundreds, while the runs have come quicker.

The combination has taken Mandhana from chasing the records of Raj and Lanning to owning two of the biggest records in women's batting herself.

And Mandhana's own assessment suggested she does not consider Thursday's achievements as an endpoint. "It's just a start," she said.

Despite unequal rivalry, India-Pakistan match could raise temperature



Deepthi Sharma has maintained an economy rate of 2.16 so far. CREIMAS

Shuvaditya Bose
New Delhi, September 4

THE BUCK stops with this.

In its tenth iteration, the Women's Asia Cup has garnered lukewarm response. The usual suspects have made the gulf between the field's strongest and weakest sides more apparent than ever before. No David has come remotely close to troubling a Goliath. Records have fallen — Smriti Mandhana alone set a clutch of them on Thursday — but there has barely been anyone around to witness it.

Into this setting walks the tournament's most anticipated fixture — India versus Pakistan. Per comparative analysis, this is unlikely to be a closely fought contest. In the last ten years, Pakistan have beaten India only once across formats. Their T20I win percentage is 17.65%. They have never won the Asia Cup either — Bangladesh have that distinction, and Sri Lanka, of course, are the defending champions.

But rivalry pays little heed to cricketing logic. It is, perhaps, for this reason that barely had the Indian team stepped foot in Dubai that head coach Amol Muzumdar was asked whether his players will shake hands with their Pakistani counterparts. Or why, after a match-winning half-century against Thailand, six of the ten questions put to Muneeba Ali in her post-match press conference were about the India fixture.

The players have embraced it too. On the eve of the match, Deepthi Sharma made no attempt to play down India's superiority. "Be it at the Asia Cup or in other tournaments, we have always been a step ahead of them," she said. The all-rounder has been in fine fettle with the ball. In two matches, be it against much lower ranked teams, Thailand and Hong Kong, she has taken six wickets — only three shy of the total runs she has conceded.

Successful teams tend to feature spinners hunting in pairs. In the Indian team, though, they do so in triads. Sree Charani has returned figures of 4 for 26, while Prema Rawat — who had played only a single international fixture before this competition — has chipped in with two wickets at an economy of 3.28.

"Charani is an exceptional

Deepthi has been in fine fettle with the ball. In two matches she has taken six wickets — only three shy of the total runs she has conceded

talent. She has done really well for India in the past one year. As for Prema, she has hardly played for India but whenever the team needs her, she is ready to give breakthroughs," Deepthi had said about the trio.

Grim portrait

India's batting, though, tells a thinner story beyond the opening pair of Smriti Mandhana and Shafali Verma, who have accounted for 66.8% of the side's total runs in the competition so far.

In that vein, Pakistan's story is along similar lines. They have scored over 130 only twice in their last ten T20Is, and could only manage 111/9 against Thailand. In that same period, though, they have taken 59 wickets at 21.35 and 7.34. Bar against the Netherlands, Pakistan lost all of their matches in the 2026 T20 World Cup, and yet, captain Fatima Sana was the joint second-highest wicket-taker. In comparison, their leading run-scorer, Muneeba ranked a distant 29th on the leaderboard.

"We will strategise differently for the match against India. It was a bit difficult to adjust to the conditions in our first game, but we will do better against them," Ali had said after beating Thailand. Whether they have the tools, or the tactical nous necessary to do better, will be known in a few hours. History offers little encouragement — there has been barely a contest between the two sides in the last five meetings across formats. And yet, because it is a match between neighbours, because eleven figures donned in blue will face an equal share clad in green, and because it is India vs Pakistan, it could still turn into a heated affair.

If not cricketing metaphorically, literally, at least — Saturday's 'real feel' temperature in Dubai is expected to touch 46°C.

WOMEN'S T20 ASIA CUP: INDIA VS PAKISTAN, live from 8 pm on Sony Sports Network and Sony LIV.

Ahead of Asian Games, India to play T20I against Japan

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 4

INDIA WILL face Japan in a T20I on September 22, 2026, the Board of Control for Cricket in India and the Japan Cricket Association said in a joint statement on Friday. The match will be played for the Suzuki Cup at the Sano International Cricket Ground in Tochigi Prefecture and will start at 9.30am IST.

The two boards stated that the match will be the first step of "Sport 75", an initiative that stems from an agreement reached during a summit between Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi and In-



This will be India's first international meeting with Japan. CREIMAS

dian Prime Minister Narendra Modi and aims to promote human exchanges and cooperation between India and Japan in the field of sports,

"taking note of India's ambition to host the Olympic and Paralympic Games in 2036".

This would be the first time that the two countries will face

The two boards stated that the match will be the first step of "Sport 75", an initiative that stems from an agreement between Japanese PM Sanae Takaichi and Indian PM Narendra Modi

each other in senior international cricket. While the bilateral one-off T20I will be between the two men's teams, the women's teams face each other in the 2026 Asian Games. The men's teams could face

each other again during the Asiad if Japan to get through the preliminary stage. Those matches will be played at the Korogi Sports Park in Nisshin, a city in the Aichi Prefecture which is situated to the south of Tochigi Prefecture.

"The BCCI is delighted to be part of this historic occasion as the Indian and Japanese men's teams come together for a special T20 International in Japan. This is a significant moment for cricket, as it takes the Indian team to new territory and provides an opportunity to introduce the sport to a wider audience in Japan and East Asia," said BCCI Secretary Devajit Saikia.

• DULEEP TROPHY FINAL

Smaran channeling hunger for runs, perseverance to manifest India A call-up

Venkata Krishna B
Chennai, September 4

LAST RANJITrophy season, none tallied more than the 950 runs made by Karnataka's Ravichandran Smaran. With four centuries and three fifties which included a career best of 227 not out and a healthy average of 86.36, he was unfortunate not to make the India A cut for the tour of Sri Lanka. But a spot in the South Zone team for the Duleep Trophy was beyond doubt for the 23-year-old, who would be amongst the batsmen that they would be banking on in the final, starting at Chepauk on Sunday, against a strong East Zone side.

When Smaran talks there is no residue of disappointment of not making the India A side. Instead, during the off-season he speaks of developing an enormous appetite that has made him hungry to

breach the 1,000-run landmark in the next Ranji season. It is what the middle-order batsman mentions when asked about the tweaks he has made to his batting. "Actually worked more on enhancing my game to ensure that the 950 runs can become close to 1,000- 1,100 runs in the next season. Just hunger for more runs and keep scoring wherever you get that opportunity," he tells *The Indian Express*.

When Karnataka pressed the transition button, Smaran was amongst the young talents they put their faith in. His start to Ranji Trophy wasn't smooth, and the left-hander first made headlines at the Vijay Hazare before turning his eyes on Ranji. After making 516 in his maiden season, he nearly doubled it up last season, taking Karnataka to the final. A meticulous person on and off

the field, Smaran swears by the term "process", oozing maturity beyond his age. The clichés — taking one game at a time, keeping the basics simple, having a clear head — are what he says helps him do what he does at the crease.

But it is the drive to score bucketful of runs that sets Smaran apart. It is a habit he has picked up from age-group cricket. It is a mindset that is drilled into him since he started representing Karnataka at age-group levels. Growing up watching the all-conquering Karnataka side which included the likes of KL Rahul, Mayank Agarwal, Karun Nair, Devdutt Padikkal — who all had a habit of pilling consistent scores — has played a part too. It is the legacy that Smaran intends to carry forward.

"These guys have come into the Test team with a huge volume of runs. So looking at them growing up, dominating



Ravichandran Smaran (R) hopes consistent performances will help him break into the India A team as soon as possible. INSTAGRAM

the Ranji Trophy over the years gave me even more motivation to break into the Karnataka side and to replicate and carry forward the legacy. The priority right now is to break into the India A

team as soon as possible," he says.

"Watching the likes of KL and Dev (Padikkal) — he really put in the hard work for almost two years and then to come in and put up a performance, I

It was actually a new experience for me facing close to 145-150 kmph. You don't find a lot of bowlers who bowl at that pace in the domestic circuit. But obviously, it was a good experience for me and something that I have to practise and work on."

RAVICHANDRAN SMARAN, ON BATTING IN THE IPL

was so happy for him. So for me as well, that is the goal. I have seen them do it and get there, so that's why I want to get into the A team. And I feel that the only way of doing that is to score big volumes of

runs," Smaran adds.

Grinding it out

Through the course of the last two domestic seasons, beyond the runs that Smaran scored, he lists out the learning that has made him evolve as a cricketer. "To grind it out in the middle isn't easy. Whenever I'm going to bat, I have to put my team into a very good position at the end of day's play. And then the same continues on to the next day.

"I feel it's the grind out there in the middle that becomes very important. There are very good spells that are bowled during the course of the domestic season. You respect those spells, the conditions and situations, you learn a lot. There's always going to be a phase in the game where you're not going to get runs. How you manage to overcome that is important to get the big scores," he says.

At the IPL, Smaran is yet to find his feet, but it is also the transition he wants to make. From domestic cricket to IPL, facing the likes of Jofra Archer cranking it up to 145kmph needed a bit of learning, no matter how many such deliveries he faced off the bowling machine.

"It was actually a new experience for me facing close to 145-150 kmph. You don't find a lot of bowlers who bowl at that pace in the domestic circuit. But obviously, it was a good experience for me and something that I have to practise and work on.

"Because in the IPL, you will always find guys who bowl consistently at this pace. And you have to ensure that you're finding a way to tackle them and to actually put them off and take them on. I feel it's just a matter of time before you get adjusted to that pace and you can really take them on," he says.

Gasly stripped of Monaco GP podium spot, Hadjar is third



Pierre Gasly was one of several drivers given penalties at the Monaco Grand Prix in June over pit lane speeding. AP

Associated Press
Paris, September 4

ALPINE'S PIERRE Gasly has been stripped of his third place at the Monaco Grand Prix and Isack Hadjar reinstated to third position, the FIA's International Court of Appeal has ruled. Gasly was one of several drivers given penalties at the Monaco Grand Prix in June over pit lane speeding, but didn't serve them during the race and finished third on track, though he was then demoted by 10 seconds to seventh place because of the penalties.

Alpine won an initial appeal to have Gasly's penalties overturned, giving the team its first Formula 1 podium since 2024. In a decision issued Thursday and made public Friday ahead of the Italian Grand Prix, the ICA has now ruled that would mean judging him differently to other drivers who served penalties. McLaren's Oscar Piastri now moves up a place to fourth, with Racing Bulls' Liam Lawson and Arvid Lindblad fifth and sixth, and Gasly back in seventh.

'Unjustly punished'

Alpine expressed "disappointment and frustration with the outcome" and said it believed the team had been "unjustly punished."

McLaren welcomed a ruling it said provided "important clarity for teams." The dispute wasn't just about pit lane speeding, and no one accused Gasly of unsafe driving.

It focused instead on whether the whole penalty system used a wrong measurement for the length of the pit lane, in effect potentially making it appear as if drivers were going faster than they really were.

However, the ICA ruled that changing the benchmark just for Gasly wouldn't be fair.

"Selectively applying a different post-race parameter to Car 10 would mean that competitors who calibrated and competed against the common benchmark would be judged by one standard, while Car 10 would ultimately be judged by another," the ICA ruled.

The dispute has put a spotlight on FI's two most powerful management organizations. Formula One Management oversaw the timekeeping process which produced the speed measurements for the pit lane, while the FIA appointed the stewards who issued - and overturned - the penalties for Gasly.

GLOBAL CHESS LEAGUE

A square box Carlsen must tick

Arguably the greatest chess player has not been able to stamp his class in team competitions, including the Olympiad

Mayank Chaudhary
Bengaluru, September 4

MAGNUS CARLSEN has won it all in chess. Well, almost all.

For all his individual brilliance and unparalleled trophy cabinet, a major team title has remained conspicuously absent from his resume. Apart from a European Club Cup victory in 2023, Carlsen has little to show for his efforts in team competitions.

He has represented Norway at the Chess Olympiad eight times, but a gold medal has remained elusive. In fact, he has never even guided his country to a podium finish in any of those editions. His luck in the Global Chess League (GCL) has been no better. In the two seasons he played for Alpine APL Pipers, the team never came close to contending for the title. And as fate would have it, the year he skipped the event, Pipers went on to win it.

Now, the GCL is back for its fourth season in Bengaluru. And so is Carlsen, fueled by a desire to finally rewrite his history with team events.

The franchise-based GCL is often viewed as a relaxed affair for players, a welcome break from the relentless grind of the chess circuit, but Carlsen made it clear that he is not here for leisure. He means business.

When a light-hearted question was thrown at him about the golf course near the players' hotel, Carlsen was quick to cut through the pleasantries.

"I am focused on playing the tournament here. I am very excited to be back. Of course, I am a little bit surprised to be back, seeing as we had a couple of really frustrating years for the team... the two first years when I was playing, and of course when I was away... you know the story, the team won it all. So this time, I am just trying to do my best to not do any worse

than last year," he said at the pre-tournament press conference on Friday.

Carlsen did taste team success in 2023, winning the European Chess Club Cup with Oferspill Sjakklubb, where Indian GM Pranav Venkatesh played a crucial role. But he is under no illusion about his complicated relationship with team events.

"Team events have been a little bit of an up and down for me for many years. I think it's been better in recent years. I think the last couple of Olympiads that I played, I've at least performed decently in terms of my own performance, even if the team performance has been a little bit up and down. In terms of this competition specifically, the history so far is not with me, and I definitely want to change that," he said.

If any team can help Carlsen finally rewrite his team-event record, it has to be this year's stacked Alpine Pipers line-up. Carlsen will lead the team on the "Icon" board, with 2026 Candidates runner-up Anish Giri and Vidit Gujrathi occupying the "Superstar Men" boards. The "Superstar Women" section features multiple-time World Rapid Champion Koneru Humpy and 2025 Women's World Cup winner Divya Deshmukh, who is making her GCL debut.

On the "Prodigy" board, where matches are often decided, the Pipers have the talented Russian and former World Rapid Champion Volodar Murzin. Despite the absence of R Praggnanandhaa and Fabiano Caruana, the finalists at the recently concluded Grand Chess Tour, the Pipers have all the firepower at their disposal to successfully defend their title.

Turkish prodigy

The team most likely to challenge the Pipers' reign is



Magnus Carlsen (2nd from right) is back after missing the last season of the Global Chess League. GCL

Carlsen has represented Norway at the Chess Olympiad eight times, but a gold medal has remained elusive.

PBG Alaskan Knights. Like the Pipers, the Knights have no glaring weakness. Viswanathan Anand leads them on the top board, joined by the ever-reliable Arjun Erigaisi and the talk of the town, 15-year-old Turkish prodigy Yağız Kaan Erdoğan, whom Carlsen once called the best 14-year-old chess player the world has ever seen.

With Kateryna Lagno and Nino Batsiashvili guarding the women's board and the world's youngest GM Abhimanyu Mishra holding the Prodigy board, the Knights look quite dangerous. However, it's Triveni Continental Kings who have the formula for triumph. The most successful side in GCL history with two titles and a runner-up finish last season, they are once again hard to

overlook when discussing title contenders. Built under the steady leadership of Dutch coach Loek van Wely, the Kings have always come in with a low-profile team that delivers it big time. Alireza Firouzja and Wei Yi have been their biggest performers. Even though Firouzja has been a shadow of his former self in recent years, he has always stepped up for the GCL.

What makes the Kings extremely dangerous is the presence of Zhu Jiner and Alexandra Kosteniuk on the women's boards, and a strong Prodigy board in Pranav V. The only possible chink in their armour is the form of Aravindh Chithambaram, which the Kings would be hoping to address.

Led by star coach N Srinath, Fyers American Gambits could be the dark horse of the tournament. With World Championship challenger Javokhir Sindarov on the top board, and short-format specialists Daniil Dubov and Nihal Sarin in the mix, the Gambits have the firepower to unsettle any side. Norway Chess winner Bibisara Asaubayeva, one of the strongest women players on the circuit, only strengthens their title bid.

CHINA MASTERS

Satwik-Chirag dig deep to tame Danes in three-game thriller



Satwik-Chirag beat Denmark's Kim Astrup and Anders Skaarup Rasmussen 21-13, 16-21, 21-18 to enter the semis. BADMINTON PHOTO

Shivani Naik
Mumbai, September 4

SOMEWHERE IN the middle of the mid-set of the quarterfinals of the China Masters, Anders Skaarup Rasmussen sent a flick serve curving over the crouching Indians, bending their backs in defense.

Serve receiving is a singularly painful part of the game for the pair of Indian 6-up footers. But knowing how opponents lace serves with wicked bobbles, Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty have learnt to literally hunker down and get the rally going, negotiating the flat serves. But the Dane devilishly flicked one high.

What followed left the handful of clearly visible Chinese faces agape, followed by lingering smiles in appreciation of the Indian's venomous power.

Chirag went from 90° bent forward to ramrod straight, then arching back, with the smallest of back swings to the racquet and pulped the shuttle for a short smash with such a thwack in a split-second that the spectators sitting right behind him exhaled their awe. Thor with a Mjolnir with Hulk's anger-affirming issues.

The Danes needed reminding of the attack. The Indians lost that mid-set after a pumped-up Kim Astrup belted like a foamy beach at the net. But even after trailing 10-14 and 15-17, Satwik-Chirag calmly flipped the lead to eventually win 21-13, 16-21, 21-18.

Doubts over Satwik's shoulder swirl. It is a gobs-macking fact then that the Indians, at half fitness, continue to remain India's most consistent international shuttlers. They have a Tour title in Singapore, a final earlier, the Thomas Cup bronze and a World Championship quarter-final — all when Satwik is broken like Arnie's Terminator. They live on the edge, but don't put it past the stellar duo to thrive on the edge too. Astrup-Rasmussen learnt it, much to their visible annoyance.

Soon after 'that' angry-Shetty bhai-smash, Satwik showed the post-hyphen ice of the fire-n-ice combo. He defended with an effortless 'tweener, and his ground defense was quite remarkable on the day. But just to make a point of his capability that can't be boxed into a brute smash, he

played a deceptive drop - aimed at Astrup's toes. Badminton's version of a slow-yorker.

The Satwik-Chirag story is eons from being done. And it's because the duo can reinvent, unlearn, rage-fuel, slice and scythe every shot to moment-specific needs. A smash to the Danish hands, no matter how hard, would've been returned. So, Satwik teased with a drop.

The opener was straightforward - swords splicing the restless Danish returns. Then Astrup got very cute from the net, pushing a decider. Aggressive, angular, agitated and admonishing — daring the Indians with cross-flats.

From a 6-foot squat, the Indian defense looks awkward and laboured. But their hard work in responding to a provocative style of fast flats mixed with the Astrup-annoying glaze was bound to bear fruit. It kicked in at just the right time.

The Indian attack was deployed to push the Danes behind. And Satwik - when confident - can defend low, out of sheer stubborn, bloody-mindedness. The attack and smashes raining down brought the frowns on Danish faces, but they knew the Achilles' heel. Coach Tan and Manu Attri (and ultimately national coach Pullela Gopichand) will need to figure out ways to smooth out that backhand push defense the two play in a convoluted, snatchy way — with biomechanical alterations.

But Satwik had enough defensive audacity to drag them out of trouble, and Chirag was angry enough to go from 15-17 to 20-17 in the most intense gnashing attack they could conjure. Rasmussen couldn't dig out an Indian smash in the end, and the edgy rivalry (that's now 5-6 H2H for Indians) ended with a confidence-boosting win.

Srikanth loses

Kidambi Srikanth, back in a Super 750 quarter-final after a long time, could not get past Lee Cheuk Yau of Hong Kong as he lost 21-16, 21-16. Lee's speed was far too frenzied for Srikanth, who made a brief fight of things in the second, but had no answers to the relentless steadiness of the 30-year-old HK shutter, who hasn't lost to Srikanth in 4 matches over the last 8 years. It's a typical matchup that Srikanth finds annoying, with a mix of speed and sturdy defense.

Despite cannabis smell, Sabalenka breezes through

Reuters
New York, September 4

TWO-TIME defending champion Aryna Sabalenka continued her imposing run at the US Open with a composed 6-3, 6-4 victory over Kamilla Rakhimova in the third round on Friday, extending her bid for a fifth Grand Slam title.

Sabalenka had an unusual interruption during her third-round match, stopping play to alert the umpire to a strong smell of cannabis drifting onto Louis Armstrong Stadium court. Sabalenka, who had made a fast start to go 3-0 ahead against Uzbekistan's Kamilla Rakhimova, raised the issue during her second service game, pointing out the smell before play resumed.

"Someone is smoking

weed," top seed Sabalenka told umpire Eva Asderaki-Moore as she was serving 30-0 up. "Would you mind to ... because it's so strong."

The odour of cannabis has become a familiar — if unwelcome — feature at Flushing Meadows, with players complaining about the distraction in the past. While smoking is not permitted inside the grounds, recreational cannabis is legal for adults over 21 in New York and smoke from people in the surrounding Flushing Meadows-Corona Park can drift into the tennis complex and onto the courts. Sabalenka opened play on a sweltering morning at Flushing Meadows and wasted little time making her intentions clear, breaking early to seize control and never looking back as she wrapped up



Aryna Sabalenka is aiming for a fifth Grand Slam title. AP

the opening set. "It's the first time I play morning session and it's a full stadium I'm so grateful, it's a dream," a smiling Sabalenka said on court.

The world number one unleashed her trademark power from the start, firing down a dominant serving display with four aces and dropping just four

points on her first serve.

In the second set, Sabalenka found herself having to work harder for her holds as Rakhimova shook off the tension and made the top seed earn her way through her service games, while saving four break points of her own. But Sabalenka eventually found the opening she needed, producing a blistering return to earn the decisive break before serving out the victory. "She played incredible in the second set, push me so hard and motivate me to bring out my best," Sabalenka added.

Sabalenka, who has now won 16 straight matches at the U.S. Open, is seeking to become the first woman since Serena Williams, who won three straight titles from 2012 to 2014, to complete a hat-trick of U.S. Open crowns.

• ULTIMATE ENTERTAINER

Monfils has no Slam titles, but he leaves a legacy

Bhuvan Gupta
New Delhi, September 4

NO GRAND Slam final in 22 years. No win against a Big Three member — Roger Federer, Rafael Nadal and Novak Djokovic — at a major. Gael Monfils has hardly had stats by his side. He has had style, spunk and athletic pizzazz to be loved globally anyway.

World No. 14 Learner Tien faced Monfils in Montreal last month and queued up among fans for his autograph. Tien hoped to get to play against the 'Flying Frenchman' one more time. He got his wish in New York on Friday.

The American sped to a 6-3, 6-4, 6-3 victory over Monfils in 2 hours and 17 minutes. He said sorry afterwards for "dropshooting so much" in the 40-year-old's last US Open, and Grand Slam, outing. The apology perhaps was meant more for the crowd, who came out to watch Monfils' outrageously inventive stroke-making. Even at the fag end of his career, he has the



Frenchman Gael Monfils is a former World No. 6. AP

legs and wrist to deceive opponents and enthrall spectators; ask Dani Vallejo.

The Paraguayan was trailing Monfils two sets to one in the first round. At 0-1, 15-30 in the fourth set, he unleashed stinging crosscourt shots on both ends amid a laborious rally. Vallejo could be forgiven

for thinking he had won the rally, but 'Slider-Man' had other ideas.

Scampering across from his backhand, Monfils slapped a deep forehand at full stretch before springing off his feet to launch a sucker-punching winner while airborne. The shot evoked awe and delight in equal measure and a YouTube commenter aptly described it as "a slam dunk from the baseline". The cherry on top was winning the match on his 40th birthday, with fans singing 'Happy Birthday' during his on-court interview.

But in Round 2, Tien did not allow Monfils enough breathing space for his acrobatics. As a result, while "La Monf" still entertained his audience, he could not turn back the clock in terms of breathtaking shots.

"You always want to give a little bit more, you want to stay a little bit more," he told reporters. "I gave my absolute all, but Learner was a really tough one tonight."

Monfils, like Stan Wawrinka

who similarly ended his Grand Slam journey three days back, was unlucky to have his peak years coincide with those of Federer, Nadal, Djokovic and Andy Murray. Unlike Wawrinka, Monfils could not challenge the big guns at Slams. However, he still managed to carve his niche with a unique playing style that garnered 13 ATP titles — the last one coming at the age of 38.

As the sport got increasingly physical and players began relying on near-mechanic hitting muscle, the former world No. 6 kept up his commitment to viewers. He has repeatedly chosen the spectacular over the prudent, even if it means putting the point at stake. Tweeners, no-look drop shots and leaping overheads have been commonplace in his matches, bringing smiles on faces amid the rigmarole of elite sport. Djokovic has called him "one of the best athletes" he's ever seen; Naomi Osaka is inspired by the Black Frenchman's trailblazing efforts, plac-

ing him alongside the Williams sisters in that regard.

Not everyone is a fan though. Some believe Monfils failed to live up to potential, comparing his achievements with wife Elina Svitolina's. He has known better than to heed their opinions. "My wife looks super professional in a way and me, I don't look professional in a way. But that's not really the case because I have my work ethic. The only thing I want is for people to never forget that to succeed or whatever, you don't have to listen to other people," he told *The Guardian* in a 2024 interview.

Having opted for an unconventional approach to his tennis, Monfils has surprised one and all with his post-retirement plans too. He is taking up an office job in finance after hanging up his racquet at the end of the year. Monfils did not let others decide what he should or should not dream about in his playing days. He is not in the mood to change that after the sun sets.

• BRIEFLY



Marcos Llorente, 31, earned 27 caps for Spain. REUTERS

World Cup winner Llorente retires from internationals

WORLD CUP winner Marcos Llorente announced his retirement from international football ending a Spain career that yielded 27 caps. The Atletico Madrid defender, 31, made his senior team debut for Spain in 2020 and was part of the squad that beat Argentina 1-0 to win the World Cup in July, although

he remained on the bench in the final. He thanked his teammates and reflected on Spain's World Cup campaign. "I'll cherish everything I've experienced, but above all, these last 52 days," Llorente said. "With a wonderful group that fought until the very end to put Spain at the top." REUTERS

India vs Panama friendly advanced

INDIA'S INTERNATIONAL football friendly against Panama here has been advanced by a day from the scheduled September 26 as the Sree Kanteerava Stadium, the venue of the match, will host the Bengaluru Marathon on September 27. Since the Kanteerava Stadium will serve as the starting and finishing point of the marathon race, it will be difficult to host the India vs Panama football match the next day as per the earlier schedule, according to sources. The match will now be held on September 25. "We are now going to advance the India-Panama match by a day. It will now be held on September 25," a Karnataka State Football Association (KSFA) source told PTI. Panama, currently ranked 44th in the world, will provide India with a high-quality test. PTI